SuperResearcher

Global Migration 1826–2226: A 200-Year Forecast

Waves, drivers, crises, and control regimes — evidence, scenarios, and the limits of long-range forecasting

Organization SuperResearcher
Date 2026-11-03

Two centuries ago, movement between countries was a trickle constrained by sail, cost and coercion; today 304 million people live outside their country of birth, more than 123 million have been forcibly displaced, and the flows are managed — and mismanaged — by the most elaborate mobility architecture humanity has ever built. This report traces that transformation from 1826 to the present, then projects it forward to 2226. It examines how migration is counted and why the counts mislead; the regional systems that organise movement, from the Gulf's vast labour corridors to Europe's two-tier interior; the wage chasm between places that gives movement its enduring motive; the queues, camps and court backlogs through which protection is rationed; the borders where enforcement displaces pressure rather than relieving it; and the governance frameworks — twin global compacts, partnerships, regularisation programmes — through which states attempt, mostly unsuccessfully, to coordinate a phenomenon none of them controls alone. Its central finding is that the system runs on ratios its politics ignores. Migrants are a near-constant share of humanity even as their numbers set records; most movement is internal, most displacement is hosted by poor neighbours, and most climate-driven movement will stay within borders. Prosperity does not quickly stem emigration — it first finances it. Enforcement relocates flows into smuggling markets, transit-state leverage and years of legal limbo, while the outcomes that matter most are decided quietly by processing speed and legal status: how fast a claim is heard, how soon a newcomer may work, how secure their right to remain. Looking ahead, the report builds scenarios rather than forecasts for the two centuries to 2226, in which fertility paths, emissions trajectories and the choice between managed mobility and fortified closure matter more than any single policy. What endures across all of them is the underlying machinery — the premium on place, the rationing of admission, the institutional conversion of pressure into legal flow, irregular flow or trapped stillness. The societies that fare best, the evidence suggests, are those that design honestly for movement as a permanent condition rather than an emergency to be ended.

Two centuries of movement: the long history of migration

Major migration waves, 1826 to today

Two centuries of movement resolve, in the measurable record, into a paradox: the numbers keep setting records while the propensity barely moves. The latest UN Population Division estimates put the international migrant stock at a record 304 million in mid-2024 — about 3.7 per cent of the world's 8.2 billion people, "almost double the 153.9 million in 1990 and nearly four times the 77.1 million in 1960," the share having crept only from 2.6 per cent in 1960 to 3.5 per cent in 2020 [1]. The World Migration Report 2024 tells the same story on the previous vintage: from approximately 161 million migrants in 1995 to 281 million in 2020, the share rose "from 2.8 to 3.6 per cent of the global population," and "staying within one's country of birth overwhelmingly remains the norm" [2] [2]. Between 2020 and 2024 the stock grew 10.4 per cent, "roughly tripling the increase in the world's total population (3.5 per cent)" — migration accelerating, but from a base so broad that the world's mover share stays in the low single digits [1].

The cross-border record is also only the visible fraction. Internal migration dwarfs it: UNDP estimated 740 million internal migrants at the turn of the millennium — "three times the number of international migrants" — and Bell and Charles-Edwards put the 2005 figure at 763 million; China alone counted some 150 million rural-to-urban migrants in 2009 [3]. The Human Development Report 2009 makes the comparison stark: 136 million movers in China and 42 million in India mean "the totals for just these two countries approach the global stock of people who have crossed frontiers" [4]. Any history of migration waves is therefore mostly a history of movement inside states — industrialisation's rural exodus, China's urbanisation — with the international series capturing the minority of moves that happened to cross a line on the map.

What waves there are in the international record are often made by the lines moving rather than the people. Europe's contemporary corridors are "heavily influenced by two major political events: the dissolution of the Soviet Union and

two decades of regional integration in the European Union": the region's three largest pathways run among Kazakhstan, Ukraine and the Russian Federation, because "millions of population changes that were formerly internal Soviet migration have now become part of the story of international migration," while EU free-movement policy built the intra-European flows beside them [5]. The 2024 origin table still carries that imprint — Ukraine (9.8 million emigrants) and Russia (9.1 million) sit fourth and fifth worldwide, behind India (18.5 million, 6.1 per cent of all migrants), China (11.7 million) and Mexico (11.6 million) [1]. Europe and Northern America are simultaneously the largest destination regions and the source of about 22 per cent of all emigrants [1].

Composition has shifted by driver. Of the 258 million migrants counted in the late 2010s, 150.3 million were migrant workers, 124.8 million women and 36.1 million children, alongside 4.8 million international students and 25.4 million registered refugees [6]. Work dominates the corridors: South–South migration exceeds 90 million, South–North follows at about 85 million, and "more than 60 percent of international migrants (150 million people) are classified as migrant workers" [3]. Destinations concentrate steeply at the top of the development ladder: 79.6 per cent of international migrants (190 million) reside in very high HDI countries, and all of the top ten destination countries are very high HDI [2]. Within regions, the same concentration appears in miniature — intra-African migration grew from 12.5 million in 2000 to 19.4 million in 2017, its top destinations South Africa, Côte d'Ivoire and Nigeria [6]. Children show the geography plainly: Africa and Asia together host three of every five child migrants, while Europe hosts 18 per cent of child migrants against only 6 per cent of the world's children [5].

Superimposed on the labour system are the displacement pulses. The late-2010s stock figures carry 25.4 million refugees, 40 million internally displaced people and 3.1 million asylum seekers, the increase "particularly marked between 2012 and 2015, mostly due to the Syrian conflict" [6]. Irregular movement leaves a mortality ledger: of the 30,000 irregular migration deaths and disappearances IOM reported for 2014 to 2018, "over 17,000 took place in the Mediterranean" [6]. Flows, where measurable, keep re-weighting the map — flow estimates "have shifted a higher share of the world's international migrants toward Asia, highlighting the region's growing importance in global migration" [5], and inflows from Africa to Europe rose an estimated 15 per cent between 2014 and 2016 [6].

The two-century arc, read through these sources, is therefore not a story of a world suddenly on the move. It is a story of accumulation and reclassification: a migrant share of humanity that has hovered near 3 per cent while the absolute stock quadrupled with population; waves manufactured as often by new borders, dissolved empires and free-movement compacts as by new journeys; a labour-migration system anchored in the richest destinations; and periodic conflict-driven pulses that dominate the politics while remaining a minority of the movement. The waves are real. They are just smaller, steadier and more internal than the headlines of any single decade suggest.

Who moves: demographic composition of migrants over time

Migration is demographically selective before it is anything else: it draws disproportionately from the working ages, and it increasingly flows between populations at opposite ends of the demographic transition. The engine is visible in the Human Development Report 2009's accounting: between 1960 and 2010, of the additional 2.8 billion working-aged people in the world, "9 out of 10 were in developing countries," so labour abundance depressed origin wages while rising incomes moved poorer countries up the "migration hump," broadening the pool able to afford long-distance movement [4]. Falling costs widened the pool further — the real price of air travel fell by three fifths between 1970 and 2000, and a three-minute Australia–United Kingdom telephone call fell from about US$350 in 1926 to US$0.65 in 2000 and effectively to zero with internet telephony [4]. The movers these forces produce are consequently concentrated in the developed world even as aggregate shares stay stable — the HDR's summary of the post-1960 pattern: "a growing concentration of migrants in developed countries against a background of aggregate stability in overall migration," with growth in movement potential "constrained by increased policy barriers to movement, especially against the entry of low-skilled applicants" [4].

Age is the sharpest separator between migrant categories. Refugees are startlingly young: UNHCR's end-2024 estimates put children at 41 per cent of refugees and women and girls at 50 per cent, the age-sex pyramid running 21 per cent boys and 20 per cent girls under 18, 27 per cent each for working-age men and women, and only 2–3 per cent aged 60 or over [7]. Displacement now reproduces itself demographically — more than 2.3 million children were born as refugees between 2018 and 2024, "equivalent to some 337,800 children per year" [7]. UNICEF's 2015 comparison made the same contrast: "while a clear majority of the world's migrants are adults, children are roughly half of all refugees" [5]. Migrant age profiles vary systematically by destination region: median age 29 in Africa — pulled down by the region's high refugee share — 35 in Asia, 36 in Latin America and the Caribbean, and 42 or above in Europe, Northern America and Oceania [5]. Household composition carries the selectivity into outcomes: Uganda's el-

evated refugee poverty is linked in part to "the demographic composition of many households (with many working-age men having stayed behind)," while Poland's post-2022 Ukrainian caseload was child-heavy in a different way — about 185,000 refugee children enrolled in Polish schools by September 2022 [8].

Sex composition is near parity in displacement but strongly gendered in labour exploitation. Forced labour exploitation counts 11.3 million men against 6.0 million women, and sorts them by sector: domestic work makes up 17 per cent of women's forced labour but only 4 per cent of men's, while construction accounts for 22 per cent of men's and 6 per cent of women's [9]. Migrants are heavily over-represented in that population: 15 per cent of adults in forced labour are migrants, against roughly 5 per cent of the global labour force, and the prevalence rate for migrant workers — nearly 14 per thousand — is "more than three times higher than that of non-migrant workers (4.1 out of every thousand)" [9].

Over time, the composition question is being decided by ageing. In countries whose populations have already peaked, the number of people aged 65 or older is projected to reach 409 million by 2027, "surpassing the number of children under age 18," while the 80-plus population rises from 85 million in 2024 toward around 267 million by 2100 [10]. The OECD support ratio tells the demand side: from about 3 working-age people per person 65 or older in 2015, the median ratio is projected to erode to 1.8 by 2050 with zero net migration, and only 1.9 under the status quo; Japan, the frontier case at roughly 2.5 in 2010, responded in 2018 with a programme to bring in more than 300,000 workers over five years [11]. World Population Prospects 2024 is blunt about the limits: for 19 already-peaked countries including Germany, Japan, Italy, the Russian Federation and Thailand, populations "would have peaked earlier and at a lower level in the absence of immigration," yet "international migration alone… cannot offset population decline or population ageing in the long term" [10]. The mirror cost falls on origins: in French Polynesia and El Salvador, among the highest-emigration locations, the working-age population in 2054 "would have been more than 11 per cent higher without international migration" [10]. Meanwhile roughly 100 countries still have a rising working-age share through 2054 — the demographic-dividend window that supplies tomorrow's movers [10].

The long-run picture is thus a slow inversion. The twentieth century's migrants were selected by labour demand from young, growing populations and absorbed into young, growing destinations. The twenty-first century's are increasingly selected by age structure itself: children constitute two-fifths of the displaced, working-age adults are bid for by ageing states that migration cannot ultimately re-youth, and the median migrant is 29 where displacement dominates and over 42 where labour markets do. Who moves is no longer just who seeks work — it is whoever a demographically divided world is short of, or cannot protect.

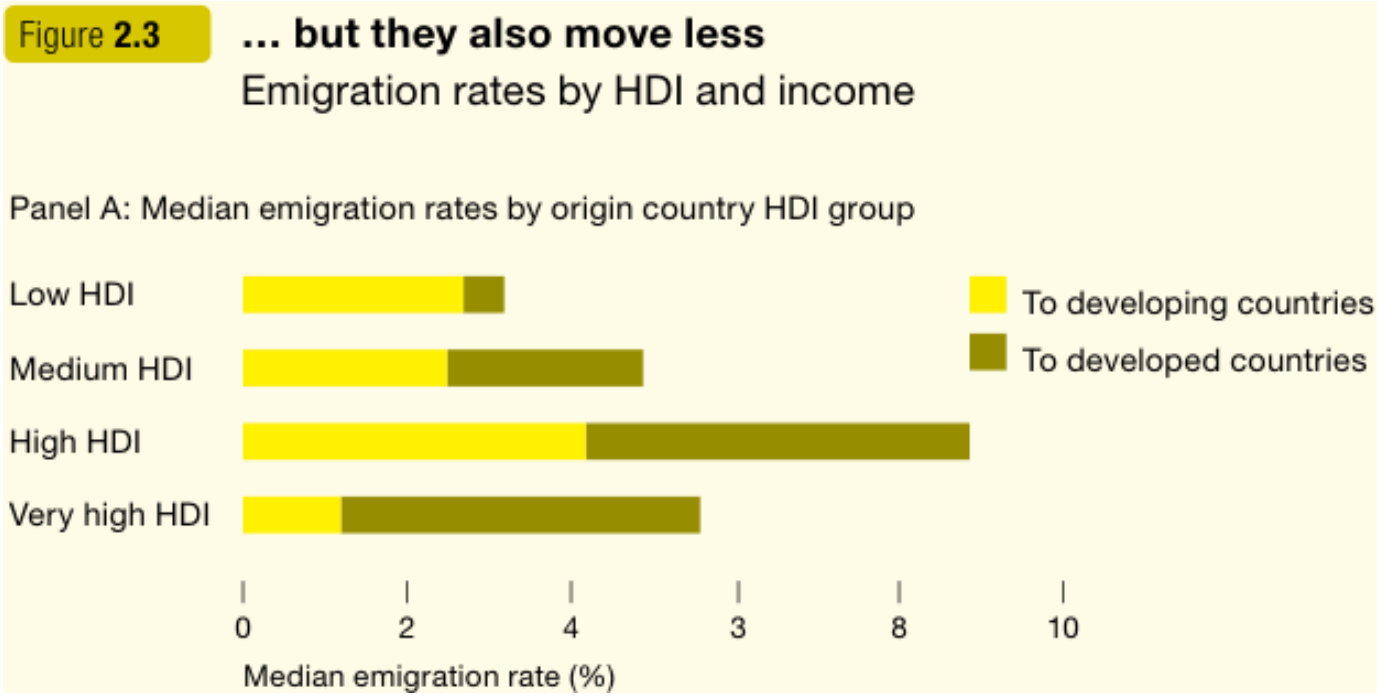


Exhibit. Median emigration rates grouped by origin countries' human development and income levels reveal that emigration is lowest where development is lowest, because the poorest populations face the steepest barriers to moving. Source: S0022.

Regional dimensions: Africa, the Americas, Europe, Asia-Pacific, Middle East and North Africa

The global system is not one system. It is a set of regional systems with different geometries, joined by a minority of long-haul corridors — because where people come from largely determines where they go. Movements "are mainly determined by the demands for skills in the labor markets of destination countries, historical and geographic links, and the costs of migration," with the result that most migrants from low-income countries move to other low- or middle-income countries, "often because the cost of migration to higher-income destinations is prohibitive" — even though, in 2020, about 84 per cent of migrants lived in a country richer than their origin, and over 80 per cent move in search of opportunity [8].

Europe runs a layered system. High-income European countries host about 43 million migrants, including 8 million refugees, drawn predominantly from elsewhere in Europe (56 per cent), then the Middle East and North Africa (13 per cent), Latin America (9 per cent), and Sub-Saharan Africa (8 per cent); the rest of Europe and Central Asia holds about 14 million immigrants moving mostly within the region along former-Soviet corridors, with a further 11 million of its people in high-income Europe [8]. The Americas split north–south. Within Latin America and the Caribbean some 10.7 million people have moved regionally — including 4.4 million who left Venezuela — while the region's emigrants go mainly to North America (about 60 per cent) and, far behind, the European Union (about 10 per cent); North America in turn counts about six times as many immigrants as emigrants, its intake 43 per cent Latin American and Caribbean, 21 per cent East Asian and Pacific, 16 per cent European and Central Asian, and 9 per cent South Asian, with high rates of eventual naturalisation [8].

The Middle East and North Africa is three systems at once: the Gulf Cooperation Council states absorb large labour inflows, mainly from South Asia (60 per cent); the rest of the region exports people — about 8 million to high-income Europe and 6 million to the GCC; and it hosts roughly 3.5 million refugees from the Syrian crisis and Iraqi insecurity within its own borders [8]. South Asia, demographically enormous, migrates less than its size suggests and in a distinctive pattern: about 19 million of its people have emigrated to the GCC and 15 million to other regions, chiefly North America and high-income Europe, while its sharpest internal movements are forced — from Afghanistan to Pakistan and from Myanmar to Bangladesh [8]. East Asia and the Pacific is the mirror image: immigration remains limited except in Australia and New Zealand, while emigration runs both within the region and out to North America and the Gulf [8].

Sub-Saharan Africa is the most intra-regional — and the most displacement-weighted — of the systems. Most of its movement stays within the region, along corridors such as Burkina Faso to Côte d'Ivoire and toward the economic poles of Nigeria and South Africa; of the approximately 22 million Africans living outside their country, about 35 per cent are refugees, fed by outflows from South Sudan, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Sudan, Somalia, and the Central African Republic, while about 10.3 million have emigrated beyond the region to the EU, the United Kingdom, and the United States [8]. The financial plumbing traces the same regional shapes: remittances to low- and middle-income countries reached $656 billion in 2023 — still "the premier source of external finance for LMICs..., surpassing foreign direct investment (FDI) and official development assistance" — with the largest regional flows to South Asia ($186 billion) and East Asia and the Pacific ($134 billion), dependence peaking in small economies such as Tonga, where remittances amount to 41 per cent of GDP, and sending costs averaging highest to Sub-Saharan Africa at 7.9 per cent of a $200 transfer [12]. The regional lesson for everything that follows is that "global" migration policy is mostly written for the long-haul minority; the typical move is to a neighbouring labour market, a regional pole, or a nearby refuge.

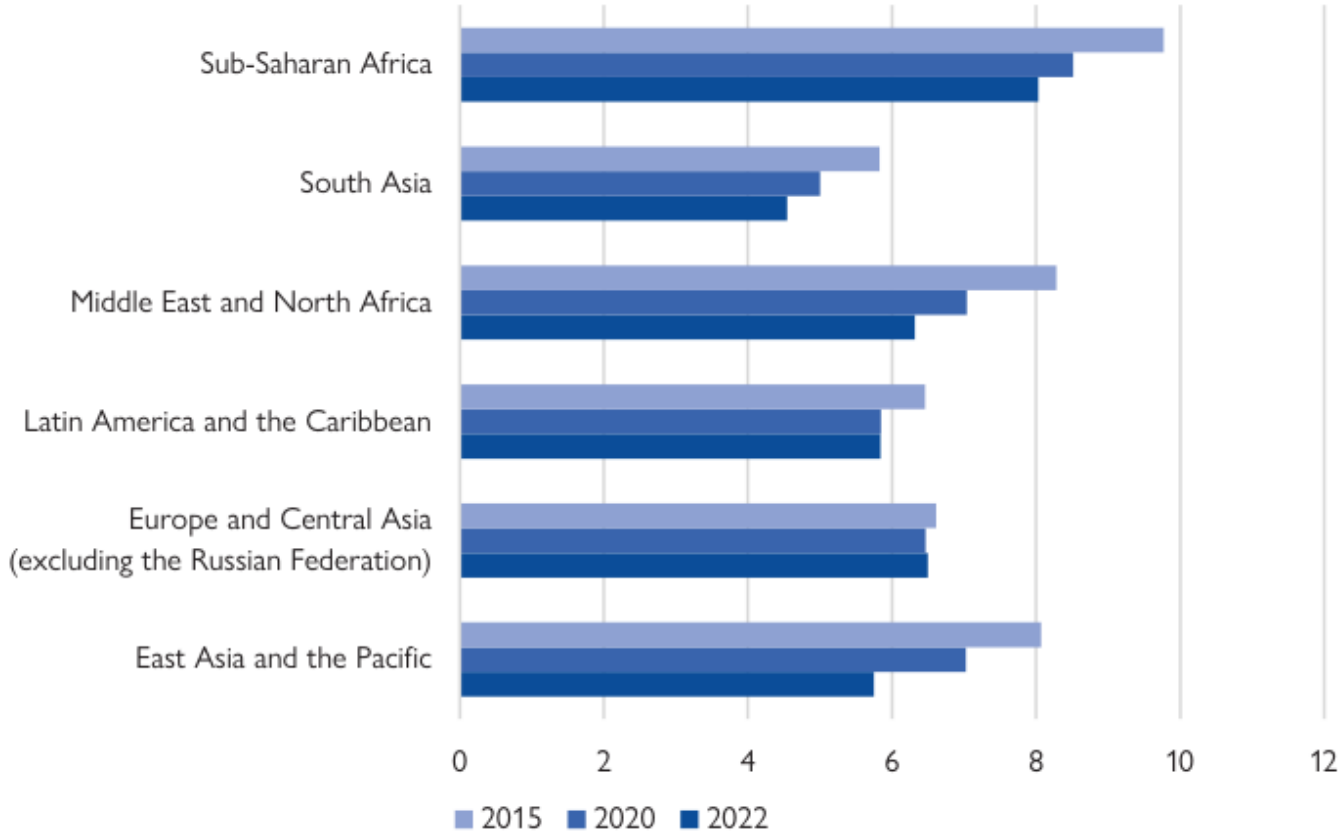


Exhibit. Figure 12. Average cost of sending USD 200 by region of the world, 2015–2022 (%). Source: S0001.

How many international migrants are there, now and historically?

The honest answer begins with the counting rule, because the number is an artefact of it. Statistically, an international migrant is a person who has crossed an international border, changed their country of residence, and stayed — "usually of 12 months" is the threshold — with no reference to reason or legal status; the stock counts such persons at a point in time, identified by country of birth where data allow, "because such data reflect a change in the country of residence more accurately than do data on country of citizenship" [13]. Every headline figure that follows is that definition, applied as consistently as 233 countries' censuses, registers and surveys permit.

By that rule: "In 2024 the number of international migrants worldwide stood at 304 million, a figure that has nearly doubled since 1990, when there were an estimated 154 million international migrants globally" — while the share of humanity barely moved, "in 2024 just 3.7 per cent of people globally were international migrants, having increased only modestly from 2.9 per cent in 1990" [13]. The doubling is real but it is population growth's shadow: the migrant stock grew roughly with the species, not faster than it in proportional terms.

The geography of the 2024 stock is concentrated and lopsided. "Europe hosted more international migrants than any other region with 94 million in 2024," followed by Northern America with 61 million and Northern Africa and Western Asia with 54 million [13]. Europe also grew fastest, adding 43 million between 1990 and 2024, its pace increasing since 2020 "due largely to refugee flows from Ukraine"; Northern America added 34 million but its growth decelerated — under 1 per cent a year in 2020–2024 against 3.8 per cent in the 1990s and 2.3 per cent in the 2000s [13]. Measured as a share of residents, the extremes invert the raw counts: Oceania, with only 46 million people, was 21 per cent international migrants; Northern America 16 per cent of 385 million residents; Europe 13 per cent of 745 million — while Central and Southern Asia and Eastern and South-Eastern Asia, "home to more than half of the world's eight billion people," counted migrants at less than one per cent of their populations [13]. The world's majority lives where the migrant stock is thinnest.

Composition adds a further check on the feminisation shorthand: "just under half (48 per cent) of all international migrants worldwide were women or girls" in 2024, their share "essentially unchanged between 1990 and 2024" in Europe, Northern America and Latin America and the Caribbean, while globally "the number of male migrants has grown more rapidly than has the number of female migrants, driven mainly by the large influx of male migrant workers to Northern Africa and Western Asia" [13]. The stock is also not a clean count of volunteers: UN DESA's series car-

ries refugees, asylum seekers and others in need of international protection inside the migrant total, tracked as a share alongside it [13].

Historically, the count's depth is methodological before it is demographic. The 2024 edition of the International Migrant Stock covers 1990–2024 and rests on uneven foundations: 60 countries and areas received "a full reassessment" for 2024 — those with new census or register data, large migrant populations, or ongoing refugee flows — while "for the remaining countries and areas, the estimates generated in 2024 reflect extrapolations of estimates published in the 2020 edition" [13]. Even the recent past is partly modelled: since 2010, only 87 per cent of the 233 destinations (201) have at least one empirical source on total migrant numbers, 71 per cent on the distribution by sex, and 76 per cent on country of origin [13]. Numbers before 1990 come from patchier instruments still, which is why the long-run history in this report is told through the waves and systems of the sources that measured their own eras.

A mid-2010s snapshot shows what such era-specific counting reveals beneath the global line. In the Americas in 2015, "four out of five migrants from the Americas move within the region" — 33 million intra-continental movers, "the third largest population movement in the world (following intra-Asian and intra-European movements)" — with just over 7 million having left for other regions, 80 per cent of the leavers in Europe; the region simultaneously hosted more than 27 million migrants from elsewhere, over half from Asia and a third from Europe [5]. The same snapshot counts 6.3 million child migrants in the Americas — 21 per cent of the global total of migrant children — with children forming 43 per cent of all migrants living in Central America against 8 per cent in Northern America, and four out of five of the region's child migrants concentrated in the United States, Mexico and Canada [5].

So the count, stated precisely: 304 million people in 2024, 3.7 per cent of humanity, nearly double the 1990 stock at nearly the same share — a number assembled from a 12-month residence rule, birth-country identification, 60 fresh national reassessments, extrapolation for the rest, and refugees counted inside the total. It is the best single figure the system produces, and this report treats it accordingly: solid enough to build on, constructed enough to argue with.

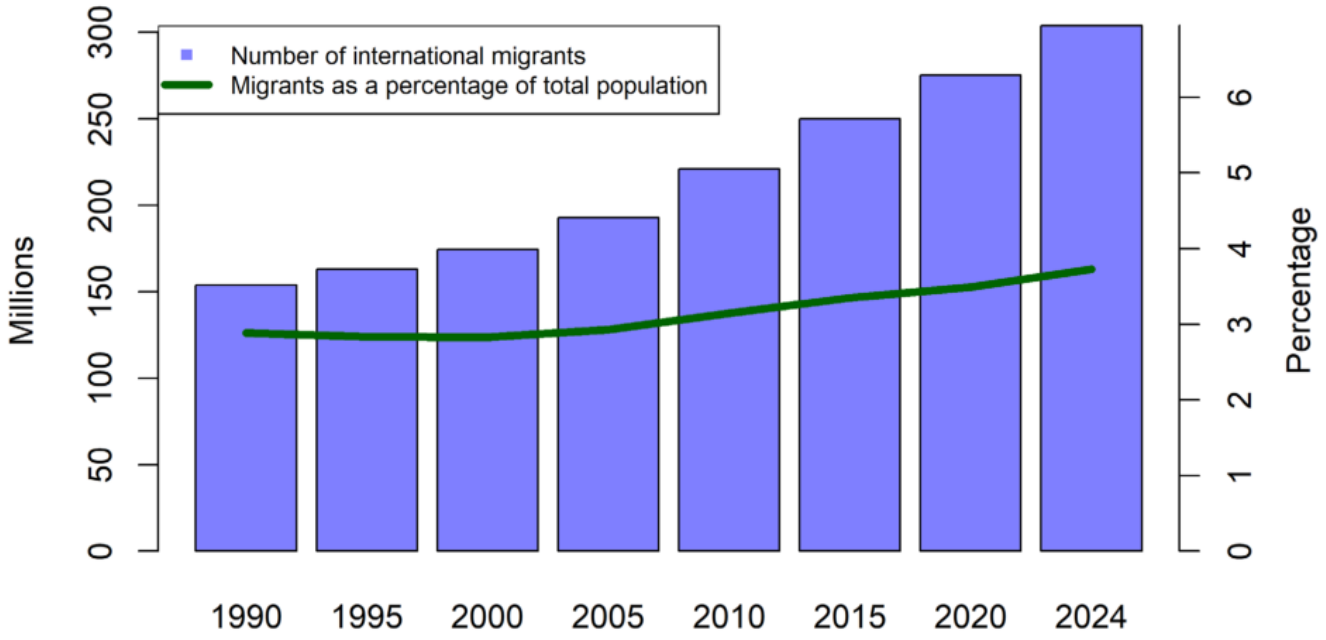


Exhibit. Number of international migrants worldwide and as a share of the global population, 1990-2024 Data source : United Nations (2025). Source: S0009.

Drivers of migration

Demographic trends: aging destinations, youthful origins

The previous sections counted the movers; this one counts the pressure differential that moves them. Population ageing is "a global phenomenon driven by the decline in fertility rates and the continuing improvement in survival to

older ages" — but it is proceeding at radically different speeds at the two ends of the migration system, and the gradient between an ageing destination world and a youthful origin world is now the deepest structural driver the system has [10].

First, a measurement caution, because the size of the "ageing problem" depends on the ruler. The World Population Prospects distinguishes three families of indicators: structural measures (the share aged 65+, median age, the ratio of older persons to the population aged 20–64 — "simple to compute and easily comparable across time and space"); prospective and economic ratios that account for remaining life expectancy and for the fact that "not all people stop working at age 65," at the cost of heavier data demands; and health-based measures such as disability-adjusted life years and healthy life expectancy, which capture the heterogeneity of older populations but are limited by data availability [10]. The headline dependency story is told with the first ruler; the second and third soften it without reversing it.

With that caveat, the destination end of the system is ageing past landmarks. In the countries whose populations have already peaked, "in 2054, older persons could comprise one third or more of the population in 16 of these locations, with Hong Kong, SAR of China, and the Republic of Korea recording some of the highest values," and the oldest-old are the fastest-growing stratum of all — in this country group, the population aged 80 or older already exceeded the number of infants in 2024 [10]. For nearly all of these countries "the time-bound window of opportunity for accelerated economic growth associated with a youthful population and declining fertility has already closed" [10]. WPP's policy menu for the peaked world is mostly non-migratory — healthcare and long-term-care systems, sustainable social protection, automation and productivity technology, lifelong learning, and bringing excluded groups (women, older persons, persons with disabilities) into the formal labour market — with immigration assigned a bounded role: it "can also help alleviate labour force shortages associated with population ageing, at least in the short term," and for some 19 countries it demonstrably delayed and raised the peak, but "international migration alone, however, cannot offset population decline or population ageing in the long term" against what is "ultimately a universal and irreversible process: the demographic transition" [10].

The origin end runs the other way, and the Human Development Report 2009's forecasts — now the baseline the newer data revise — state the asymmetry in its starkest form. World population grows by a third over four decades, "virtually all of this growth will be in developing countries"; in one in five countries, "including Germany, Japan, the Republic of Korea and the Russian Federation," populations shrink, while one in six countries — "all of them developing and all but three of them in Africa" — more than double [4]. "Were it not for migration, the population of developed countries would peak in 2020 and fall by 7 percent in the following three decades," and the half-century trend of Europe's population share falling and Africa's rising continues [4]. By 2050 "the world as a whole and every continent except Africa are projected to have more elderly people (at least 60 years of age) than children (below 15)," the average age reaching 38 in developing countries against 45 in developed ones — and the labour arithmetic is the migration system's fuel line: "the global working-age population is expected to increase by 1.1 billion by 2050, whereas the working-age population in developed countries, even assuming a continuation of current migration flows, will decline slightly," with new labour-force entrants in developing countries over the next 15 years exceeding "the total number of working-age people currently living in developed countries" [4].

Whether the youthful end's bulge becomes a dividend or a pressure cooker is a policy variable, and the Groundswell analysis ties it directly to mobility: "good management of demographic transitions and investment in human capital can also reduce climate vulnerability," the dividend arising when smaller dependent cohorts meet larger working-age ones — Bangladesh and Mexico cited as positioned to benefit, with girls' education singled out as reducing climate risk — while Ethiopia, facing "a population increase of up to 85 percent by 2050" alongside falling agricultural productivity, "will need to absorb labor and a large youth bulge into non-agricultural and less climate-sensitive sectors" [3]. Bangladesh's shift into manufacturing is already absorbing migrants into less climate-sensitive work [3]. The demographic map, in short, is a pressure map: destinations short of workers and long on retirees, origins long on young workers and short of jobs that can hold them — and, as the support-ratio analysis in the demographics chapter showed, migration is the only mechanism that moves people from the surplus side of that equation to the deficit side, even if it can soften the gradient but never level it.

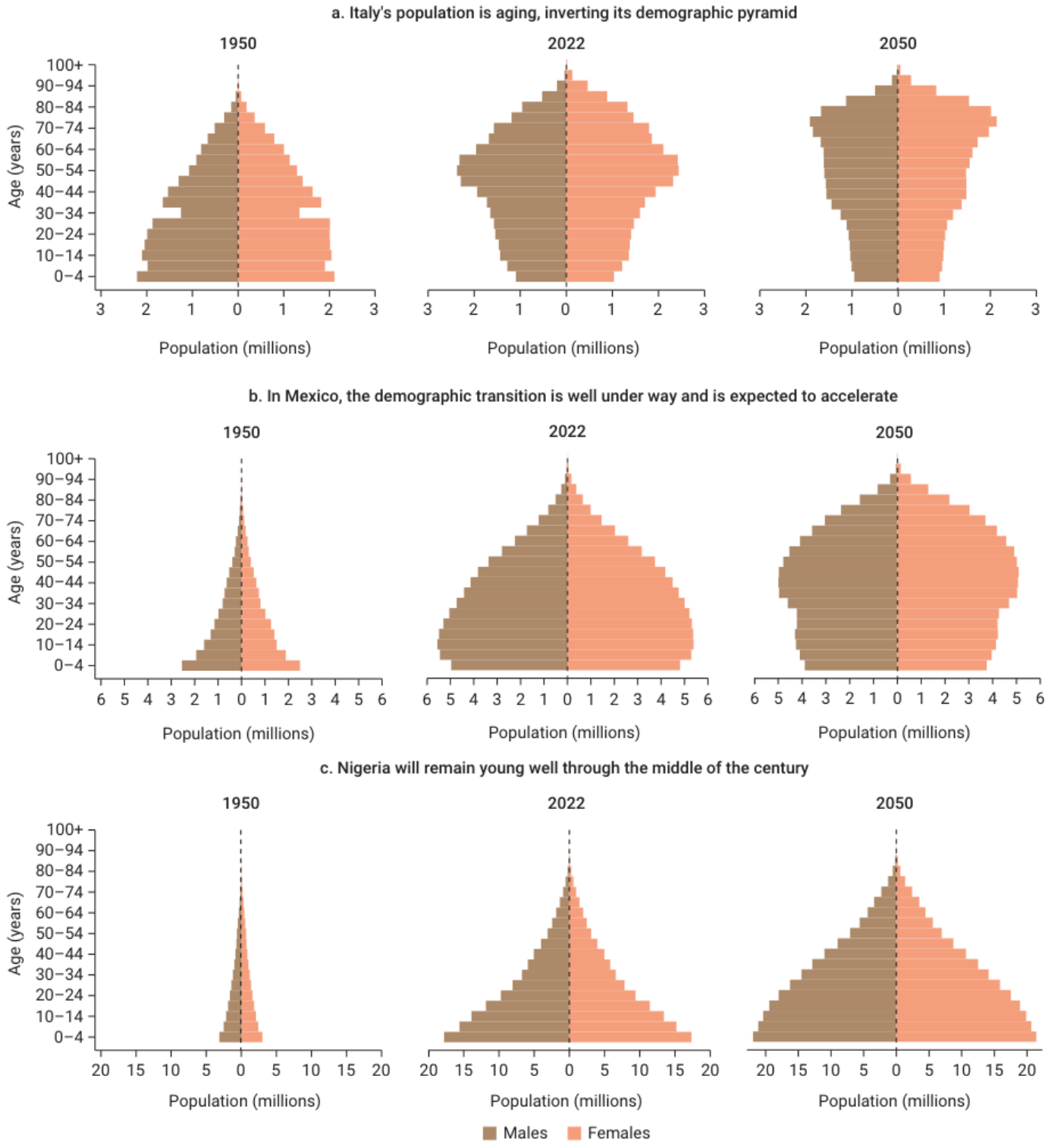


Exhibit. Widely different demographic forces in Italy, Mexico, and Nigeria — shrinking, transitioning, and rapidly growing populations — frame the complementary labour surpluses and deficits that drive migration between youthful origins and aging destinations. Source: S0010.

Economic drivers: wage gaps and demand for skills in destination countries

Demography sets the gradient; wages set the flow. The Human Development Report 2009's central empirical finding is that the returns to crossing a border dwarf almost every other economic decision available to a worker: "The evidence consistently reflects very large average income gains for movers," largest for those leaving low-HDI countries — migrant workers in the United States earn "about four times as much as they would in their developing countries of origin," and Pacific Islanders in New Zealand tripled their net real wages [4]. The gaps are not an OECD peculiarity: Thai migrants in Hong Kong and Taiwan are paid "at least four times as much" as low-skilled work at home, and in Tajikistan, where the average monthly wage was US$9, seasonal earnings of US$500–700 in Russia "could cover a family's annual household expenses" in Dushanbe [4]. Nor are they a low-skill peculiarity: Indian software engineers in the late 1990s earned "less than 30 percent of their United States counterparts," and a doctor from Côte d'Ivoire

"can raise her real earnings by a factor of six by working in France" on a purchasing-power basis [4]. Gains compound with time as language acquisition improves labour-market integration [4].

The same gradient operates inside borders, which is why internal migration dwarfs the international kind: internal movers in Bolivia with low education more than quadrupled their incomes moving countryside to city, and across a 16-country comparison internal migrants out-earned non-migrants in 13 [4]. But the receiving labour markets are segmented, and the segmentation decides who captures the gain: administrative registration systems — China's hukou, Viet Nam's ho khau — and informal norms across South Asia, Africa and Latin America channel rural–urban migrants into "the lowest social and occupational rungs," while migrant women from developing countries concentrate in care, paid domestic work and the informal sector, in the Gulf states often excluded from normal worker protections altogether [4]. Most movers from low-HDI countries, the report notes, end up in other low- or medium-HDI countries anyway, "in part because barriers to admission are often lower and the costs of moving are less" — the wage gap is largest exactly where the door is narrowest [4].

That narrowing is the demand side's politics. Destination labour demand is real but rationed: entry barriers create artificial scarcity, and the HDR's policy logic follows directly — link liberalisation "to the demand for labour, such that inflows of migrants will respond to vacancy levels," a condition "already widely applied by governments, particularly in the developed economies, to the entry of skilled migrants," which the report proposes extending to low-skilled workers with explicit links to labour-market conditions and sectoral needs [4]. The barrier itself creates a rent: "If entry barriers create a shortage of skilled labour in destination countries and hence higher incomes for those who do manage to move, taxing these rents is non-distortionary" — the Bhagwati-tax argument for charging citizens abroad — though implementation has been "very limited" (the Philippines tried and shelved it, and now grants emigrants tax holidays instead), and the practical compensation menu for skill losses is constrained: wage supplements for public-sector workers exceed poor governments' fiscal capacity because "the wage differentials are often too great," leaving options like training in less internationally tradable skills (paramedics rather than doctors), private financing of export-oriented training (the Philippines' nurse route), and return incentives whose record is mixed — returns, the evidence suggests, happen "when countries offer sufficiently attractive opportunities," as in China, India and Mauritius [4].

The newest demand signal is decarbonisation. The Center for Global Development's review of projects linking green-skilled training to migration finds the EU, since 2017, funding labour-mobility projects through Talent Partnerships, the Migration Partnership Facility and the EU Trust Fund for Africa — initiatives "largely set up to be responsive to labour shortages in EU countries of destination," with skills shortages, "rather than broader carbon emissions reductions goals," the key driver across the sample; 16 of 25 mapped initiatives were launched in the last four years [14]. The design flaw is temporal: AMIF funding capped at 36 months "has largely created short-term, temporary, mobility projects" moving relatively few people [14] — destination demand expressed in project cycles too short to build the corridors the wage gaps would fill.

The economic engine, assembled: a four-to-sixfold wage differential for identical labour across a border, a destination side that admits labour against vacancies while rationing entry enough to create scarcity rents, an origin side that cannot fiscally match the differential and so manages its consequences, and now a green transition adding a skills-specific pull funded in three-year tranches. The theories chapter next asks why, given gaps this large, so few people move — the puzzle that the wage numbers alone cannot solve.

Theories of why people move

The wage gaps of the previous section pose the theory problem in its sharpest form: if the same labour earns four to six times more across a border, why does only 3.7 per cent of humanity cross one — and why does so much movement run between rich countries, or end in return? The theories are successive attempts to explain what the differential cannot.

The classical economic account, dominant since the 1950s, models migrants as "opportunity-seekers who weigh the financial costs and benefits of potential destinations and make rational decisions based on the information available to them," with flows running predictably "from low-wage to high-wage labor markets and from low-opportunity to high-opportunity locales" (Todaro's formulation) [3]. Its own literature lists the repairs immediately: "People seldom have perfect information. They are rational actors only to a degree, and decisions are not necessarily made just by the individual. The poorest people often have insufficient capabilities to access high-wage or high-opportunity mar-

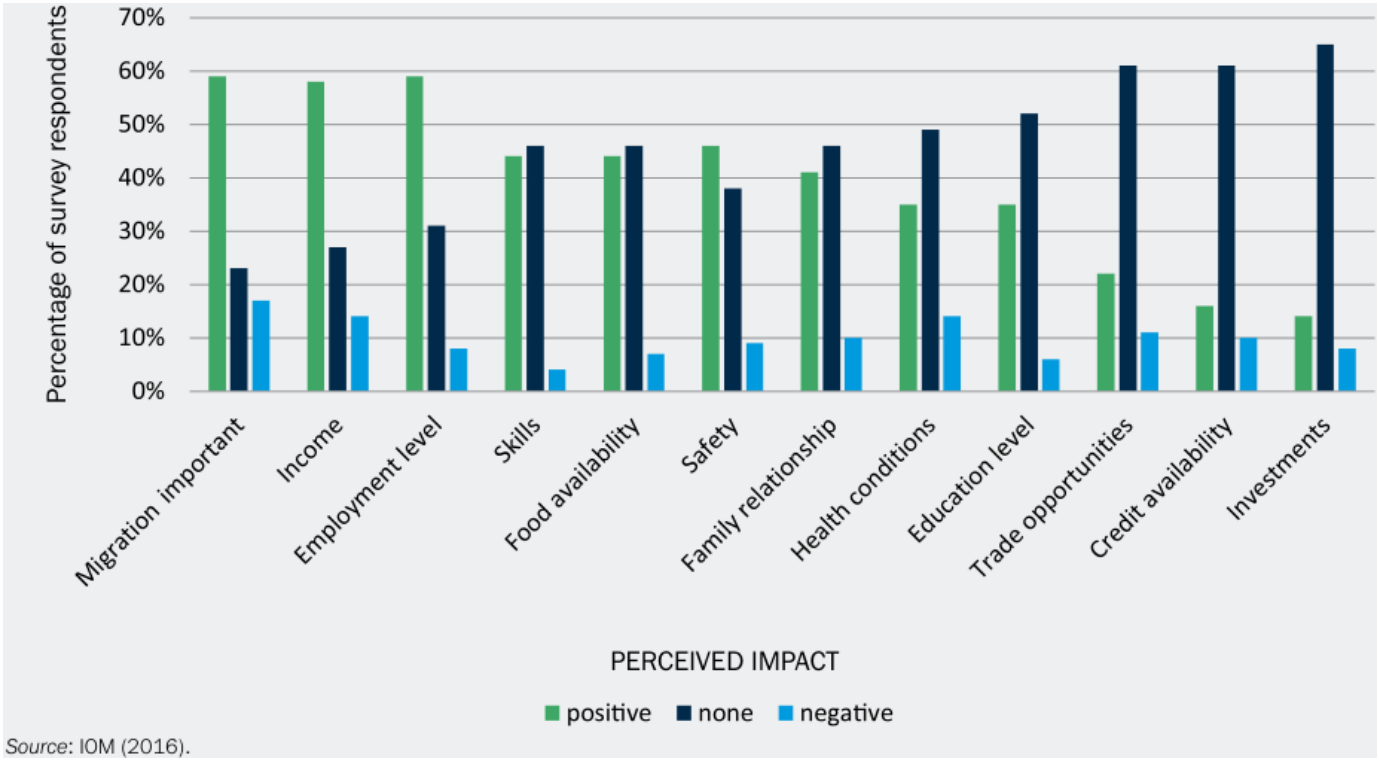
kets" [3]. That last repair is the seed of the immobility puzzle: the people with the most to gain are systematically those least able to act on the gain.

Lee's push–pull framework (1966) widened the unit of analysis from the wage to the situation: four factor groups shape migration — conditions in the sending area, conditions in the destination, "intervening" facilitators and obstacles, and personal factors — with characteristics like age, gender and ethnicity filtering who responds to identical conditions, younger people being consistently more mobile [3]. The New Economics of Labour Migration then moved the decision-maker: not the individual but the household, which sends a member abroad as portfolio strategy — because "credit markets in developing countries are highly imperfect, while household livelihoods often depend on such volatile sectors as agriculture," a migrant's earnings diversify the family's risk rather than simply maximising one worker's wage [4].

The Human Development Report's critique goes further: wage-only theory fails its own tests. "If movement responds only to income differentials, it is hard to explain why many successful migrants choose to return to their country of origin after several years abroad"; and "if migration were purely determined by wage differences, then we would expect to see large movements from poor to rich countries and very little movement among rich countries — but neither of these patterns holds in practice" [4]. Its Indonesian case makes the structural point concretely: tens of thousands of Indonesians enter Malaysia yearly on a wide income differential, yet "the scale of movement has also grown steadily since the 1980s, whereas the income gap between the two countries has alternately widened and narrowed" — the trend is explained instead by Malaysian industrialisation emptying its countryside into cities and creating agricultural labour scarcity just as commercialisation and population growth produced an Indonesian farm-labour surplus, with shared ethnic, linguistic and religious background facilitating the flow [4]. And motives can be orthogonal to wages entirely: young lower-caste Kola men in Central Gujarat take factory jobs outside their villages "in order to break away from subordinate caste relations" at wages "not higher, and in some cases lower, than what they would earn as agricultural day labourers at home" [4]. The report frames the synthesis as an "agency–structure interaction" — individual decisions framed by economic and social structures that are context-specific and change over time — and grounds its own lens in the capabilities approach of Sen and Haq, in which movement matters first as "the expansion of people's freedoms to live their lives as they choose," before any of its income effects are counted [4].

The climate literature inherits this apparatus rather than replacing it. The Foresight framework (2011), as adapted in the Groundswell analysis, holds that "climate change influences migration decisions through existing migration drivers" — depressing rural wages, raising agricultural prices, shaping hazard exposure — operating simultaneously at macro level (demographic, economic, political, social and environmental variables beyond household control), meso level (the intervening facilitators and obstacles: employment agencies, smuggling networks, diasporic links, the cost of moving), and micro level (health, skills, risk perception) [3]. Households decide with portfolios of livelihood capital — natural, financial, human and social, in Scoones's typology — which climate stress erodes directly and indirectly, the indirect effects "just as pernicious" as the visible ones; and the decision itself "is not a simple binary choice," being filtered through perceptions of vulnerability, assessments of future need, norms and beliefs, and any prior migration experience [3].

Assembled, the theoretical stack explains the data the earlier chapters presented. Wage differentials set the direction of potential flow; household risk logic sets its composition; intervening obstacles and capabilities set its volume — which is why the largest gaps produce modest movements and why development, by relaxing the capability constraint before it closes the wage gap, first raises emigration (the hump examined later in this report); networks and structure explain persistence and rich–rich symmetry; and non-economic motives — freedom from hierarchy, family strategy, the value of movement itself — explain the residual that no wage regression captures. Theory's verdict on the counting chapters is sobering: the stock is small not because the incentives are weak, but because the filters are strong.



Source: IOM (2016).

Exhibit. Figure 2.2: Perceived impact of migration on households according to a 2016 survey conducted by the International Organization for Migration PERCEIVED IMPACT Source : IOM (2016). Source: S0006.

Water, food insecurity, and compounding climate pressures

The pressure that moves people rarely arrives as a single shock. It arrives as water that is scarcer, harvests that are thinner, and prices that transmit both into the household — and the IPCC's Sixth Assessment states the aggregate finding at high confidence: climate change, "including increases in frequency and intensity of extremes[,] have reduced food and water security, hindering efforts to meet Sustainable Development Goals"; extremes "have exposed millions of people to acute food insecurity and reduced water security, with the largest impacts observed in many locations and/or communities in Africa, Asia, Central and South America, Small Islands and the Arctic"; and "[r]oughly half of the world's population currently experience severe water scarcity for at least some part of the year due to climatic and non-climatic drivers" [15]. The same assessment finds that although overall agricultural productivity has grown, climate change has slowed that growth over the past 50 years, and that sudden production losses compounded by decreased diet diversity have increased malnutrition, "especially for Indigenous Peoples, small-scale food producers and low-income households," with children, the elderly and pregnant women particularly affected [15]. These are the conditions under which the livelihood portfolios described in the theory sections are spent down — and under which moving, or being unable to move, becomes the household's residual strategy.

The Mashreq, examined in the World Bank's Groundswell Part 2, shows the compounding in a single subregion. At 4°C of warming by 2100, agricultural zones could shift "up to 75 kilometers northward," wheat growing periods in large parts of the subregion could shorten "by about two weeks by mid-century," and pest regimes shift with temperature: fall armyworm and desert locusts are "having disastrous impacts in Yemen," where "[i]n the 2020 growing season alone, the locust outbreak caused an estimated US$222 million in damages and losses" [16]. Livestock systems fail through feed, water, heat stress and disease together — "[b]etween 2005 and 2010, recurring droughts cost herders in Syria almost 85 percent of their livestock," and Syria's collapsed animal-health system has been linked to disease outbreaks in Lebanon through seasonal transboundary livestock movements [16]. Household surveys record the lived version: in Syria, 87 percent of respondents reported crop losses between 2005 and 2010, 20 percent lost income and 17 percent lost livestock; in Yemen, 61 percent reported crop losses, 52 percent lost income and 26 percent livestock and fishing losses [16]. And because the Mashreq countries are already "some of the world's largest importers of food" — Jordan imports around US$4 billion of food and agricultural products with "a cereal import dependency ratio of around 90 percent" — local production shocks compound with exposure to trade disruption, price spikes and currency depreciation [16].

The final compounding is political, and the evidence demands care. Scarcity of land and water "can sometimes exacerbate important drivers of conflict," and Syria's 2007–2010 drought "has been identified as a contributing factor

in the country's ongoing conflict, acting through impacts on vulnerable livelihoods and food insecurity and on rural-urban migration" — yet "[t]he precise role of drought is difficult to gauge, however, given the vast number of intermediating variables," and across the wider region "cooperation to address water risks has been found to be more common than conflict" [16]. Mobility then feeds back into fragility: Syrian refugees "have placed an unplanned burden on water services and resources in Jordan and Lebanon," with many in Lebanon concentrated in "the main agricultural areas of the North and the Bekaa, putting additional pressure on farmlands, rangelands, groundwater, and forest resources," while "the poorest people might not have the means to migrate... and thus be trapped in difficult situations, facing the compounding impacts of conflict and climate change" [16]. The Groundswell conclusion is institutional rather than hydraulic: "[i]t is often not water scarcity itself that leads to tensions, but the way that resources are managed" [16]. Water and food pressures thus convert into migration through exactly the channels the theory chapter specified — eroded livelihood capital, meso-level obstacles, and households whose remaining choices narrow to moving badly or not moving at all.

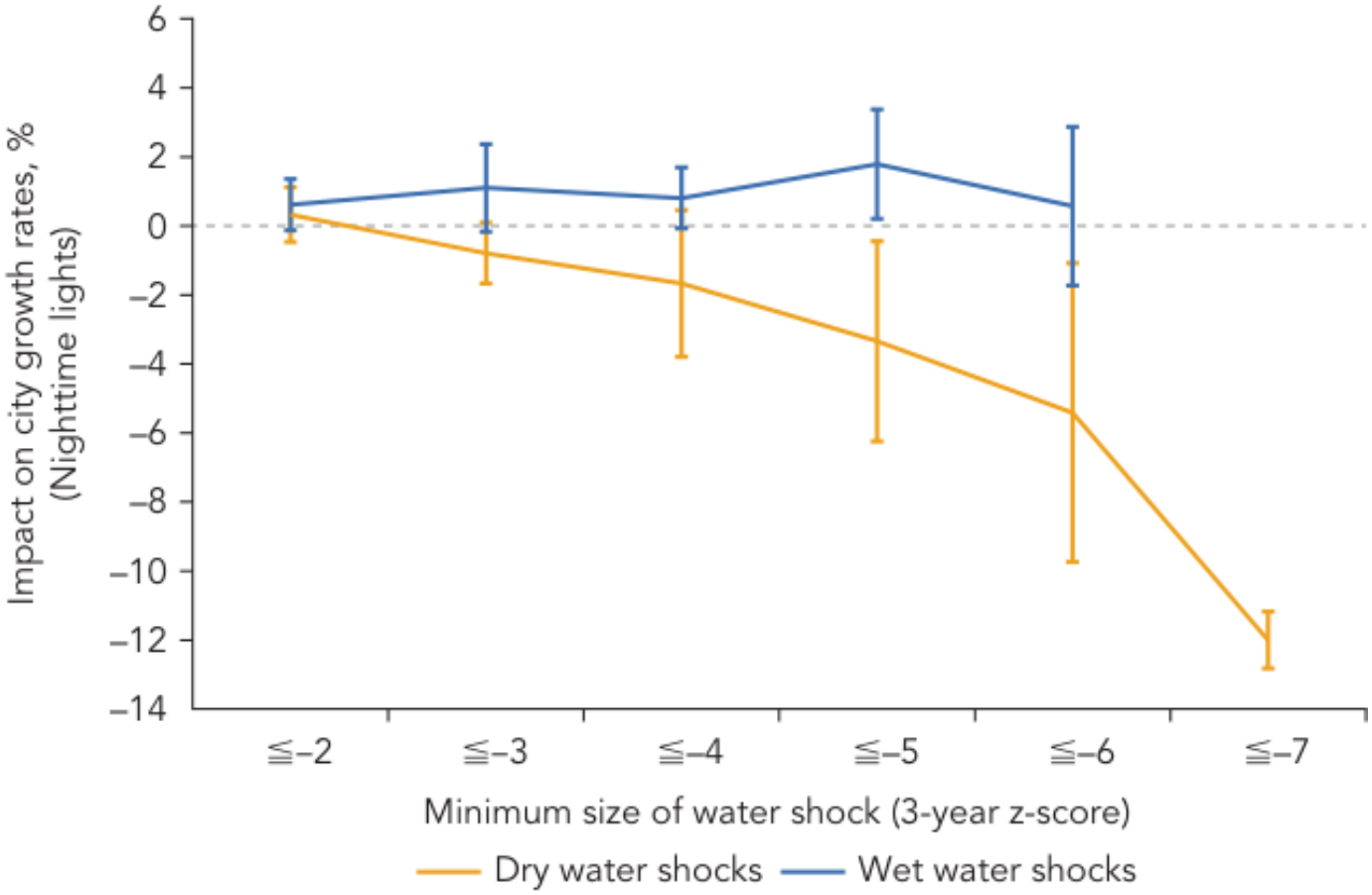


Exhibit. The impact of rainfall shocks on growth rates of cities at urban water points shows how water availability mediates climate-driven internal migration, with better-watered cities absorbing movers from drought-stressed areas. Source: S0019.

Conflict, violence, and disaster displacement

Forced displacement runs on two different logics, and conflating them misreads both. Conflict displacement tracks fragility: the World Migration Report's cross-index comparison finds that peaceful, high-development countries "produce fewer refugees and asylum-seekers and have a lower number or are without conflict-induced IDPs," while in Syria "protracted conflict means that more than half the population is still forcibly displaced" and Ethiopia, Afghanistan and Somalia hold millions of conflict IDPs against zero recorded in stable Costa Rica, Malaysia and Bhutan [2]. Disaster displacement does not follow that gradient at all: "new internal disaster displacements show a very different pattern, highlighting that disaster displacement is more linked to geographical issues than to development issues" — new displacements "occurred across the spectrum of HDI ranked countries," and the countries affected by disaster displacement "far outstrip[] the number of countries affected by internal displacement due to conflict and violence" [2]. Exposure decides the second system; state failure decides the first. Their intersection is where the worst numbers accumulate.

The scale of the disaster system is now the larger flow. UNHCR's Global Trends records "45.8 million internal displacements due to disasters" in 2024, with 9.8 million people still displaced at year-end — disaster movements accounting for "70 per cent of all new displacements in 2024," slightly more than half of them (54 per cent) triggered by cyclones, three-quarters occurring in low- and middle-income countries [7]. National concentrations are extreme: storms and cyclones displaced "just over 9 million people in the Philippines" and floods "5.4 million people in India" in that single year [7]. The following year's Global Report on Internal Displacement shows the flow receding from that peak without normalising: disaster displacements "declined in 2025 to 29.9 million new or repeated movements across 140 countries and territories," a 35 per cent fall from 2024 but "still 13 per cent higher than the decadal average," with storms driving 17.9 million movements (about 60 per cent, the second-highest figure on record), wildfires over 694,000 — the second-highest in a decade, striking Los Angeles County, Greece's Attica region and Türkiye's İzmir province — and geophysical events around 2.5 million, including nearly 1.6 million pre-emptive tsunami evacuations in Chile and Japan [17]. Conflict displacement, meanwhile, stood at 68.6 million people in 54 countries and territories at the end of 2025 — down 7 per cent on the year, the total stock falling "for the first time since 2016, but remain[ing] near record level and far above the decadal average," led by Sudan (9.1 million), Colombia (7.2 million) and Syria (6 million) [17].

The compounding is systematic, not incidental. "In 45 of the 49 countries and territories (92 per cent) where new internal displacements due to conflict and violence were reported by IDMC, new displacements due to disasters were also reported" — Chad's 2024 floods alone caused "more than 1.3 million internal displacements, by far the highest disaster displacement figure on record for the country and more than in the previous 15 years combined," floods and storms triggered around 750,000 further displacements in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and Sudan's June–August 2024 flooding displaced nearly 200,000 people, "including many conflict-affected IDPs" [7]. The same report notes — a counting fact with real consequences — that headline global forced-displacement totals do not include the disaster-displaced at all [7]. What separates a displacement event from a displacement crisis, the GRID evidence suggests, is preparation: "Impacts varied significantly depending on early warning systems, evacuation protocols and response capacity," and where those systems work, "temporary displacement through evacuation can function as a protective measure that reduces human and economic losses" [17]. Conflict displacement is a governance failure measured in people; disaster displacement is an exposure fact whose human cost is set by the institutions that meet it — which is why the two systems, so different in origin, keep producing the same protracted caseloads where fragile states and exposed geographies coincide.

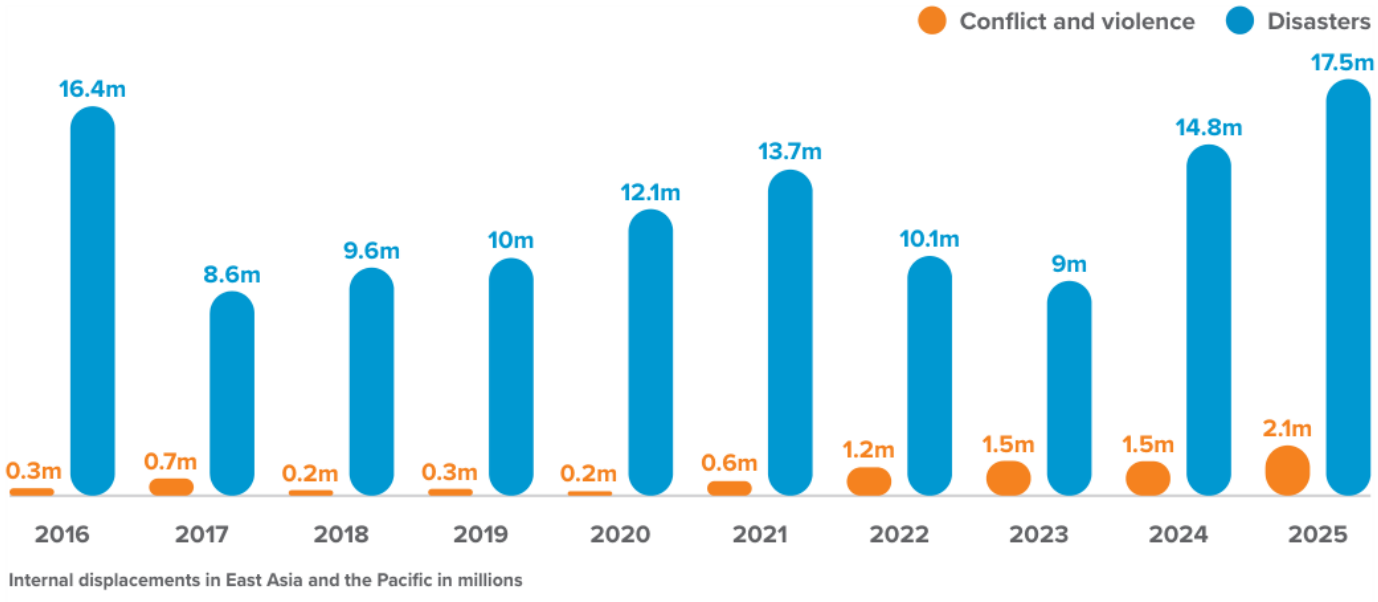


Exhibit. Annual internal displacements from 2016 onward show disaster movements consistently outnumbering conflict and violence displacements while both series climb to record levels. Source: S0029.

Forced displacement at record scale

Global forced displacement trends

Forced displacement ended 2024 at another record — and, for the first time in years, the shape of the curve changed. “The number of people forced to flee persecution, conflict, violence, human rights violations and events seriously disturbing public order rose in 2024, reaching a record 123.2 million,” an increase of 7 million (6 per cent) on end-2023, so that “[o]ne in 67 people globally were forcibly displaced at the end of 2024” [7]. Concentration is the second headline: “[s]lightly more than one-third of all forcibly displaced people globally were Sudanese (14.3 million), Syrian (13.5 million), Afghan (10.3 million) or Ukrainian (8.8 million)” — four situations carrying more than 47 million people between them [7]. The flows behind the stock were 20.1 million people newly displaced within their own countries by conflict and violence during 2024 and 5.4 million crossing borders as refugees and asylum-seekers, within a total of 65.8 million new internal displacements once disaster movements are counted [7]. Over the decade the forcibly displaced population “has almost doubled” [7].

The inflection sits inside the year. Growth decelerated sharply: “while there was an estimated increase of 5.2 million forcibly displaced people in the first half of 2024, the increase in the second half of the year dropped to only a third of that, 1.7 million,” and operational data into 2025 “indicate that global forced displacement may begin to fall during 2025” — by end-April 2025 UNHCR estimated a slight fall of 1 per cent, to 122.1 million [7]. Whether that becomes a trend “will depend on the dynamics in key situations”: ceasefires or their absence in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Sudan and Ukraine; South Sudan not deteriorating; return conditions in Afghanistan and Syria; and “how dire the impact of the current funding cuts will be on the capacity to address forced displacement situations” [7].

The Sahel spotlight shows what the aggregate conceals about reception. Surveyed displaced households in Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger reported striking cohesion — 91 per cent felt integrated into the host community and 82 per cent reported good intercommunity relations, with eight in ten confirming community-based conflict-management mechanisms — while the coastal states of Côte d’Ivoire, Ghana, Togo and Benin registered more than 62,400 new asylum applications during 2024, and Ghana granted prima facie refugee status to Burkinabè asylum-seekers in January 2025 [7]. The pressure valve nonetheless points outward: Malian irregular movements rose 57 per cent to 19,200 in 2024, and Malians recognised as refugees in Europe reached 12,200 — “a three-fold increase from the previous year,” with the protection rate rising to 82 per cent from 65 per cent [7]. The global trend line and the regional one thus tell the same story at different scales: a stock built by a decade of unresolved conflicts, a growth rate finally bending, and outcomes that hinge less on new displacement dynamics than on whether the large situations resolve, returns become viable, and the funding to hold host communities together survives.

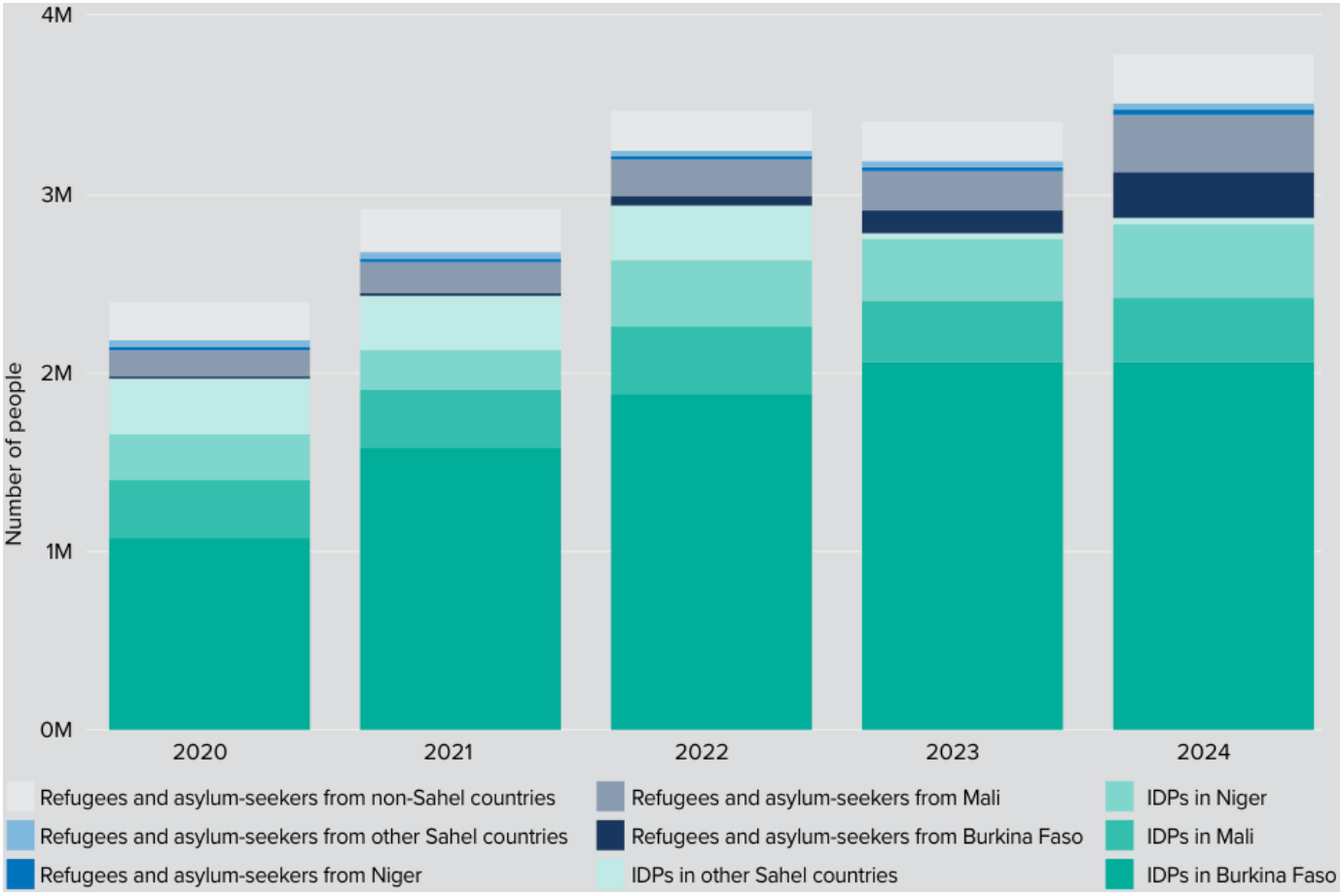


Exhibit. Refugees, asylum-seekers and internally displaced people in the Sahel from 2020 to 2024, showing end-year totals climbing toward four million across the region's displacement categories. Source: S0004.

Refugees: key situations and demographic composition

The refugee system at end-2024 held 42.7 million refugees and other people in need of international protection, and its geography is a study in asymmetry: flight is short-distance, hosting is poor-country, and exile is long. "Most people fleeing conflict and persecution remain near their country of origin" — 67 per cent of refugees were hosted in neighbouring countries at end-2024 — and 73 per cent were hosted by low- and middle-income countries [7]. The disproportion is quantifiable: low-income countries, with "9 per cent of the global population and only 0.6 per cent of global domestic product… hosted 19 per cent of refugees," including very large populations in Chad, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Ethiopia, Sudan and Uganda, while the Least Developed Countries — 1.4 per cent of global GDP — hosted nearly 23 per cent, 8.4 million people, up 9 per cent on end-2023 [7]. High-income countries, holding most of the world's wealth, hosted 27 per cent [7]. Even the categories move: the lower-middle-income share fell from 28 to 17 per cent in a single year "due to the reclassification of the Islamic Republic of Iran, which hosts 3.5 million refugees, as an upper-middle-income country by the World Bank," pushing the upper-middle share (Türkiye, Colombia, Peru) to 37 per cent [7] — a reminder that burden-sharing statistics are partly accounting artefacts.

The major situations at end-2023, the last full origin breakdown in these sources, show the pattern at country level. Syrian refugees stood at 6.4 million, "almost three-quarters (73 per cent)… hosted in neighbouring countries including Türkiye (3.2 million), Lebanon (784,900) and Jordan (649,100)" [18]. Of the reported 6.1 million Venezuelans displaced abroad, 97 per cent remained in Latin America — Colombia (2.9 million), Peru (1 million), Ecuador (471,400) and Chile (435,800) — the total up from 5.4 million at end-2022 [18]. Ukrainian refugees numbered 6 million, up 5 per cent on the year and "25 times more than a decade ago," 2.6 million of them (44 per cent) in neighbouring countries [18]. And 90 per cent of Afghan refugees were hosted in just two countries, Iran (3.8 million) and Pakistan (2 million) [18]. The hosting league table is correspondingly concentrated: Iran (3.8 million), Türkiye (3.3 million), Colombia (2.9 million), Germany (2.6 million) and Pakistan (2 million) — Germany "the only country which does not share a border with the major refugee source countries it hosted," its population drawn from Ukraine (1.1 million), Syria (705,800), Afghanistan (255,100) and Iraq (146,500) [18]. Counts themselves are negotiated objects: Iran's 2023 increase of 339,400 "was mainly due to the inclusion of additional estimates of Afghans" after a government recount that enrolled 2.6 million people and extended to the undocumented [18].

Duration is the system's defining pathology. A protracted situation — over 25,000 refugees of one origin in a low- or middle-income host for at least five consecutive years — held an estimated 24.7 million people at end-2024, 67 per cent of the total, across 57 situations in 36 host countries; the figure fell by 200,700, "the first decrease in the scale of protracted situations globally since 2020" [7].

One population sits in a parallel legal universe. The 5.2 million Palestinian refugees registered with UNRWA — in Jordan (2.2 million), the Gaza Strip (1.3 million), the West Bank (790,000), Lebanon (500,000) and Syria (450,000) — descend from those who lost home and livelihood in the 1948 conflict, refugee status now extending "into a fifth generation," with 38 per cent aged 15–24 and almost 30 per cent living in 58 administered camps; many global refugee totals exclude them despite their entitlement to protection [5]. Their Syrian branch shows displacement compounding: of 560,000 Palestinian refugees registered in Syria before its war, 110,000 fled abroad again and 60 per cent of those who remained were internally displaced [5].

Demographic composition varies by destination as much as by origin. Children form roughly half of refugee populations in aggregate (the end-2024 age structure was set out in the demographics chapter), but "in Germany, children are just one in five refugees, while they represent three in five refugees living in both South Sudan and the Democratic Republic of the Congo" — variation UNICEF attributes to the distance and difficulty of the journey, the origin population's age structure, destination asylum policy, and the social and financial capital families can mobilise [5]. The refugee map, assembled: four protracted mega-situations and dozens of smaller ones, hosted overwhelmingly next door by countries with a fraction of global income, counted by methods that shift with reclassifications and recounts, and ageing — in the Palestinian case across five generations — in place.

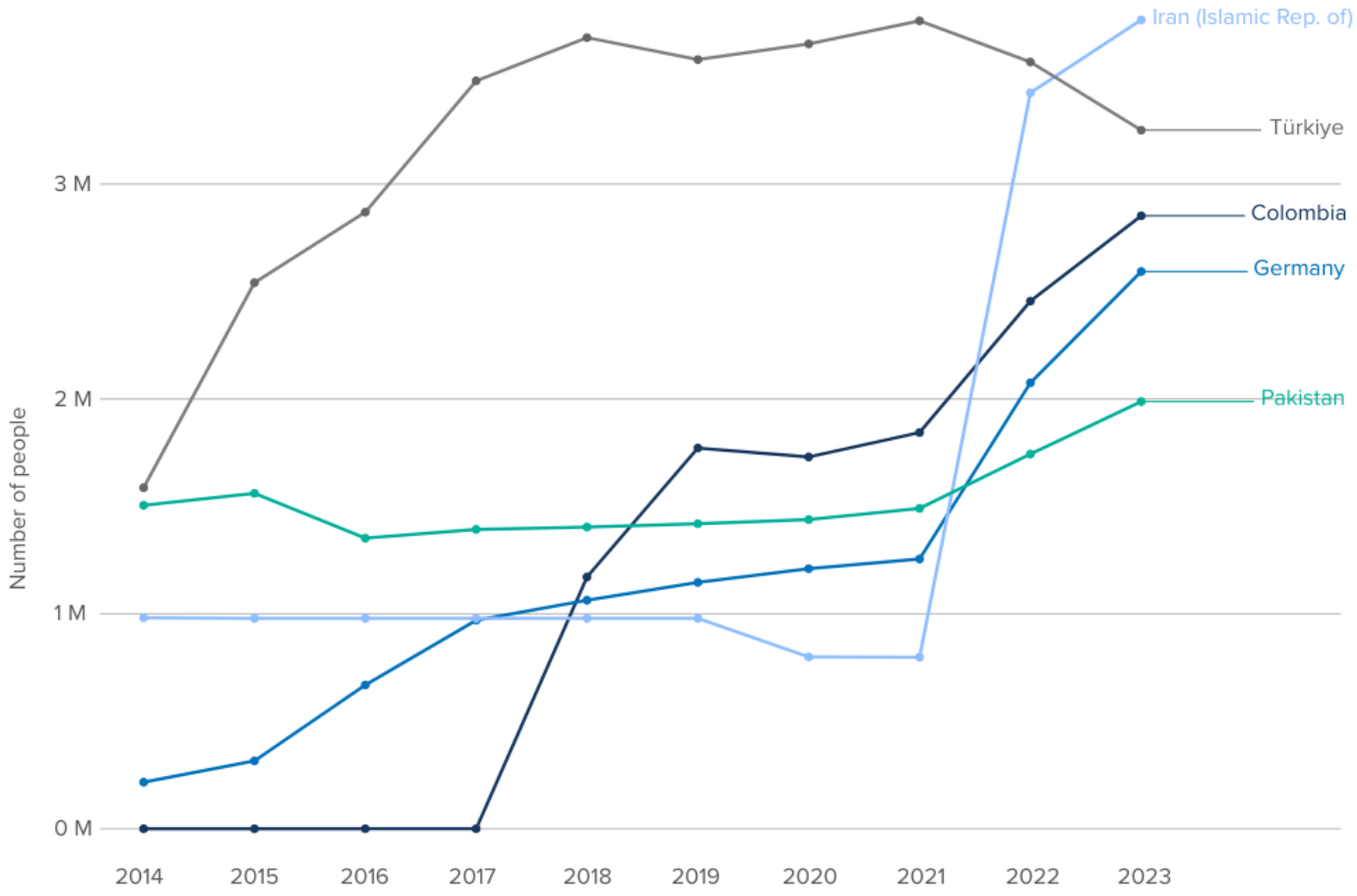


Exhibit. Refugees, people in refugee-like situations and others needing international protection are shown by major country of asylum from 2014 to 2023, with Iran among the largest hosts over the decade. Source: S0003.

Internally displaced people (IDPs): scale, drivers, and returns

Internal displacement is forced migration that stops at the border. Under the 1998 Guiding Principles, IDPs are people "forced or obliged to flee or to leave their homes or places of habitual residence, in particular as a result of or in order to avoid the effects of armed conflict, situations of generalized violence, violations of human rights or natural or human-made disasters, and who have not crossed an internationally recognized State border" [17]. The

counting discipline matters as much as the definition: the stock — "the total number of people living in internal displacement at a specific point in time," including everyone uprooted in earlier years who has not returned or found another solution — is a different quantity from the flow, in which "[t]he same person or people can be displaced several times over a given period" and each movement counts [17]. Stocks measure unresolved failure; flows measure instability.

On the stock measure, conflict and violence held 68.6 million people in internal displacement across 54 countries and territories at the end of 2025 — a 7 per cent decrease on 2024, the total "fall[ing] for the first time since 2016, but remain[ing] near record level and far above the decadal average" — concentrated in Sudan (9.1 million), Colombia (7.2 million), Syria (6 million), Yemen (4.8 million) and Afghanistan (4.4 million), with a further disaster-displaced stock spread across 82 countries and territories [17]. The drivers are the previous sections' two systems operating inside one jurisdiction: the same wars that produce refugees produce larger IDP populations upstream of the border, and the same storms and floods displace people who overwhelmingly remain within their own country — which is why internal displacement, lacking a dedicated international protection regime, is at once the largest forced-movement category and the least institutionally owned.

Returns are the stock's main release valve, and the numbers show both their power and their fragility. "In 2023, nearly 5.1 million internally displaced people are estimated to have returned to their place of origin. This is a 60 per cent drop from the previous year but remains generally consistent with earlier years," with nearly 62 per cent of returns in just two countries — the Democratic Republic of the Congo (1.8 million) and Ukraine (1.3 million) — and 534,300 people returning in northern Ethiopia "after a peace agreement was signed in November 2022," alongside 325,900 returns in the Central African Republic and 281,000 in Mozambique [18]. But the World Development Report warns against reading return as restoration: it "may be experienced as a new movement rather than as going back to the status quo ante," not least where roughly three-quarters of Afghan refugees in Pakistan were born in exile [8]. The failure statistics are stark: "[b]etween 2000 and 2015, 46 percent of large-scale returns were matched by a sizable increase in the number of IDPs," returnees in Afghanistan have repeatedly become IDPs themselves, and "[o]f the 15 largest instances of return since 1991, about one-third were followed within a couple of years by a new round of conflict" [8]. What distinguishes durable return is endowment, not just peace: people repatriate successfully "where they have portable assets... and marketable skills," so that "the extent to which life in exile provides space to build assets and skills can therefore be critical to a successful return" [8]. Some households refuse the binary altogether — split families and cyclical return, "with some household members moving back and forth between their place of origin and a place of exile," as practised by some Somali refugees [8]. The IDP stock, in short, drains through returns whose durability is an economic question disguised as a geographic one.

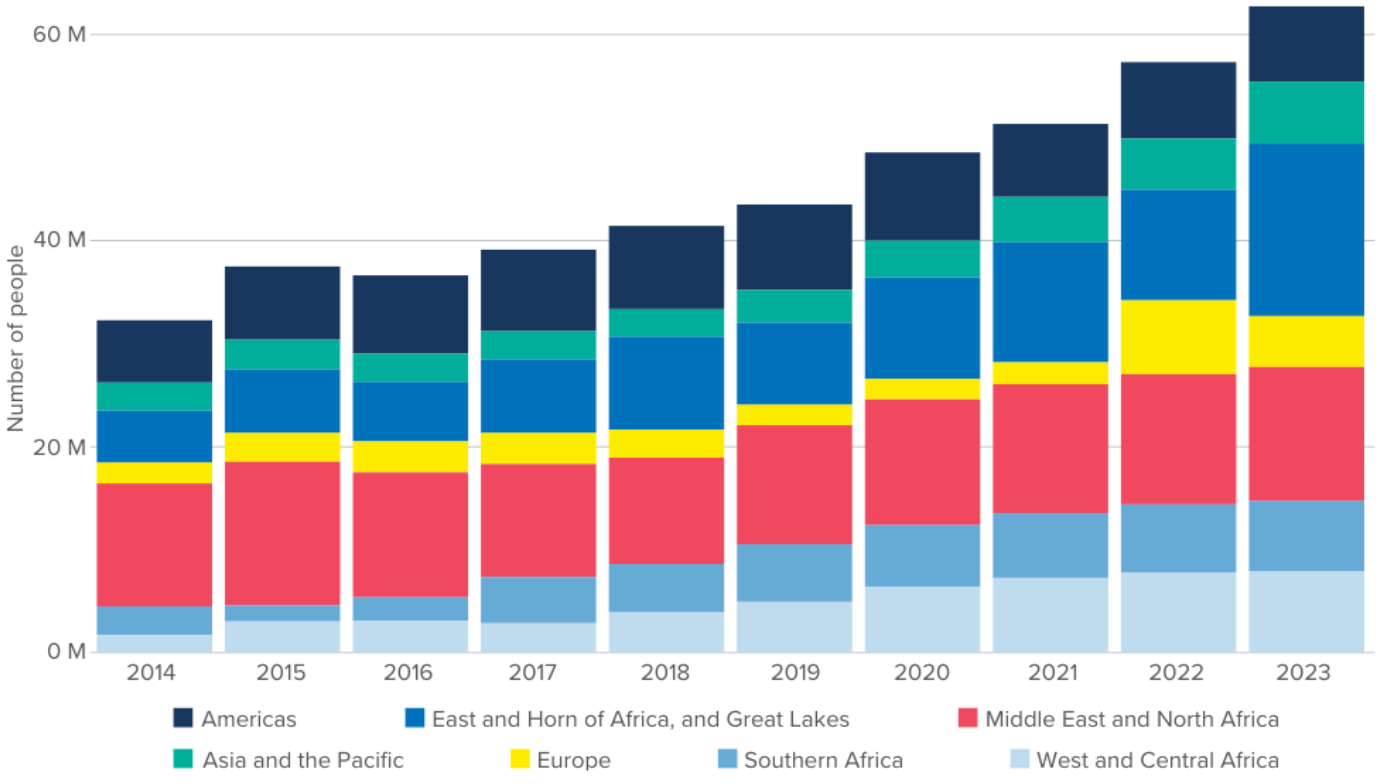


Exhibit. Internally displaced people protected or assisted by UNHCR are shown by region from 2014 to 2023, tracing the growth and geographic spread of the internally displaced population under UNHCR's mandate. Source: S0003.

Stateless people

Statelessness is the migration system's limiting case: people who belong to no state at all, and therefore appear in almost no state's statistics. UNHCR's reported figure is 4.4 million, derived "from data for 101 countries on known stateless populations reported to UNHCR in 2024," but the caveats dominate the number: "[j]ust under half of all countries do not report any data on statelessness to UNHCR, including several with significant known stateless populations," some countries report only part of their stateless population, and so "[t]he true global number of stateless people is likely much higher" [7]. What data exist come from administrative registers, asylum processing, censuses, surveys and estimates of variable quality, and the category itself needs policing — estimates must distinguish mandate statelessness, where "discriminatory nationality laws or practices" structurally bar citizenship, from people who merely lack documents, and must exclude people of unknown origin who do not cooperate in establishing their identity [7]. The undercount is thus constitutional: a population defined by exclusion from state systems is counted only where states choose to look.

Unlike most categories in this report, statelessness has a working exit, and 2024 saw it used at an accelerating rate. "In 2024, 47,200 stateless people or people of undetermined nationality acquired citizenship or had their nationality confirmed… in 32 countries. This represents a 47 per cent increase compared to 2023," led by 19,900 nationality certificates issued in South Sudan and citizenship grants in Viet Nam (6,200) and Thailand (5,700) [7]. Thailand approved "a resolution to accelerate pathways to permanent residency and nationality for nearly half a million registered stateless people," against a national total above 612,500; Turkmenistan, after naturalising a final group of 1,100 in September 2024, "announced that all known statelessness cases within its territory have been resolved" — the category's only complete national closure [7]. Sao Tome and Principe and South Sudan acceded to both the 1954 and 1961 statelessness conventions; Mauritania registered over 600,000 people in a civil-registration campaign reaching those at risk; Iraq simplified nationality confirmation for Faili Kurds [7].

The institutional architecture thickened in the same year. Latin American and Caribbean states adopted the Chile Declaration under the Cartagena+40 process; the League of Arab States launched the Arab Declaration on Belonging and Legal Identity, centred on birth registration and women's legal rights; and the African Union adopted a Protocol on the right to a nationality and the eradication of statelessness in Africa — addressing generational statelessness and nomadic and cross-border populations, entering into force after 15 ratifications [7]. Above these sits the Global Alliance to End Statelessness, launched in October 2024 with 141 states and organisations as members by May 2025, succeeding UNHCR's ten-year #IBelong campaign, "during which more than 600,000 stateless people acquired citizenship, 14 States acceded to the 1954 Convention and 18 States to the 1961 Convention" [7]. Statelessness is therefore the one displacement-adjacent problem in this report with a plausible terminal state — every case is, in principle, a paperwork decision away from resolution — yet its persistence, and the certainty that the real total exceeds the reported one, measure how much of the world's belonging still depends on whether a state bothers to count.

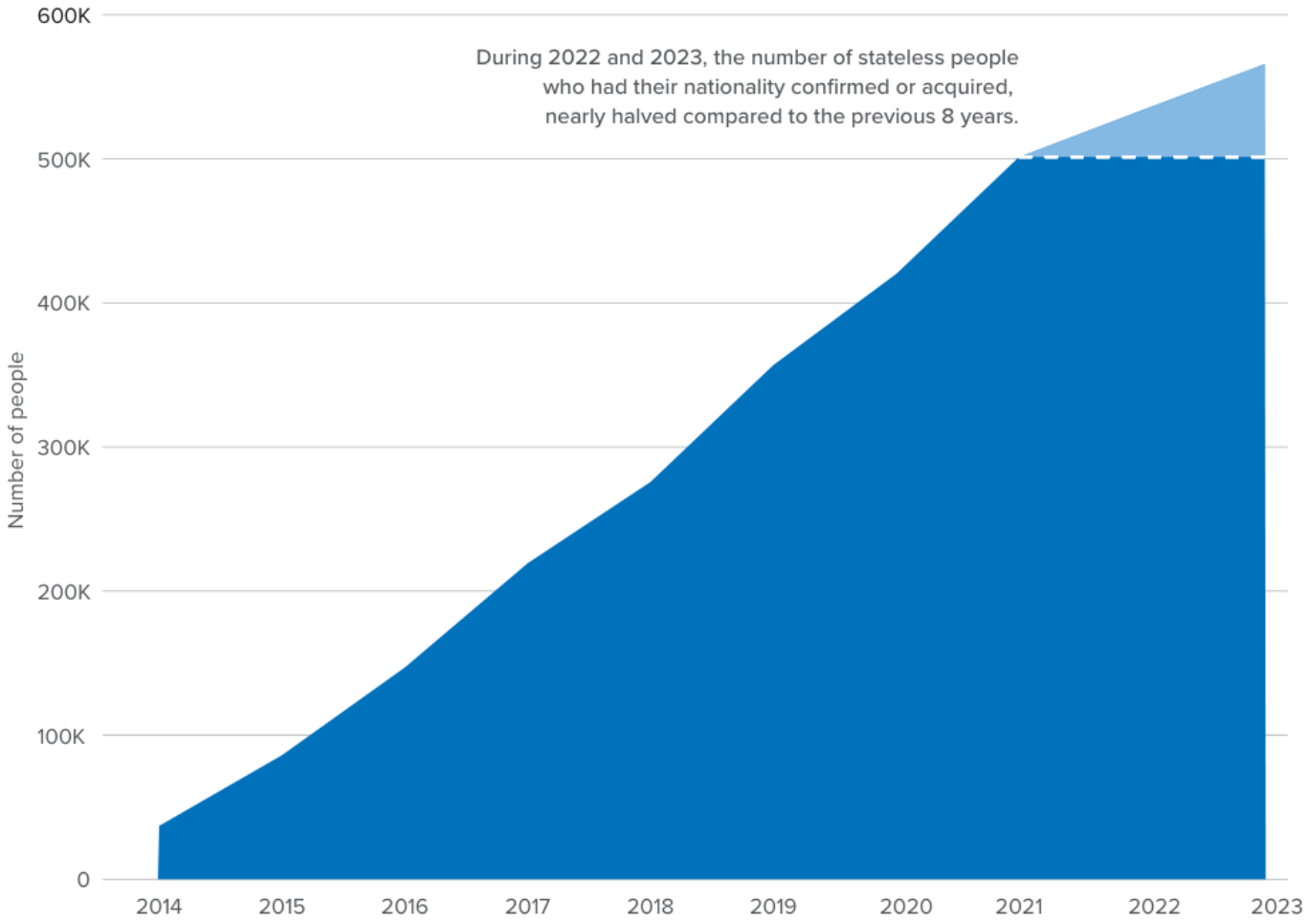


Exhibit. The cumulative number of stateless people who had their nationality confirmed or acquired citizenship between 2014 and 2023 charts the slow administrative resolution of statelessness over the decade. Source: S0003.

Children on the move

Children are not migration's luggage. They are roughly half of all refugees against a clear minority of voluntary migrants — the composition chapters put children at 41 per cent of the refugee population — and they move under legal and physical regimes built for adults. The route-level evidence, from UNICEF and IOM's seven-country study of North Africa and the corridors toward Europe, shows what that mismatch costs. In 2024 alone, 127 children died or disappeared on overland or maritime journeys toward Europe — 5 per cent of recorded deaths and disappearances on those routes — and the losses "are increasing due to systemic gaps in child protection systems that should include and safeguard children on the move" [19].

The drivers contradict the economic-migration stereotype. Among girls and female youth on these routes, 70 per cent reported leaving home for safety — 35 per cent fleeing personal violence and 35 per cent war and conflict; among boys and male youth, 51 per cent left for safety, including 29 per cent for war and conflict, 20 per cent for personal violence and 2 per cent to escape forced conscription [19]. Violence compounds: "children who experienced violence in their home countries were far more likely to encounter violence again in transit" than children who did not flee threats [19]. The assistance caseload reflects the scale: in 2024 IOM registered 15,691 vulnerable migrant children for assistance in the seven transit countries, including 2,989 unaccompanied and separated children, 979 with critical health needs and 396 identified as potential victims of trafficking; boys outnumbered girls among registered and unaccompanied children everywhere, while girls were more often identified as trafficking victims in Libya, Egypt and Mauritania [19].

The system's characteristic failure is detention and summary removal. On the Western Mediterranean route, children's detention "often follows maritime interceptions, border crossings, or returns"; despite legal prohibitions in some countries, enforcement is inconsistent, and children experience "expulsions, pushbacks, removals and relocations internally and internationally on a routine basis, without due process" — arrested and transferred to remote border crossings "without engagement with guardians or service providers," without notice, belongings or documentation, and without access to family tracing, "leading to prolonged separation and disappearance from formal

systems” [19]. In Mauritania and Morocco, unaccompanied children are “often held in adult facilities or in police custody due to a lack of formal shelters,” with long referral delays and reunification “rarely prioritized”; across the routes, “there is no formal referral system in place for children intercepted at sea” [19]. The human residue is recorded in frontline testimony — a social worker in Italy: “Libya breaks them. It is the worst part of their journey. They arrive in Italy physically safe but emotionally destroyed” [19]. UNICEF’s summary of the practice is categorical: migrant children are “frequently detained with and treated as adults, denied access to critical health-care services, psychosocial support and legal representation,” even as Egypt, Libya, Morocco and Sudan have built community-hosting alternatives for unaccompanied children with UN and NGO support [19].

The developmental stakes are longest where displacement is deepest. In Africa, UNICEF’s earlier global survey found well over one-third of primary- and lower-secondary-age children out of school in South Sudan, Niger and Sudan — three long-running conflicts — while the evidence on migration’s effects on children who move voluntarily is “extremely limited” and mixed: outcomes vary with which parent migrated, whether the move is temporary or permanent, the child’s age, and whether the child moved with family or alone, with remittance income benefiting left-behind children only as far as their care arrangements allow [5]. The through-line of the chapter is asymmetry of consequence: adults experience migration as an episode; children experience it as development — schooling interrupted at exactly the ages where interruption compounds, protection systems that process them as small adults, and journeys whose violence, for those who fled violence first, arrives twice.

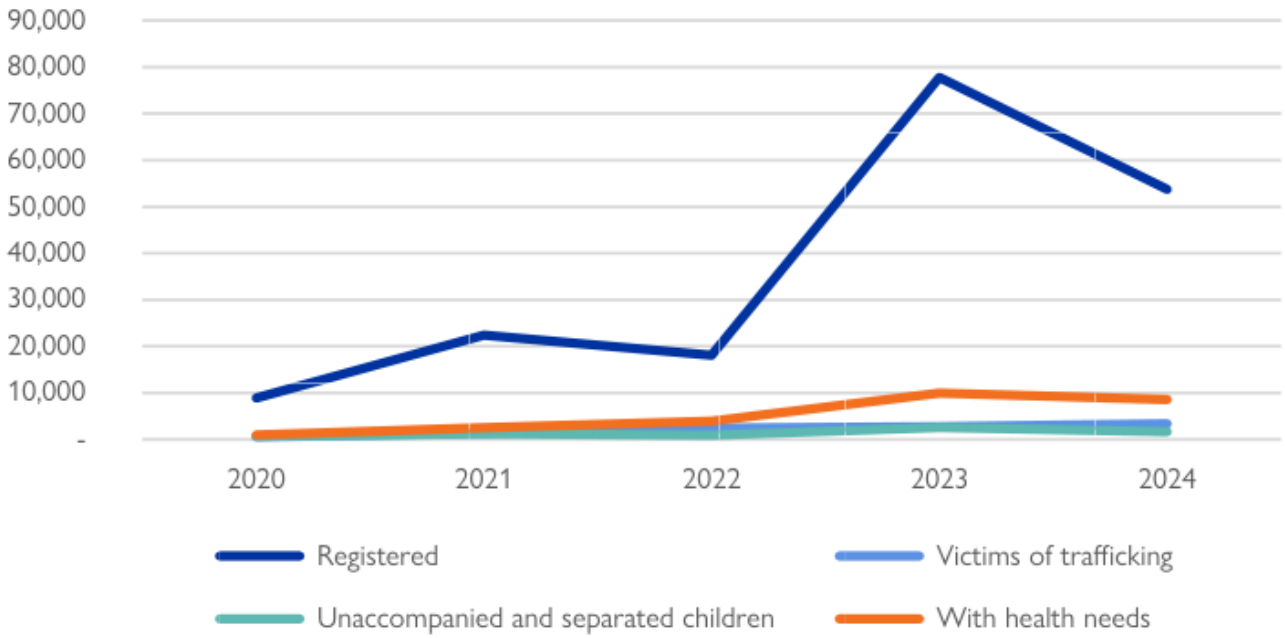


Exhibit. Figure 19. Migrants registered and assisted, by year — children on the move routes, 2020–2024. Source: S0028.

Climate migration: projections and scenarios

State of the art in climate migration modeling

Climate migration modeling is, in the World Bank’s own assessment, “a new but growing field” — and its methods form a ladder of increasing behavioural realism and increasing data hunger [16]. The bottom rung is **exposure mapping**: overlay a hazard on a population map and count who is in the way. The approach has been applied to sea-level rise, floods, multiple climate hazards, and combined climatic and non-climatic hazard sets, and it usefully illuminates “the potential risks to human populations” — but it “generally make[s] fairly simplistic assumptions about who will stay or go,” treating exposure as displacement [16].

The next rung grounds the stay-or-go decision in observed behaviour. Statistical studies model recent migration against environmental variables — the literature runs from Henry, Schoumaker and Beauchemin through Feng, Krueger and Oppenheimer to Gray and Wise — deriving climate coefficients that later models can carry forward, provided they “carefully control for known determinants of migration” and are supplemented by household field studies of how environmental change is actually perceived [16]. **Agent-based models** build the decision itself:

autonomous agents acting on attitudes, subjective norms and perceived capacity — the theory of planned behavior — parameterised from household surveys [16]. The Burkina Faso model lets agents weigh rainfall change within social networks, finding that gradual rainfall reductions produce the most migration when combined with social and governance change; the Thai Nang Rong model couples social modules (migration, household assets, networks) to land-use and crop-yield modules, finding farmers meeting climate variability with portfolio diversification that includes migration and remittances [16]. The approach's strength — "explicit modeling of micro-level demographic behavior based on theory and empirical evidence" — is also its limit: it needs rich local data, and it "typically produce[s] volumes of flows out of one location" without spatially precise destinations [16]. **System dynamics models** — IDMC's simulation of drought, flood and climate impacts on pastoralist displacement in northern Kenya is the exemplar — support "what if?" policy experiments but remain "in [their] early stages," while **radiation models**, introduced by Simini and colleagues in 2012, assume flows decay with distance and intervening opportunities, so movers take "the nearest suitable location rather than go farther to pursue similar opportunities" [16].

The field's production instrument is the **gravity model**, and Groundswell's implementation defines the current state of practice. Its logic is calibration by revealed sensitivity: the model is fitted on how actual population distributions shifted between 1990–2000 and 2000–2010 in response to deviations in water availability and crop productivity from long-term baselines, then assumes those sensitivities hold into the future, so climate impacts "directly affect the population potential of locations" [16]. Calibration found populations "most sensitive to historical deviations in water availability (in both rural and urban areas) followed by historical deviations in crop productivity," with crop productivity excluded from urban cells, whose residents are assumed less agriculture-dependent; drivers "may either act in concert… or they may offset each other" [16]. The machinery runs on CIESIN's Gridded Population of the World (v3 for 1990–2010, v4 for the 2010 baseline), aggregated to 7.5-arc-minute cells of about 196 km², and the input combinatorics are formidable — feeding all ISIMIP water and crop model outputs through the model would have meant 12,500 runs (2 RCPs × 5 GCMs × 25 crop outputs × 50 water outputs) [16].

The method's honesty about its own limits is part of the state of the art. Gravity models "do not directly model internal migration": climate migration is inferred as the deviation between population distributions in runs with climate impacts and development-only runs, an inference licensed by migration being "a 'fast' demographic variable" responsible for most decadal redistribution, and by assuming fertility and mortality do not differ systematically between movers and stayers [16]. Each scenario therefore yields "a range of estimates that reflect variation in the underlying inputs" — climate-model and development uncertainty propagated, not hidden [16]. And some places are simply excluded as unmodelable: climate migration was not modeled for the Middle East because conflict had destroyed the baseline — Syria's 2010 population of 21.4 million has since produced 6.6 million refugees and 6.7 million IDPs, Yemen's 23.2 million more than 4 million IDPs — while Libya was modeled because its 6.2 million people are concentrated in a few coastal cities and its distribution "has not changed significantly since the onset of the conflict" [16]. The model was validated against Mexico and Ethiopia [16]. The state of the art, in sum, is a division of labour: exposure maps bound the problem, statistical and agent-based studies establish that climate actually moves people and how they decide, and calibrated gravity models convert sectoral impact projections into spatially explicit population redistribution — with the field's frontier problems (behavioural realism at scale, conflict-corrupted baselines, uncertainty ranges that span orders of magnitude) stated in its own appendices.

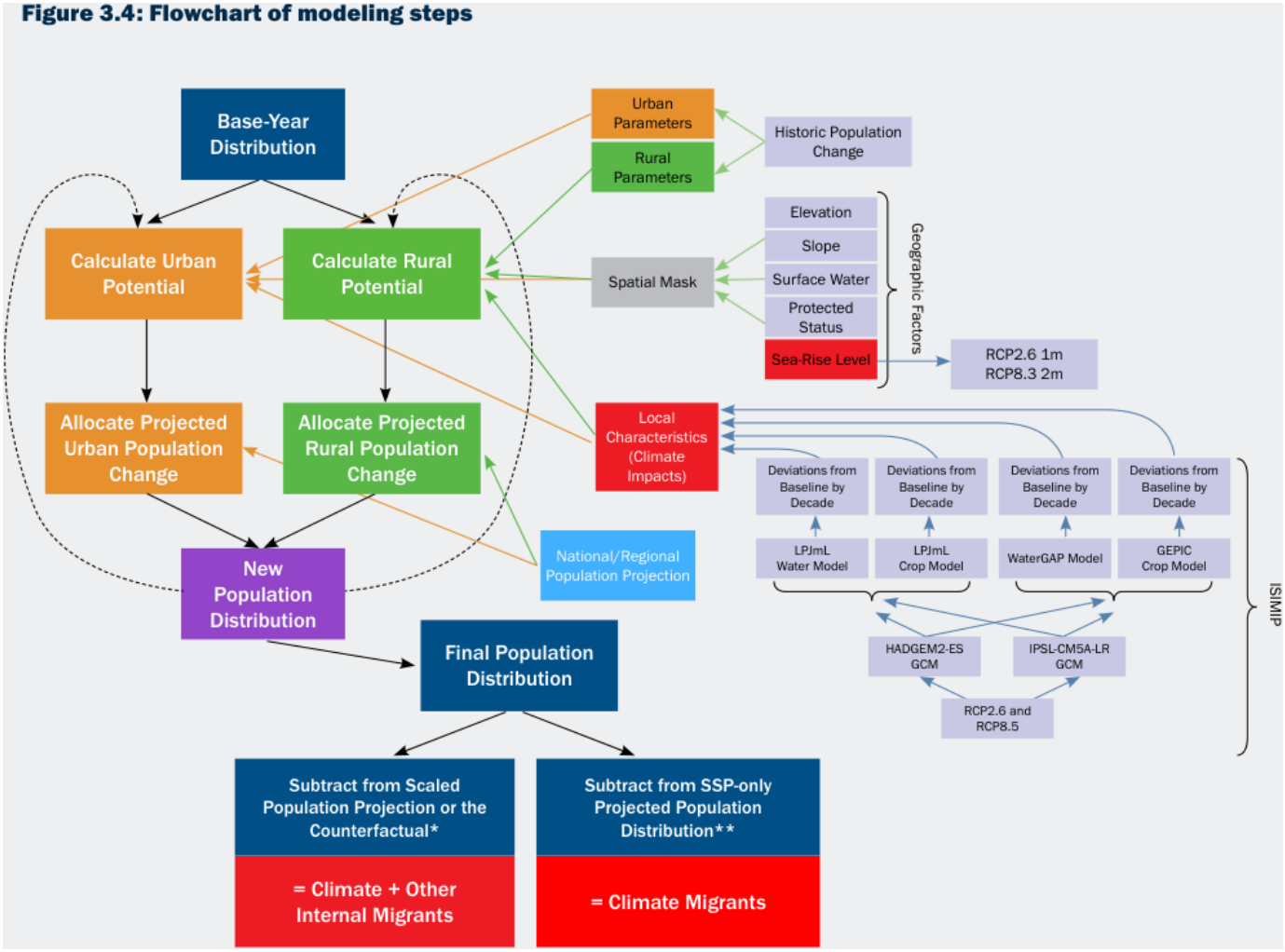


Exhibit. Steps "c" and "d" of the Groundswell modelling approach are illustrated for a hypothetical population distribution, showing how projected climate impacts are translated into spatial population redistribution. Source: S0006.

Shared socioeconomic pathways and scenario combinations

A projection of climate migration is two forecasts multiplied: how the climate changes, and how societies develop while it does. The Groundswell framework keeps the two apart by construction. Its development axis uses two Shared Socioeconomic Pathways — SSP2, "moderate development," and SSP4, "unequal development" — and its climate axis two Representative Concentration Pathways, RCP2.6 (low emissions) and RCP8.5 (high emissions), with climate impacts delivered as ISIMIP water and crop model results plus sea-level rise augmented by storm surge [16]. Climate migrants are then defined residually: for each grid cell, the population under a climate-impact scenario is compared with the same development pathway run without climate impacts, and "the positive difference across all grid cells [is] aggregated to the national level (and then regional) to produce the estimated number of climate migrants" — areas inundated by sea-level rise and storm surge are masked out entirely, so no one can move into them [16].

Only three of the four possible combinations are run, and the omission is the design's argument. The **pessimistic reference** scenario pairs high emissions with unequal development (RCP8.5/SSP4); **more inclusive development** holds emissions high but swaps in the moderate pathway (RCP8.5/SSP2); **more climate-friendly** holds development unequal but cuts emissions (RCP2.6/SSP4) [16]. Each lever is thus varied one at a time against the pessimistic corner, so the differences between scenarios attribute outcomes to development policy or to emissions policy separately. The low-emissions-plus-moderate-development corner — the world where both levers are pulled — is never modelled, a conservatism worth noting when the results are read as bounds. Uncertainty is carried openly: each scenario's estimate is an ensemble mean whose whiskers mark the 95th percentile confidence interval across its four model runs, the intervals deliberately wide because "climate and sectoral models were selected to represent the widest possible range of outcomes," while "other" (non-climate) migrants carry no interval at all, since each scenario uses a single development trajectory [3].

The country results show the two levers doing different work. For Bangladesh, climate migrants rise under every scenario but diverge sharply by 2050 as a share of population: 7.53 per cent under the pessimistic reference, 3.43 per cent under more inclusive development, and 2.02 per cent under the more climate-friendly pathway — and only in the pessimistic case do climate migrants come to outpace other internal migrants, elsewhere settling at "a third to a half of other internal migrants" [3]. The trajectories also bend: numbers trend upward in the final modelled decade under both high-emissions scenarios, "reflect[ing] the more pronounced climate impacts expected in the second half of the century," while the low-emissions scenario's increase runs slower [3].

Mexico isolates the development lever. The pessimistic reference projects 1.7 million climate migrants by 2050 (range 0.3–3.1 million); the more climate-friendly scenario 1.4 million (0.2–2.5 million); and more inclusive development the fewest, 1.2 million (0.4–1.9 million) — lowest "despite the higher population projections under the more inclusive development scenario," from which the report concludes that in "a middle-to-high income country like Mexico, development policies and targeted interventions that strengthen adaptive capacity play an important role in reducing climate migration" [3]. But the same scenario's numbers "begin to trend upward... towards 2040, when more pronounced climate impacts start to set in," so development buys time rather than exemption: policy "must also be accompanied by action on emissions reductions" [3]. The framework is applied across six regions — with deeper subregional analysis for East Africa, the Lower Mekong, South Asia, North Africa, Mexico and Central America, and Central Asia — and six narrative country cases: Ethiopia, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Morocco, Mexico and the Kyrgyz Republic [16]. Read together, the combinations make the report's central policy claim testable rather than rhetorical: emissions determine how hard the climate pushes, development determines how many people must answer by moving — and because the two multiply, neither lever alone reaches the low-migration corner the scenario set deliberately leaves unmodelled.

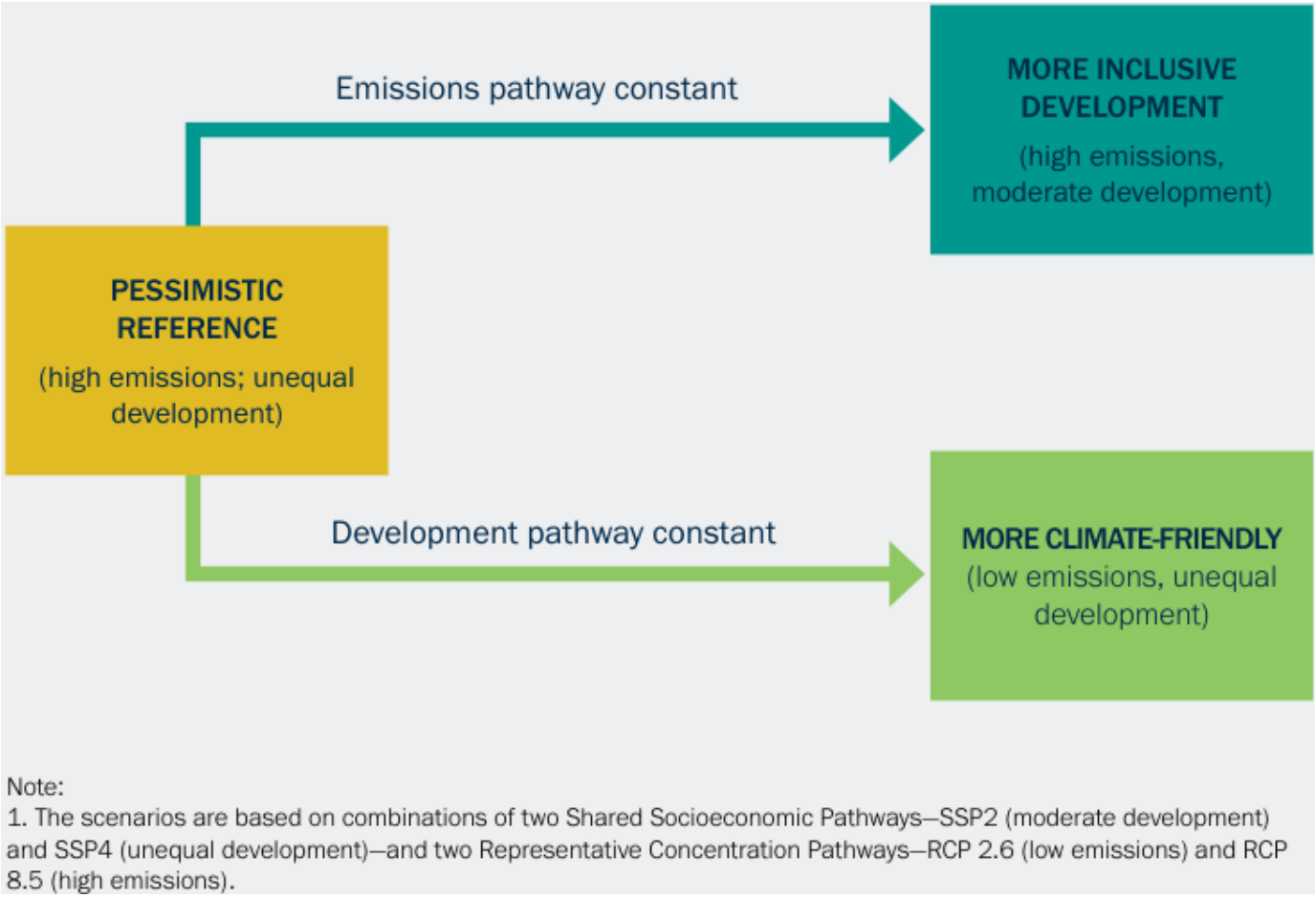


Exhibit. Internal climate migration is projected under three scenarios combining emissions pathways and development trajectories — a pessimistic reference, a more inclusive development path, and a climate-friendly path — showing how scenario choice drives projected mig. Source: S0006.

Projected numbers and spatial patterns of climate migrants

The combined Groundswell results give the field's canonical headline: "by 2050, as many as 216 million people could be internal climate migrants across the six World Bank regions (at the high end of the pessimistic reference

scenario),” almost 3 per cent of those regions’ projected population [16]. The distribution is steeply unequal. Sub-Saharan Africa contributes the largest number — up to 85.7 million (4.2 per cent of its population), a product of near-total dependence on rainfed agriculture and vulnerability “in already fragile drylands and along exposed coastlines”; East Asia and the Pacific follow at 48.4 million (2.5 per cent) and South Asia at 40.5 million (1.8 per cent); North Africa’s 19.3 million is the largest share of any region at 9.0 per cent of population, “due to a great extent to severe water scarcity, as well as the impacts of sea-level rise on densely populated coastal areas and in the Nile Delta”; Latin America projects 17.1 million (2.6 per cent) and Eastern Europe and Central Asia 5.1 million (2.3 per cent) [16]. The report’s gloss on the geography is explicit: “the scale of internal climate migration will be largest in the poorest and most climate-vulnerable regions,” threatening development gains where coping capacity is thinnest [16].

The spatial patterns complicate any simple flight-from-the-coast story. In the Lower Mekong, projected in-migration hotspots include the Malay Peninsula in southern Thailand, the inner Mekong Delta at higher elevations adjacent to out-migration hotspots, coastal eastern Vietnam, the Red River Delta including Hanoi, an area southeast of Phnom Penh, and southern Myanmar around Hinthada and along the Irrawaddy [16]. Several coastal hotspots “coincide with areas projected to see increases in water availability across multiple models,” while the Cambodian and Myanmar hotspots gain on both water and crops — producing the pattern the modellers flag for planners: “better water availability may attract people to areas that also face heightened risks from sea-level rise and extreme weather events, including tropical cyclones” [16]. Disaggregated by livelihood zone, the Mekong flows are small against their uncertainty: rice-growing areas show a central projection of just over 550,000 net in-migrants by 2050 under the pessimistic scenario “but projections range from negative 590,000 to positive 1.7 million”; seminatural and wildlands centre on net negative 575,000 with a range from −1.5 million to +350,000; and the only zone whose interval does not cross zero is rainfed croplands under the climate-friendly scenario, at about +290,000 [16]. Dense settlements show small negative net climate migration across all three scenarios [16].

Mexico’s map, from the first Groundswell report, shows the urbanward tilt: “large climate in-migration hotspots in the central plateau near Mexico City and to the east of Puebla,” smaller ones in Oaxaca and on Baja California’s northern coast, against out-migration hotspots “scattered across the arid north,” concentrated on the Gulf coasts of Veracruz and Tabasco, in Chiapas, and on the Pacific coast in Guerrero [3]. Hotspot status itself is a consensus measure — high certainty where all three scenarios agree, moderate where two do, on density changes in the top tenth percentile (for Mexico and Central America, roughly +3.3 to +6.8 people per km² for in-migration, −1.8 to −3 for out-migration) [3]. The livelihood flows run from rainfed croplands — “likely to have the most climate out-migrants, mainly as a result of declining productivity in rainfall-dependent cropping areas” — toward peri-urban and urban locations and irrigated croplands, but the magnitudes discipline the drama: “generally no greater than plus or minus 300,000, or less than 0.2 percent of Mexico’s 2050 population,” with even a hypothetical exodus of all 200,000 climate migrants from Mexico City amounting to “no more than one percent of the population” of a megalopolis above 20 million [3]. The central plateau’s pull comes with a caveat the maps make visible: it “may face water shortage challenges if water management systems are not improved” for the arrivals [3].

Three interpretive rules emerge from the numbers and maps together. First, scale lives at the regional level — hundreds of millions in aggregate, single-digit percentages almost everywhere — while livelihood-zone and city-level flows are small and interval-bound, often sign-ambiguous. Second, the dominant direction is rural-to-urban and dry-to-watered, not coast-to-inland: water availability, the model’s most sensitive variable, pulls people toward some of the very coasts that sea-level rise threatens. Third, the projections describe redistribution pressure, not destiny — they are differences between modelled distributions under stated scenarios, and the next chapters’ regional hotspots inherit both their geography and their error bars.

Figure 5.8: Projected net climate migration in and out of livelihood zones in Ethiopia under three scenarios, 2020–50

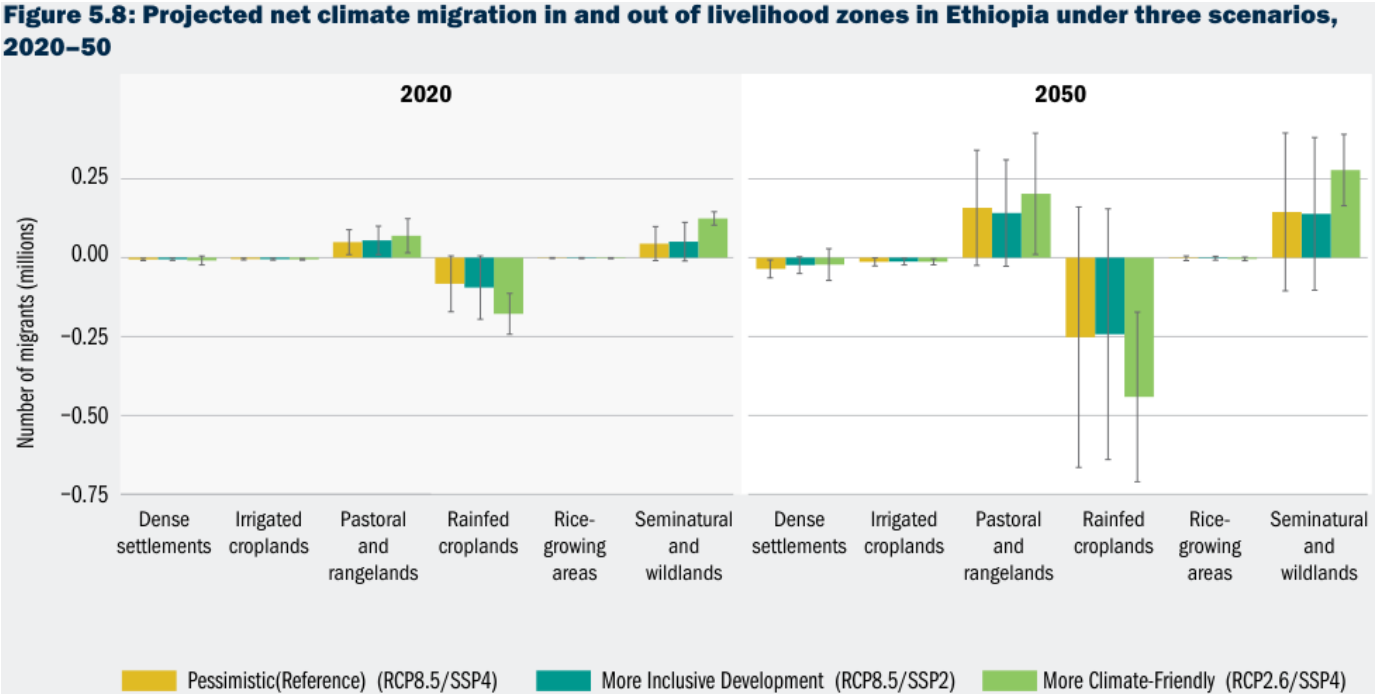


Exhibit. Projected net climate migration into and out of Ethiopia's livelihood zones between 2020 and 2050 is mapped under three scenarios, revealing which zones gain and which lose population as climate pressures intensify. Source: S0006.

Regional hotspots: Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia, Latin America, North Africa

The first Groundswell report modelled three of the six regions in depth, and its regional arithmetic sets the hotspot geography. Under the pessimistic reference scenario, "up to 143.3 million people or 2.8 percent of the population of Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia and Latin America could be internal climate migrants" by 2050 — and the figure is explicitly a floor, since the analysis is "limited to climate-induced migration within countries in three regions and has a focus on slow-onset climate impacts (water availability, crop productivity, and sea level rise) rather than on rapid-onset events such as floods and hurricanes," making the results "lower-bound estimates of the likely overall impact" [3].

Sub-Saharan Africa carries the largest burden on every measure: 56.6 to 85.7 million internal climate migrants by 2050 under the pessimistic scenario, "an average of 3.5 percent of the region's total population, which is more than twice the proportion of the other two regions" [3]. The report assigns the exposure to two structural facts: the region "is highly vulnerable to climate impacts, especially in already fragile drylands and along exposed coastlines," and its agriculture "depends on rainfall for almost all its crop production" while employing a significant share of the labour force — so the model's most sensitive variable, water availability, strikes the region's dominant livelihood directly [3]. East Africa is the report's subregional deep-dive, and its cities illustrate the hotspot duality: large urban centres such as Addis Ababa "will need to balance climate out-migration against broader trends of population growth" through long-term planning and adaptive-capacity investment [3].

South Asia projects 30.9 to 40.5 million internal climate migrants by 2050 under the pessimistic scenario, 1.6 per cent of the region's population, with the distribution dominated by a single country: "Bangladesh, which is very densely populated and highly exposed to climate risks, accounts for almost one-third of the region's total climate migrants" [3]. Dhaka, like Addis Ababa, is named as a city that must plan for simultaneous climate out-migration pressure and aggregate population growth [3] — the scenario chapter's finding that climate migrants could reach 7.5 per cent of Bangladesh's population under the pessimistic combination, outnumbering other internal migrants, is the national expression of the regional hotspot.

Latin America is the smallest of the three in both number and share: 4.3 to 17.1 million by 2050, an average of 1.6 per cent of population, with the report attributing the lower figures to "generally stronger economies in the region with higher adaptive capacity and less reliance on climate sensitive sectors, with some exceptions in the low-income countries in Central America" [3]. The Mexico and Central America subregion — the plateau in-migration and Gulf-coast out-migration patterns mapped in the projections chapter — is where the region's hotspots concentrate.

North Africa, modelled in the second report, inverts the ranking: a mid-sized absolute number (19.3 million) but the largest population share of any region at 9.0 per cent, driven by severe water scarcity and sea-level rise against dense coastal settlement and the Nile Delta.

Across all four, the hotspot dynamics are consistent. In- and out-migration hotspots "emerge by 2030, and by 2050, the scenarios increasingly converge on their growing number, intensity, and spatial extent"; out-migration concentrates where livelihoods fail — "low-lying cities, coastlines vulnerable to sea level rise, and areas of high water and agriculture stress" — while in-migration gathers "in locations with better climatic conditions for agriculture as well as cities able to provide better livelihood opportunities," with major cities in all three first-report regions projected as in-migration hotspots as declining crop productivity pushes people along existing rural-to-urban pathways [3]. Two qualifications frame the maps: vulnerable areas "will continue to support significant numbers of people" even where out-migration is projected — hotspots are margins, not evacuations — and the projections "do not consider technological advances or adaptation and development responses that might allow cities or rural areas to sustain larger populations" [3]. Finally, the scenario spread is itself the policy finding at regional scale: across the three regions, more inclusive development cuts the pessimistic total to between 65.1 and 105.3 million, and the more climate-friendly pathway to between 31.2 and 71.7 million — "reductions of up to 80 percent of the pessimistic reference scenario," with the largest declines in Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia [3]. The hotspots are where those reductions would have to be earned.

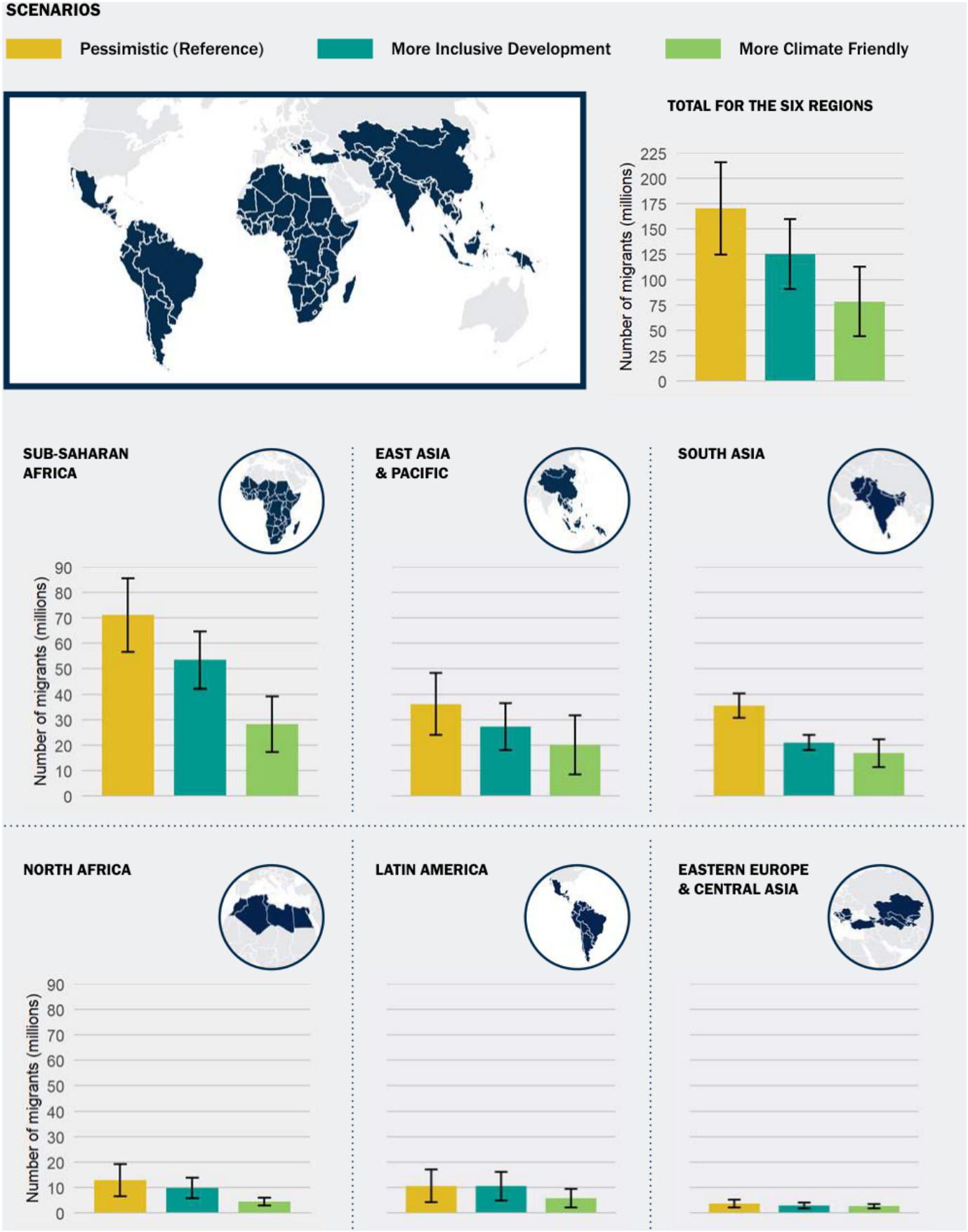


Exhibit. Projected internal climate migrants by 2050 are compared across six world regions under pessimistic, more inclusive development, and more climate-friendly scenarios, with Sub-Saharan Africa contributing the largest numbers. Source: S0005.

Water and crop models behind the projections

Every number in the projections chapters is, at one remove, a statement about rivers and harvests. The gravity model does not ingest climate directly; it ingests two sectoral impact streams produced by the Inter-Sectoral Impact

Model Intercomparison Project (ISIMIP), converted into a common currency of local attractiveness. The water models output river discharge, "measured in cubic meters per second in daily/monthly time increments"; the crop models output yield "in tons per hectare on an annual time step at a 0.5° x 0.5° grid cell resolution," for four crops — maize, wheat, rice and soybeans — with regions that have multiple cropping cycles represented by "only the major crop production period" [3]. A third impact, sea-level rise, enters as a mask rather than an index: rise augmented by storm surge of 0.85–0.9 metres under RCP2.6 and 1.68–1.85 metres under RCP8.5, on Church et al. (2013) figures [16].

The conversion to model inputs is indexation against a remembered climate. Both streams are reduced to decadal averages per grid cell, then expressed as deviations from "the 40-year average for water availability and crop productivity for 1970–2010" — so an index of 0.2 means 20 per cent above the baseline average and −0.6 means 60 per cent below [3]. The crop stream carries a known fiction, disclosed in the method: the models report "'pure crop yields'... (that is, they assume that a given crop is grown everywhere, irrespective of growing conditions or the location where crops are actually grown)," which are then multiplied by observation-based 2005 growing areas, separately for rainfed and irrigated production, to obtain grid-cell tonnage [3]. What the gravity model responds to is thus not yield at a farm but production potential reweighted by where farming actually happens — appropriate for measuring livelihood pressure, and one more modelling layer between the climate signal and the migration estimate.

The ensemble is deliberately small and deliberately diverse. Two global climate models — HadGEM2-ES and IPSL-CM5A-LR — driven by the two emissions pathways drive two water models (LPJmL and WaterGAP2) and two crop models (LPJmL and GEPIC), and the four resulting runs per scenario are averaged into an ensemble mean [16]. The sectoral models were "selected based on several criteria, including model performance over the historical period, diversity of model structure, diversity of signals of future change, and availability of both observationally driven historical (ISIMIP2a) and global climate model-driven historical and future (ISIMIP fast-track) simulations" [16]. The reduction was a computational necessity — the full ISIMIP menu would have required 12,500 gravity-model runs — but diversity of signal was a scientific choice: in East Africa the selected models' precipitation trends "differ substantially in magnitude, and partly even in sign," in a region where projections "appear to contradict evidence of current drying" [3]. The ensemble spread is therefore not noise around a consensus; in places it is the finding.

The same sectoral machinery, run past the reports' 2050 horizon, supplies the projections' most sobering footnote. Comparing 2050–2100 impacts against the 1970–2010 baseline, "impacts will be more severe, further strengthening the conditions for increased climate migration," so the modelled decades "may be just a starting point for much greater flows in the second half of the century" [3]. The regional signatures diverge by sector: in East Africa late-century water availability is "not markedly worse" than 2010–50 on average — though averages hide the variability and extremes the literature expects — while crop productivity projections are "significantly worse," with large areas under RCP8.5 seeing steep declines; in South Asia water increases across broad areas but declines in Afghanistan, northeastern Pakistan and northwestern India under the IPSL scenario, while the GEPIC crop model shows "much of India will see sharp declines in crop productivity" late-century under RCP8.5; and in Mexico and Central America both water and crops deteriorate sharply under high emissions, "consistent with the extreme drought conditions projected by Dai (2012) by the end of the century under RCP8.5" [3]. The water and crop models are thus where the migration projections' two deepest properties originate: their sensitivity ordering (water first, crops second — a calibration result from these very indices) and their honesty problem, since every downstream figure inherits the sectoral ensemble's spread, its sign disagreements, and its baseline fiction of a crop grown everywhere.

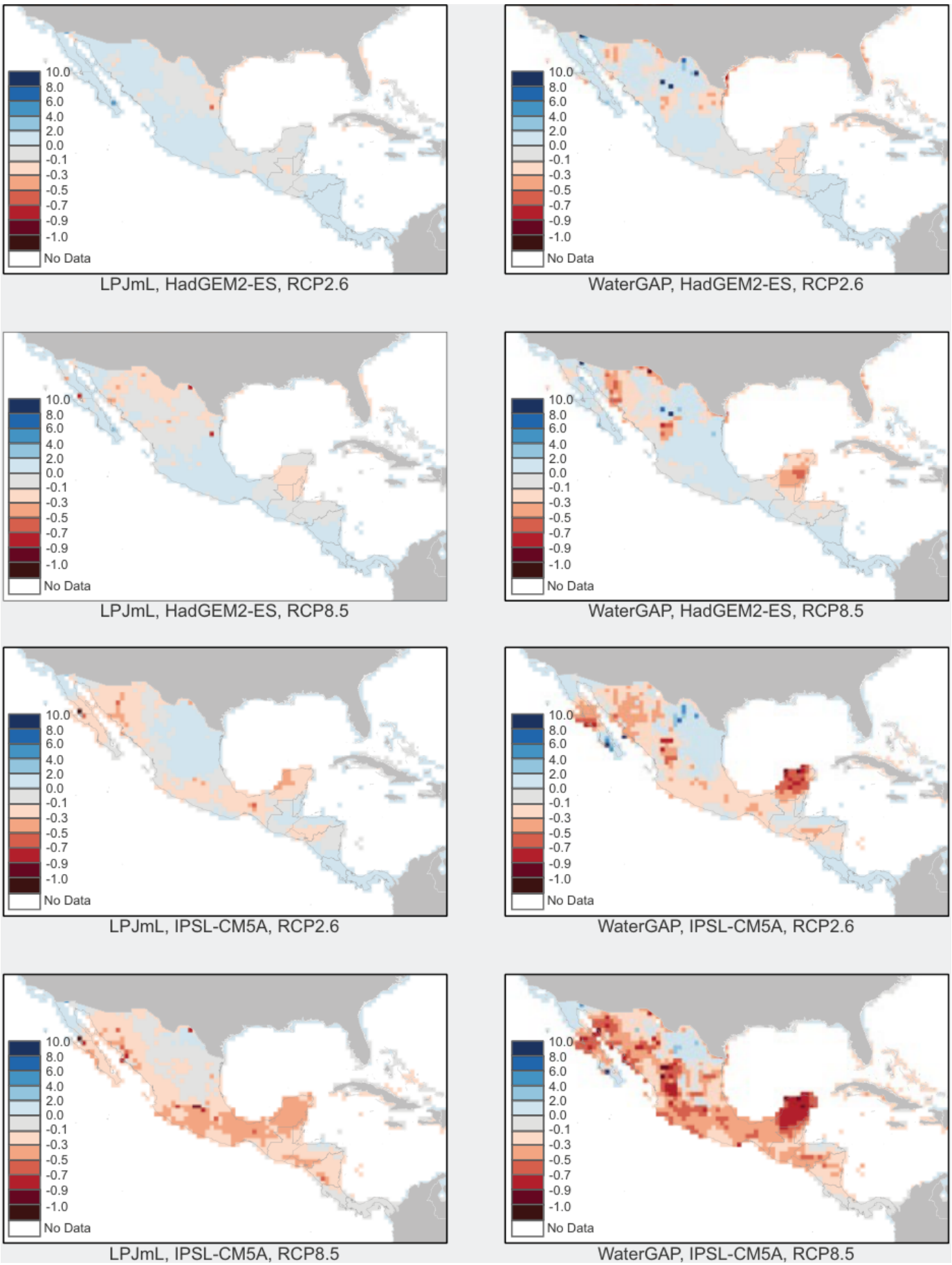


Exhibit. Average index values for water availability during 2010–2050 against a 1970–2010 baseline are mapped from two hydrological models forced by two climate models, showing how model choice shapes projected water scarcity. Source: S0006.

Labor mobility and the economics of migration

Labor mobility partnerships and managed migration corridors

If the wage gradient documented earlier in this report is the world's largest unexploited arbitrage, labour mobility partnerships are the attempt to trade it deliberately: bilateral or multilateral arrangements that train, certify and move workers along managed corridors, splitting the gains among destination employers, origin countries and the movers themselves. The attempt is newer than its rhetoric. The Center for Global Development's working group on connecting international labour markets found a policy field whose "dialogue has not caught up to the scale of the need": attention has concentrated on whether mobility should be "more" or "less," leaving "a very limited evidence base on 'how'" [11]. The basic instruments are barely catalogued — until recently there was no database of bilateral labour agreements at all, and when the ILO surveyed in 2015 it "was able to identify 358 BLAs but was able to find copies of only 144 of those agreements," so practitioners lacked even reference texts for the agreements they were meant to imitate [11]. The diagnostic capacity underneath is thinner still: a Global Forum on Migration and Development business review of five Latin American receiving countries found they lacked "the accurate national statistical capacity required to analyze skill shortages," with national skill policies "scant," of "reduced industry coverage," and reliant on out-of-date data [11].

The Migration Policy Institute's study of employment- and skills-based pilot projects shows where the economics bite: training. "The choice of sector and skills level carries significant implications for the costs of a program," because meeting destination requirements — above all in regulated professions — demands language and vocational preparation that "can take months (or even years)" [20]. The healthcare corridor is the canonical case: "migrants recruited to work as nurses in other countries typically take on a more junior role (e.g., as nursing assistants) while they acquire the host-country language proficiency and fill any gaps in training to sit licensing examinations" — the pattern in Finland's Opteam recruitment of Filipino nurses and in Japan's JPEPA programme, where Filipino nurses work as aides through up to a year of language training before the Japanese licensing examination [20]. Underemployment during that interval is not a side effect but a central design risk: it "can not only deter migrants from participating, but it can result in a significant loss of earnings in the long run" — the brain waste that the next section takes up [20].

The cost problem has one proven mitigation, and it is the intellectual core of the partnership model: move the training to the worker. Filipino nurses recruited to Japan "receive part of their language training in the Philippines, capitalizing on both the quality of training delivered by the Philippines' Technical Education Skills Development Authority and the cost savings compared to delivering the same training in Japan" — and "[t]his cost differential underpins the logic for the 'global skills partnership' model set out in the 2018 Global Compact," in which destination countries finance training in origin countries for both movers and stayers [20]. Even so, "program costs may remain high, especially when providers need to tailor curricula extensively or bring in specialist trainers from destination countries," and the financing settlement is unsettled: upfront costs of travel, accommodation and predeparture training are "usually covered by the destination-country government or other actor(s) responsible for administering the project," migrants sometimes bearing a small share such as airfare — making "[f]inding a way to distribute these costs equitably and sustainably… a top priority, especially if policymakers intend to extend or scale up these programs" [20]. Oversight is the other standing condition: the same study's framing insists it is "vital for governments to monitor private-sector actors' activities closely, so as to prevent potential exploitation or abuse" inside the corridors [20].

Around these pilots an institutional ecosystem has formed — the EU's Talent Partnerships and its pilot projects on legal migration, ILO programmes on labour-mobility governance in North Africa (THAMM), Germany's Triple Win nurse-recruitment scheme, and the Australia-Pacific Training Coalition in the Pacific [14] [20] — and the green transition has given the model a new sectoral frontier, with CGD mapping projects that link green-skilled training to migration for the energy transition's workforce gaps [14]. The honest summary of the state of practice is the CGD working group's: the corridor idea is sound, the demand on both ends is documented, and the binding constraints are unglamorous — missing agreement texts, missing shortage statistics, training costs that sink pilots before they scale, and cost-sharing rules nobody has yet standardised. Partnerships remain, in scale, a rounding error against the flows the rest of this report describes; whether they stay one depends on solving the accounting, not the concept.

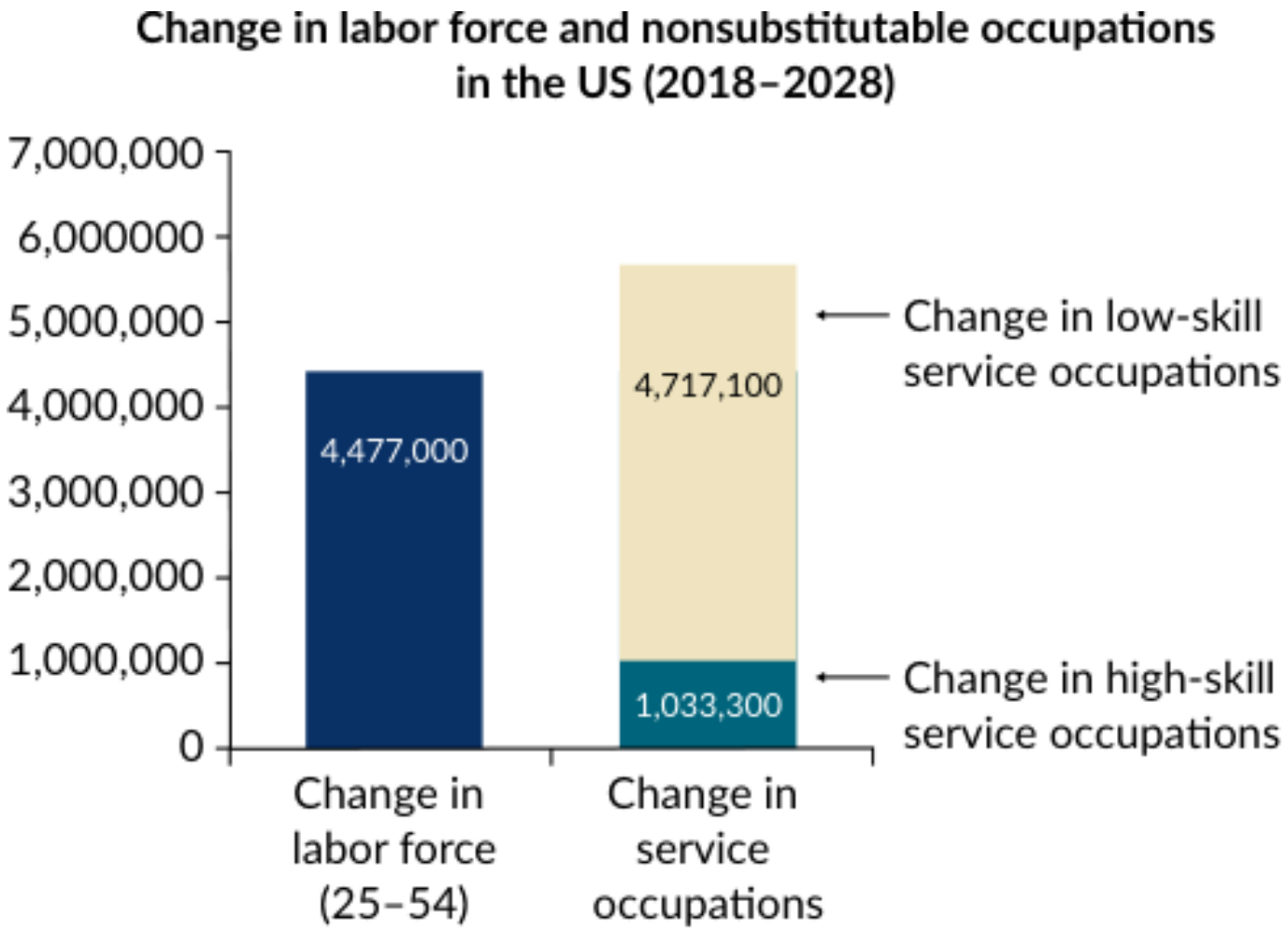


Exhibit. Changes in the United States labour force and in nonsubstitutable occupations between 2018 and 2028 illustrate the domestic workforce gaps that labour mobility partnerships are designed to help fill. Source: S0007.

Skills, training, and brain drain

"Brain drain" names the fear that skilled emigration is a zero-sum transfer: the destination gains a nurse or an engineer, the origin loses one it paid to train. The contemporary evidence reframes the problem as a stock problem rather than a flow problem. In the green transition — the sector where the training-and-migration model is now being tested hardest — "there is a global skills shortage in sectors critical to delivering the green transition, estimated to rise to six million workers in the next five years," spanning general roles such as sustainable construction and seasonal agriculture and specialists such as heat pump installers and solar panel technicians, with shortages "already causing delays to project timelines, restricting the growth of sectors key to climate change mitigation and meeting net zero targets" [14]. Pure recruitment into high-income countries cannot close that gap equitably, because it "may deprive low- and middle-income countries of the skilled labour they need to achieve their own green transition goals. What is needed, therefore, is a global increase in the stock of green-skilled workers" [14].

Linking training to migration is the mechanism for growing the stock instead of reallocating it. The model family — Skills Mobility Partnerships as the umbrella term, Global Skill Partnerships delivering a "dual track" of training in the origin country with some trainees moving and others staying, and the EU's Talent Partnerships consolidating programming in target countries including Tunisia, Morocco, Egypt, Bangladesh and Pakistan — claims three benefits "over and above pure recruitment": the schemes "increase the global stock of workers, thereby reducing the risk of 'brain drain'"; they "guarantee a pipeline of skilled workers for countries of destination, particularly from markets with a large supply of young labour"; and they "facilitate credential and skill recognition, as employers and governments come together to co-design curricula which can meet international standards" [14]. Demand for the model is documented: a 2022 survey found pairing migration with development cooperation "becoming an increasing priority for European countries," interested in legal pathways "while facilitating international skill and diploma recognition, mitigating against 'brain drain', and preventing labour market distortions" [14]. The constraints are equally documented — the projects are "often complex (due to the number of stakeholders involved); costly (due to the necessary foundational capacity-building for migration systems and relationships, and training alignment)," factors "inhibiting

the ability of these projects to scale," and an analysis of EU initiatives concluded that "'no universal good practice exists … all schemes and mechanisms are differently challenged by bureaucracy, cultural constraints, private sector's mistrust or public sector's rigidity'" [14].

The World Development Report supplies the origin-country half of the doctrine. Emigration's effects on the sender — remittances, knowledge flows, human-capital incentives against the loss of scarce professionals, felt most sharply in "smaller and poorer countries" — are "neither preset nor uniform," and "[o]rigin countries can shape these impacts for their own development" [8]. Its headline recommendation is to "[m]ake emigration part of development strategies," with dedicated institutions where scale warrants [8]. The Philippines is the worked example: successive governments have made labour migration "an integral part of the country's development strategy," the 2017–2022 development plan aiming to mainstream migration and support return, the 2023–2028 plan turning to "returning migrants' reentry into the economy" and the social impacts of emigration, including "health and psychosocial services to migrants and their children," with the Philippine Overseas Employment Administration and the Overseas Workers Welfare Administration "recently consolidated into a single Department of Migrant Workers" [8]. Bangladesh built the parallel institution in 2001 — a Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment charged with strategic planning for regular and temporary labour migration and providing information campaigns and skills training, backed by migration attaché offices in major destination countries [8].

The bilateral layer completes the argument. Left to individual choices and "aggressive brokers," labour migration mismatches skills to needs; "[w]hen countries with surpluses in certain sectors and skill sets are matched with countries with shortages, there can be great benefits," yet "migration policy has often been designed and implemented unilaterally by destination countries," the EU's internal free-mobility scheme the standing exception [8]. The report's prescription — structure movement through bilateral labour agreements, and "enhance skills match through skills recognition and skills development" — is precisely the partnership agenda of the previous section restated as general policy [8]. Brain drain, on this account, is not a law of migration but a symptom of its unmanaged form: where training expands the stock, recognition keeps skills usable across borders, and origin states govern emigration as strategy rather than enduring it as leakage, the drain becomes circulation.



Exhibit. Approaches to candidate targeting across projects linking green-skilled training with migration vary widely, with private-led projects selecting more highly skilled candidates who had often already completed training or held work experience. Source: S0020.

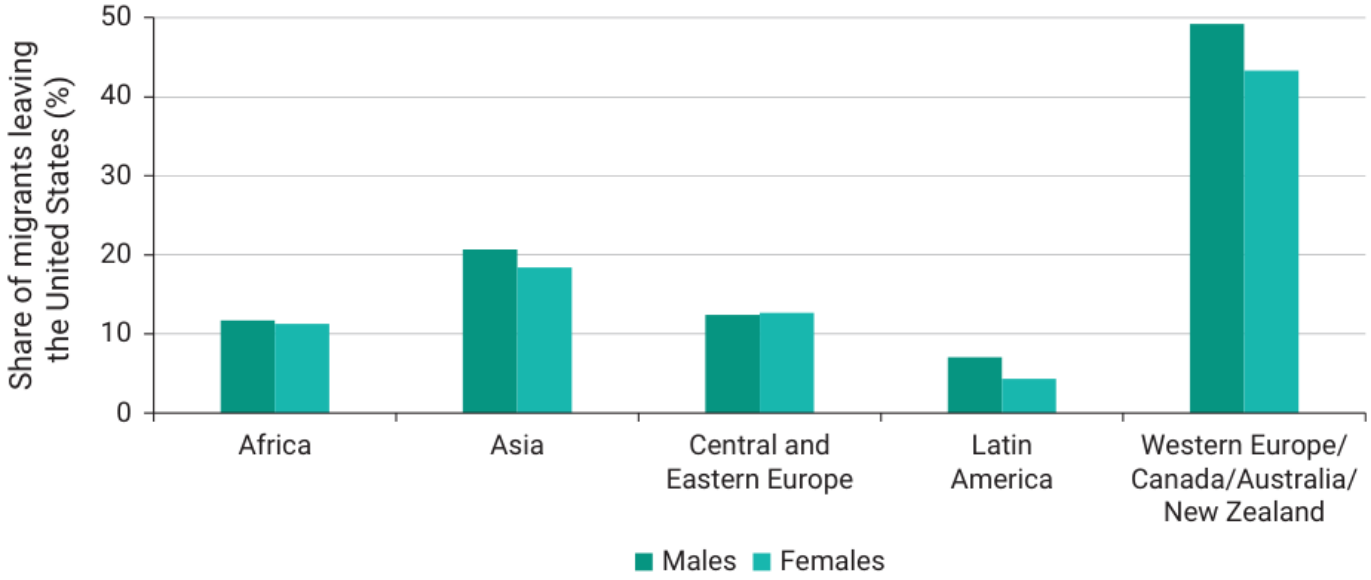
Wage gains for movers

The private return to crossing a border is the largest well-documented payoff in development economics, and it accrues to the mover personally. The Human Development Report's commissioned research "found large differences in income between stayers and movers to OECD countries, with the biggest differences for those moving from low-HDI countries": migrant workers in the United States "earn about four times as much as they would in their developing countries of origin," and Pacific Islanders in New Zealand "increased their net real wages by a factor of three" [4]. The World Development Report's comparison sharpens the point about which border matters: in Bangladesh, Ghana and India, "income gains from international migration are many times greater than those from internal migration" — the same worker, the same effort, a different jurisdiction [8]. Its companion calculation converts the gap into time: decades of economic growth in the origin country would be needed for non-migrants to reach the income level that movers to high-income countries achieve by moving [8].

The gains are not an OECD artefact, nor confined to the low-skilled: the wage-gradient cases among the drivers — seasonal workers, engineers, doctors — span the full skill range. They also compound over time: "[e]vidence from a range of countries suggests that income gains increase over time, as the acquisition of language skills leads to better integration in the labour market" [4].

Three qualifications keep the averages honest. First, distribution: "these average gains are unevenly distributed, and the costs of moving also detract from the gross gains" — recruitment fees, travel, and the junior-role intervals documented in the partnerships chapter all come off the headline multiple [4]. Second, the destination side is structural, not incidental: CGD's labour-market analysis notes that US prime-age labour force growth projected for 2018–2028 (about 4.48 million) falls short of the growth in low-skilled nonsubstitutable service jobs alone (about 4.72 million) — occupations that by definition cannot be offshored or automated — which is the demand pull that sustains the premium [11]. Third, intention shapes realisation: worldwide, "an estimated 40 percent of all migrants eventually return to their country of origin," nearly all Gulf migrants return because their migration "is temporary by design," and in OECD countries "between 20 and 50 percent of immigrants leave their destination within five to 10 years"; movers who expect to return "have stronger incentives" inverted — they invest less in destination-specific human and social capital, accept lower wages in consequence, but save and remit at higher rates than intending settlers [8].

Set against the report's other magnitudes, the wage gain is the engine and the explanation. It is why rationed access converts into scarcity rents worth thousands of dollars per crossing, why households finance moves as portfolio decisions, why a season in Russia can capitalise a family in Dushanbe, and why the flows persist at volumes far below what the differential alone would predict — the subject the remittances chapter now follows home, tracing what portion of the gain is sent back, at what price, and to what effect.

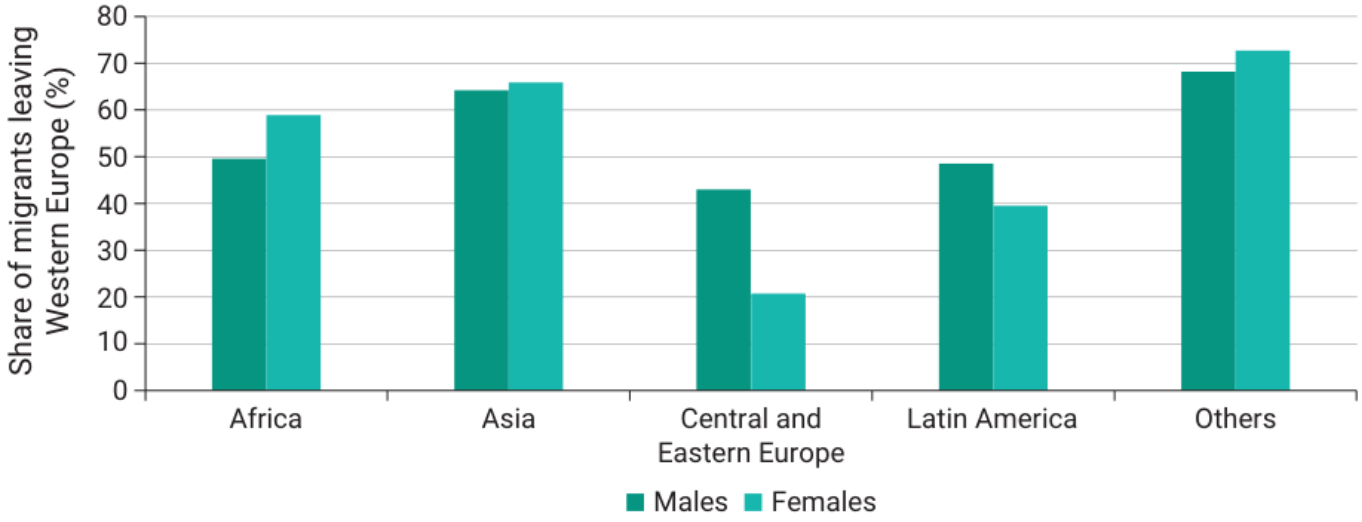


Source: Bossavie and Özden 2022, based on data from American Community Survey (dashboard), US Census Bureau, Suitland, MD, https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs.

Note: OECD = Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development.

Figure 4.10 Many migrants to Western Europe return to their country of origin, but less so women from Eastern Europe

Percentage of migrants leaving Western Europe, by gender and region of origin



Source: Bossavie and Özden 2022, based on data from Employment and Unemployment (LFS): Overview (European Union Labour Force Survey, Overview) (dashboard), Eurostat, European Commission, Luxembourg, https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/lfs.

Exhibit. Percentages of migrants leaving Western Europe are shown by gender and region of origin, revealing that many migrants eventually return home but that women from Eastern Europe are notably less likely to do so. Source: S0010.

Remittances: flows, costs, and development impact

Remittances are the portion of the wage gain that goes home — $656 billion to low- and middle-income countries in 2023, the largest external finance flow most of them receive. The World Development Report's summary of their development mechanics is compact: remittances "reduce poverty by enabling investments in health, education, and entrepreneurship; providing insurance against income shocks; and increasing recipient households' access to formal financial markets," and "[i]n countries where they account for a relatively large share of income, remittances contribute to macroeconomic stability and reduce fluctuations" [8]. The regional anatomy matters as much as the total. In the Middle East and North Africa, Egypt is the largest recipient in dollar terms at $27.5 billion in 2023, ahead of Morocco ($19.5 billion) and Lebanon ($18.8 billion), while the dependence ranking inverts — Lebanon and the West Bank and Gaza carry the largest shares of GDP [12].

The country detail from the World Bank/KNOMAD Migration and Development Brief shows the flows behaving like what they are: wage income earned in foreign labour markets, transmitted through family obligation. In East Asia and the Pacific, the Philippines — the region's largest recipient after China — saw flows grow only 2.8 per cent to $39 billion in 2023, muted because "[t]ourism recovered to pre-pandemic levels in the Philippines, giving Filipinos domestic employment opportunities as an alternative to emigration" [12]. Indonesia's remittances grew over 10 per cent to almost $14.5 billion, Vietnam's over 6 per cent to $14 billion, and Cambodia's 6 per cent to $2.8 billion, their migrants "benefitt[ing] from the recovery in manufactured goods exports in China, Malaysia, and Thailand," while Myanmar's fell 13 per cent to $1.1 billion and Mongolia's a reported 30 per cent to $280 million [12]. The brief's causal account runs through destination labour markets: "record-low unemployment rates in the United States paired with wage hikes contributed positively to remittances," tight OECD and Gulf labour markets raised migrants' savings, while shrinking regional trade and a slow tourism revival cut demand for less-skilled workers [12]. Even the Pacific's micro-flows track the mechanism — Fiji's remittances rose 9 per cent to $500 million as tourist arrivals recovered, Timor-Leste's spiked 31 per cent to $244 million, and several island states declined as workers stayed home "to cope with idiosyncratic shocks" [12].

The cost of sending remains the system's clearest market failure. The G20's 2014 target of cutting the global average transfer cost from 10 per cent to 5 per cent "had still not been met" as of 2021, "the G20 average cost is 8.12 percent" [8]. Corridor dispersion is wide: in East Asia, the leading least-cost corridors averaged 5.8 per cent for a $200 transfer in late 2023, with Kuwait-to-Philippines the cheapest of them, while "the South Africa to China corridor remained the most expensive corridor at 17.1 percent, up from 14.8 percent a year previous," and costs on the Thailand-to-Myanmar corridor rose 2.6 percentage points in a year [12]. The policy toolkit the WDR endorses is competition-first: "increasing financial competition; introducing new financial products; expanding access to finance, especially in rural and poorer communities; and adopting digital payment technologies," coordinated through the G20 Plan to Facilitate Remittance Flows with its workstreams on payment instruments, technology and transparency [8].

Mexico is the worked example of scale plus reform. Its emigrants "enjoy relatively low remittance fees because of the large size of the US–Mexico corridor and the extent of competition"; the state then pushed further — a 2018 Financial Technology Law authorising and governing fintech providers, the Directo a México digital payments initiative for US–Mexico transfers, online account opening and US-dollar deposit facilities at Mexican banks, and the La Red de la Gente (People's Network) programme coordinating banks for rural access [8]. The general lesson is embedded in the contrast: where corridors are thick and contested, costs approach the low single digits; where they are thin, sanctioned or monopolised, the tax on the world's most effective poverty-transfer system reaches a sixth of the amount sent. Remittances are private money performing a public function, and their price is set less by technology — the cheap corridors prove the technology exists — than by the competitive and regulatory structure each corridor happens to have.

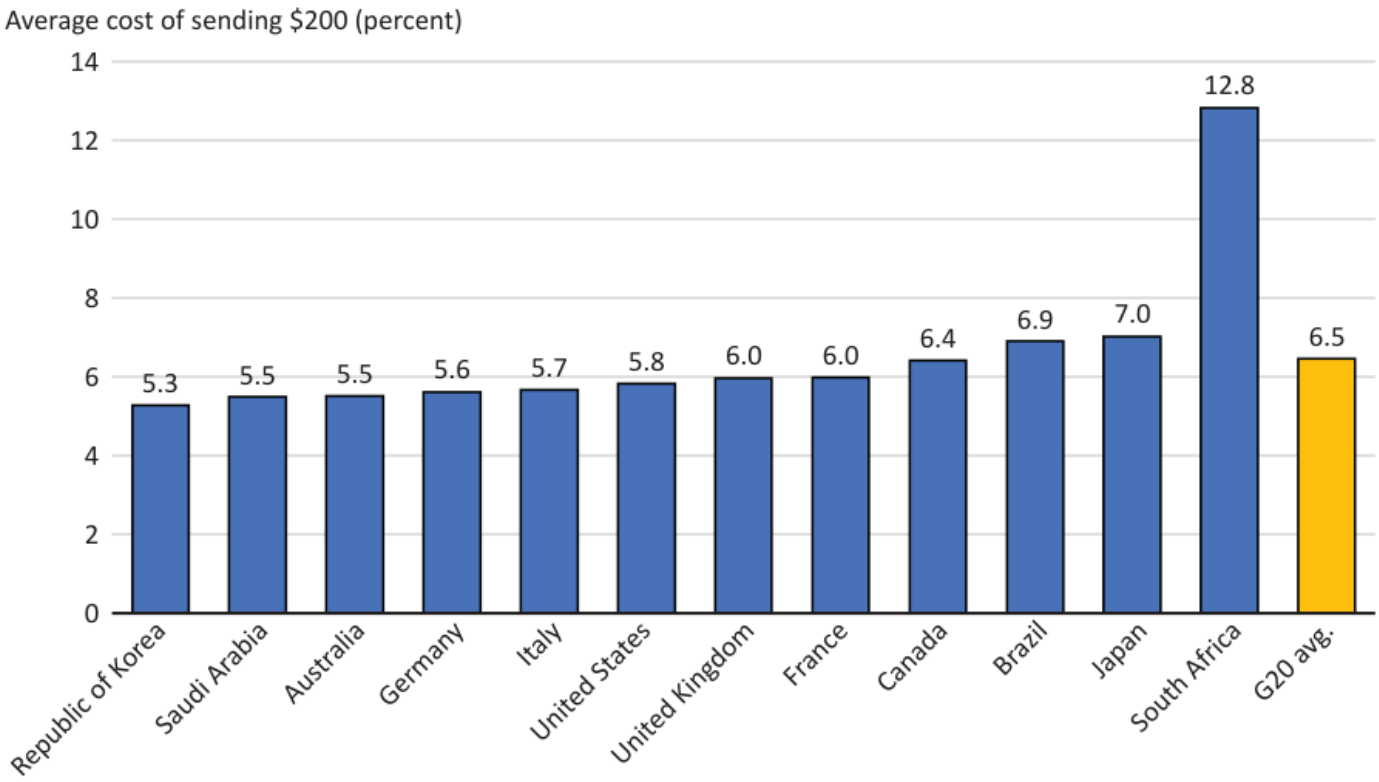


Exhibit. The average cost of sending remittances from G20 countries in the fourth quarter of 2023 shows how transfer fees vary across the world's major sending economies. Source: S0008.

Longer-term economic effects on sending and receiving countries

The short-run accounting of migration — wages gained, remittances sent, vacancies filled — understates its consequences, because migration rearranges the productive capacity of both endpoints for generations. The destination evidence begins with a decomposition. In general-equilibrium estimates commissioned for the Human Development Report, "destination countries would capture about one-fifth of the gains from a 5 percent increase in the number of migrants in developed countries, amounting to US$190 billion" — the bulk accruing to the movers themselves, the rest shared between destination residents and origins through financial and other flows [4]. The micro-econometrics support the mechanism: across a commissioned dataset of 14 OECD destinations and 74 origins over 1980–2005, "immigration increases employment, with no evidence of crowding out of locals, and that investment also responds vigorously," implying that "a 1 percent increase in population due to migration increases GDP by 1 percent" — per-capita income rising in the short run, because flows are small relative to the labour force and predictable enough for capital to adjust [4]. Simulations of the EU's 2004 enlargement put the United Kingdom's and Ireland's output "0.5–1.5 percent higher after about a decade" from the inflows they admitted [4]. The innovation channel is larger than the output channel: in United States data for 1950–2000, "a 1.3 percent increase in the share of migrant university graduates increased the number of patents issued per capita by a massive 15 percent," driven by science and engineering graduates and "without any adverse effects on the innovative activity of local people" [4] — one reason destinations compete for talent with points systems and fast permanent-residence tracks (two years in Singapore, seven in Hong Kong), and why the tertiary-educated share of migrant stocks exceeds 30 per cent in Ireland and the United Kingdom against under 15 per cent in Austria, Italy and Poland [4].

The century-scale evidence is stronger still. The World Development Report's survey of long-run studies finds that in Argentina, counties that raised their immigrant share from 20 to 25 per cent during the age of mass migration "had GDP per capita almost 40 percent higher at the turn of the twenty-first century"; Brazil's 1850 inflows left municipalities with higher income and schooling "100 years after the migration episode"; and United States counties receiving more migrants in 1850–1920 show higher incomes, lower poverty and unemployment, faster urbanisation and greater educational attainment "still evident today" — gains that "did not come at the expense of nearby counties that received fewer immigrants" [8]. Even forced movement compounds positively where integration follows: Indian districts receiving large numbers displaced in the 1947 Partition "were more likely to adopt new agricultural technologies in the decades that followed, and they experienced significantly higher agricultural yields," and Greek municipalities settled by those displaced in the Greco-Turkish War of 1919–22 gained textile and commercial-agriculture skills such that "[s]eventy years later, they still had larger manufacturing sectors and higher average earnings"

— though “where newcomers were segregated in separate villages, the economic benefits were smaller, which illustrates the importance of social integration” [8].

Origin countries’ longer ledger is double-sided in ways the earlier chapters priced only partially. On the credit side, the incomes and health knowledge associated with migration show “a positive influence on infant and child mortality rates” at origin [4]. On the debit side, the same Mexican evidence finds preventive care — breastfeeding and vaccinations — lower where at least one parent had migrated, plausibly through the work burden and thinned caregiving of single-adult households, and return travel can import health risks including HIV and other sexually transmitted infections [4]. The deepest long-run exposure is financial integration itself: the 2009 crisis, beginning in destination countries, transmitted instantly through remittances — flows to Bangladesh, Egypt, El Salvador and the Philippines fell significantly, and in Moldova and Tajikistan, “where remittance shares of GDP are the highest in the world (45 and 38 percent respectively), flows are projected to shrink by 10 percent in 2009,” with El Salvador exposed at over 18 per cent of GDP and three-quarters of Sub-Saharan Africa’s remittances sourced from the crisis-hit United States and Europe [4]. The synthesis the evidence supports is asymmetric interdependence: destinations convert migration into durable productivity — capital deepening, innovation, century-persistent prosperity — conditional on integration; origins convert it into household welfare and human development, conditional on managing absence and on a revenue stream whose stability is hostage to destination business cycles. Both conditionals, not the flows themselves, are where policy earns its return.

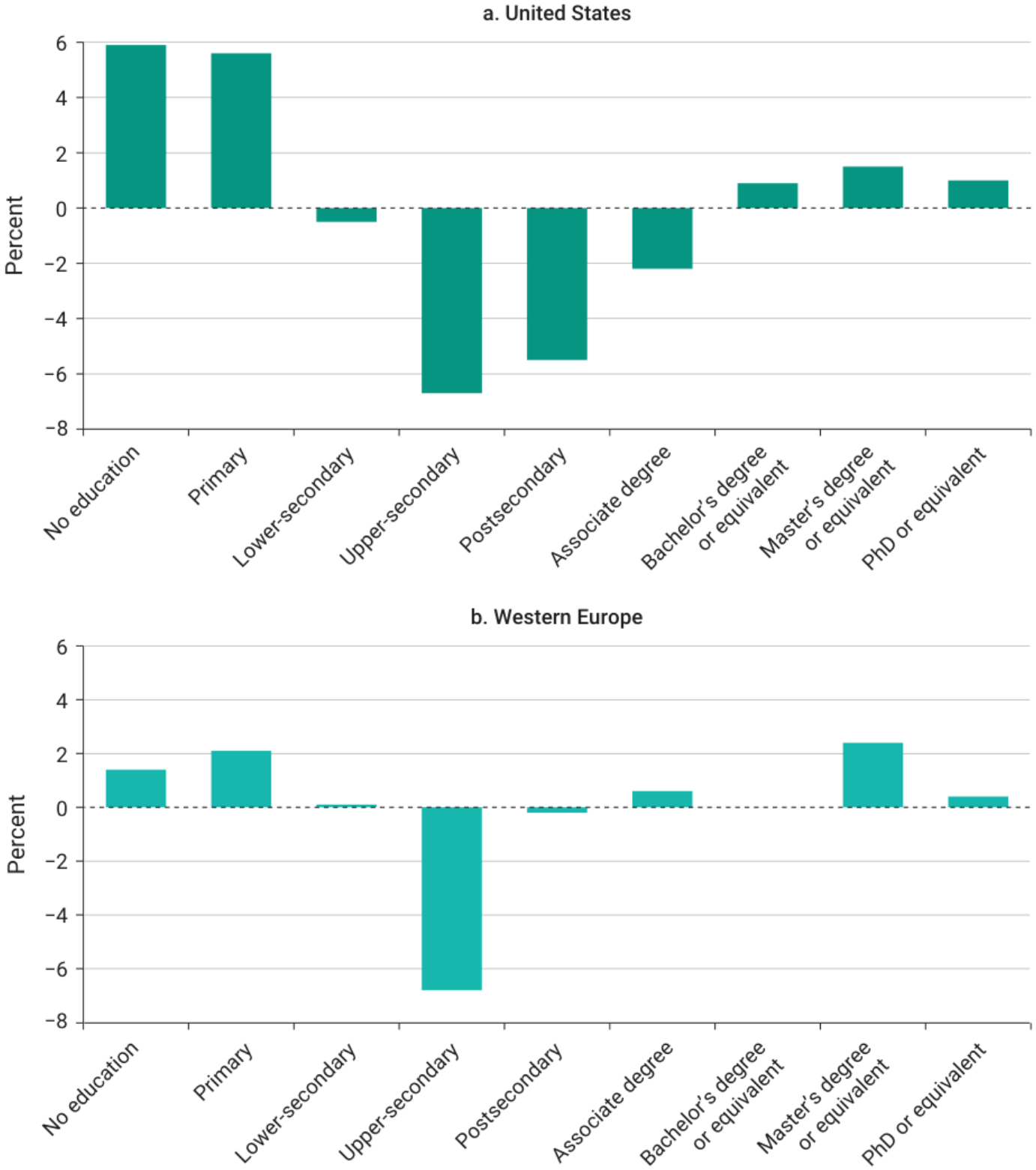


Exhibit. Differences between the education-level shares of migrants and naturalised citizens and those of native-born citizens in the United States and Western Europe reveal how migrant skill profiles compare with native workforces. Source: S0010.

Irregular migration

Counting irregular migrants: methods and estimates

Every count in this report so far rests on states counting people they have admitted. Irregular migrants are defined by their absence from that record, and counting them is the discipline's hardest measurement problem — hard enough that the Human Development Report gives it a boxed treatment of its own. The first difficulty is categorical fluidity. The HDR's analogy is a house with multiple doors: migrants "can enter the house through the front door (permanent settlers), the side door (temporary visitors and workers) or the back door (irregular migrants). However,

once inside a country, these channels often merge, as when temporary visitors become immigrants or slip into unauthorized status," and irregular residents regularise in the other direction [4]. A stock estimate therefore photographs a moving target: the same person is regular in January, irregular in March, and an asylum applicant — a distinct statistical category — by June. The second difficulty is the stock–flow confusion the temporary-migration data expose: temporary migrants are "more than a third of arrivals in a given year" in OECD countries, yet because most leave quickly, "the number of people on temporary visas at any given moment is much smaller than the aggregate flows suggest," and 83 per cent of the OECD foreign-born have been resident at least five years [4]. Flow statistics (apprehensions, interceptions) measure enforcement activity at borders; they do not measure the resident irregular population, and the gap between the two is systematically misleading in one direction.

The World Development Report identifies the distortion precisely: the visible irregular entry is the minority case. "In many countries the majority of irregular migrants enter legally and overstay their visas. In the United States, from 2010 to 2016 there were twice as many visa overstayers as irregular border crossings. Similarly, in the United Kingdom the number of visa overstays exceeds illegal entries, even in 2021 when irregular inflows across the English Channel were at an all-time high" [8]. A counting regime built on border events thus misses most of the population it purports to size, while overstating the border-crossing share — with direct policy consequences, since enforcement budgets follow the visible metric. Estimation practice responds with indirect methods — residuals between census counts and legal-resident registers, regularisation-programme take-up, capture–recapture on administrative lists, and survey inference — each with characteristic biases, which is why responsible estimates arrive as ranges with methods attached rather than as the single global figure public debate demands. Notably, no source in this report's corpus offers a defensible world total for irregular migrants; the honest output of the counting literature is country-level ranges and a profile of who the counted are.

That profile, where direct survey is possible, overturns the stock image. UNDP's Scaling Fences study interviewed irregular African migrants in Europe and found people "relatively better off than their peers," who "had manifestly benefited from development progress in Africa in recent decades" — urbanisation, demographic pressure, often a family migration history — with education "typically educated above the average levels in their home countries" and pre-departure incomes "competitive in national contexts," many in jobs "described as safe and regular" [6]. Yet only 38 per cent said they earned enough "to get by," 50 per cent felt they were not earning enough, and only 12 per cent could save — aspiration outrunning adequate-but-flat prospects, compounded by "a strong sense of identity-based social exclusion by, and alienation from, state duty bearers" [6]. The study's framing conclusion is that irregular migration, for this population, is "an investment in a better future: embraced by individuals whose development trajectory is already in ascendance" — undertaken because "legal channels facilitating migration remain largely closed to this class of traveller" [6]. Context disciplines the politics: "over 80 percent of African migration happens within Africa," and African arrivals are "a smaller proportion of total arriving migrants than other populations," despite media descriptions of Europe being "'invaded' or 'swarmed'" and the disproportionate policy attention they attract [6].

In Europe, the counted population's labour-market reality completes the measurement story. Among Scaling Fences respondents, 38 per cent were earning at interview — and 38 per cent of those were working without a legal right to do so, evidence of "the readiness of otherwise regular businesses as well as criminal networks to exploitatively absorb the services of irregular migrants when legal channels are closed" [6]. Significant numbers had nonetheless gained legal work rights despite travelling for non-protection reasons, reflecting how "the asylum system becomes perhaps the only route available for these migrants where other legal pathways do not exist" [6]. The human-capital waste is measurable: respondents with tertiary or vocational education were nearly twice as likely to be earning as those with none, yet the cohort's share in elementary occupations rose "from nearly one third to over one half" between home and Europe — "an underutilized human and labour potential" that better counting, and the legal pathways counting argues for, would make visible as an economic loss rather than a border statistic [6].

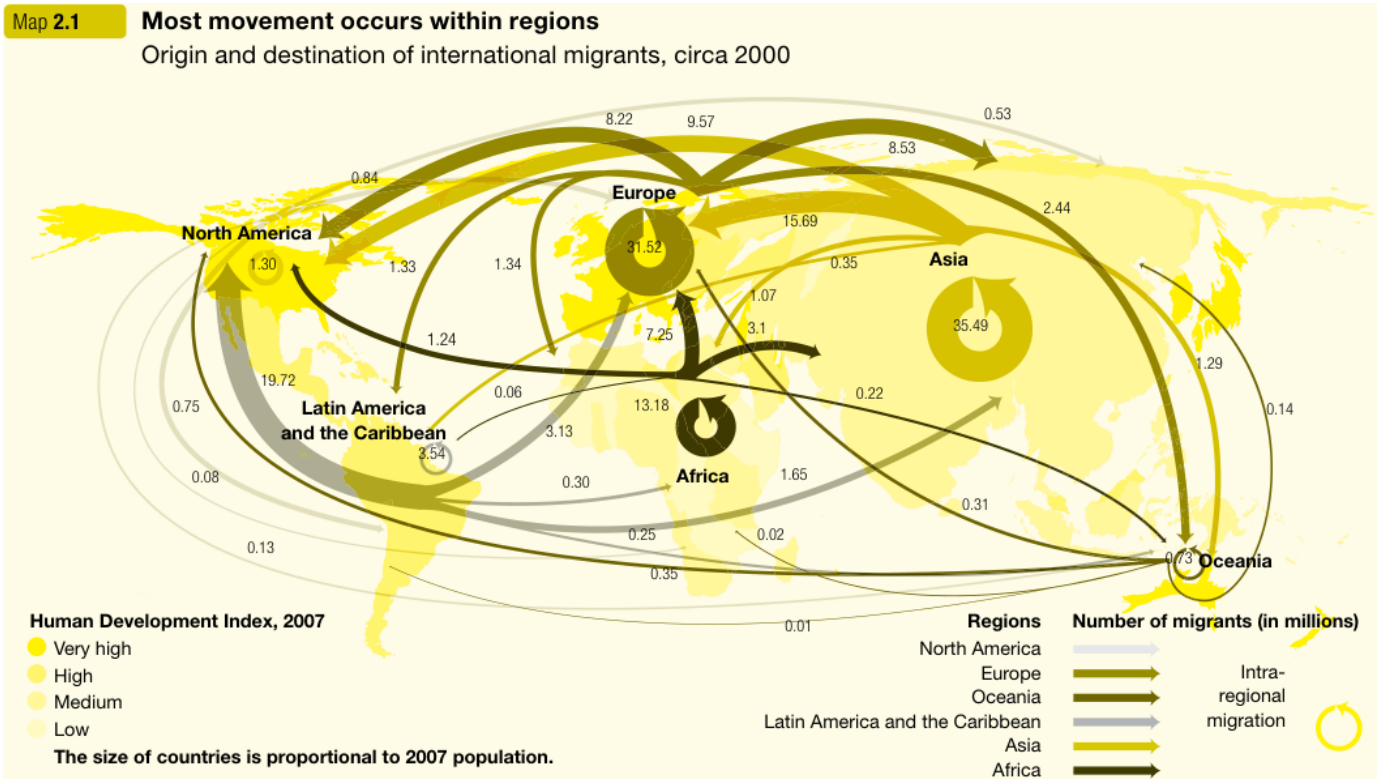


Exhibit. Origins and destinations of international migrants around 2000 are mapped to show that most movement occurs within regions rather than between them. Source: S0022.

Smugglers and traffickers

Where legal channels close against acute pressure to move, a market opens. The World Development Report, drawing on UNODC estimates, sizes it: "at least 2.5 million migrants were smuggled in 2016 for an economic return of US$5.5–$7 billion, making it an important part of the illegal economy" — a turnover "roughly equivalent to the humanitarian aid budget of the United States or of the European Union that year" [8]. The industry's structure defies the cartel stereotype: "[t]he organization and scale of smuggling operations vary" from individuals and small networks in one or two countries to "large, complex multinational criminal organizations," with many operations "based on independent actors loosely linked via social networks and communicating via digital technology, complicating efforts to combat this phenomenon" — and ethnographic research warns that "portraying smugglers as criminals and migrants as their victims may oversimplify a complex and often symbiotic relationship" [8]. Some operators behave as professional service providers, "guaranteeing services and agreeing to receive final payment when the migrant reaches the final destination"; others subject their clients to "traumatic ordeals throughout their transit" [8].

The analytic line the law draws — smuggling as "a voluntary movement of migrants by a smuggler who receives payment to take them to a destination," trafficking as movement involving "an element of extortion, exploitation, or coercion" — "is often blurred" in practice, and the populations overlap heavily: undocumented migrants make up 65 per cent of trafficking victims in Western and Southern Europe, 60 per cent in the Middle East, 55 per cent in East Asia and the Pacific, 50 per cent in Central and Southeastern Europe and 25 per cent in North America [8]. The exploitation end of the market is an order of magnitude larger than the transport end: the ILO estimated the profits of trafficking and forced labour at "about US$150 billion a year," two-thirds from commercial sexual exploitation and the rest from forced economic exploitation [8].

The child-focused route evidence shows the blur operating as a business model. On the Central Mediterranean route, trafficking networks "deliberately recruit and target vulnerable children before their departure in their country of origin," trapping them in debt bondage — formally or informally — before they travel, with the debt later used "as a means of control"; unlike routes where migrants face "different recruiters, smugglers or criminal syndicates at each step, most of which rob them," the eastern-route child traffic runs through "the same line of recruiters, smugglers and/or syndicates who facilitate the entire journey," with exploitative work "already organized" on arrival — drug trafficking, forced labour or sex trafficking in Italy or Greece — and children pre-briefed on "the locations they should go to, who to call, and what to say" [19]. The deception is measurable in the journey's casualty statistics: on the Central Mediterranean route 54 per cent of migrant youth experienced physical violence, against 1 per cent on

the western routes; at least 56 per cent reported a protection concern such as unpaid work, forced work, being held against their will or loss of documents; 14.8 per cent had been deceived with false work-permit promises, 11 per cent held against their will, 5 per cent subjected to forced labour [19]. Not all facilitation is predation — among young Bangladeshi migrants reaching Libya, 97 per cent flew, most held work permits and passports, and only 11 per cent used a migration facilitator, indicating largely formal channels into a country hosting 824,131 migrants in 2024 [19] — and aspiration itself is an exploitable asset, as with the West African boys whose hopes of professional football are harvested by fraudulent sports recruiters [19].

The policy logic that follows from the market structure is three-sided. Against supply: combat smuggling through corridor-wide international cooperation, since fragmented networks re-form around national enforcement. Against demand: "[t]he attractiveness of irregular channels depends on whether there is a demand for irregular labor from employers," laws against irregular employment are "unevenly enforced, if at all," and "[e]fforts to restrict distressed migration cannot succeed if employers are willing and able to hire these migrants" — clamping down on the irregular labour market, with regularisation pathways for large existing populations, is therefore critical [8]. Against the incentive: processing speed — Germany's Federal Office for Migration and Refugees modernised and digitalised after the 2015 arrivals, "dramatically increas[ing] its ability to process requests," and "[p]rocessing requests for asylum or for visas expeditiously can reduce the incentives for distressed migrants' use of irregular channels" [8]. The smuggler, in this analysis, is a price signal: he charges what closed channels are worth, and the durable way to shrink his market is to make the legal door cheaper than the back one.

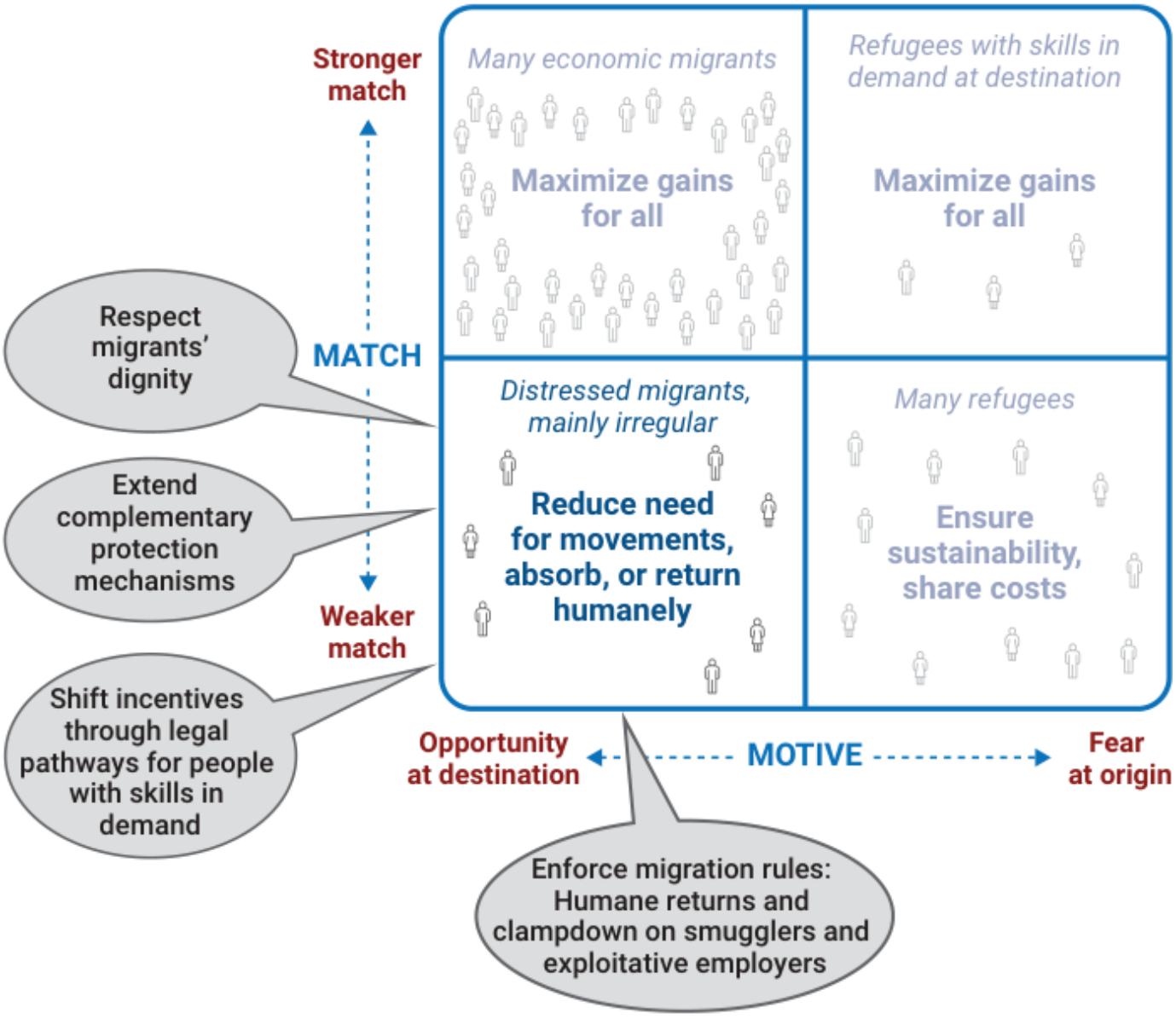


Exhibit. Migration policy options are organised by migrants' skills match at destination and their motive for moving, with human dignity as the yardstick for maximising gains for migrants and for origin and destination countries alike. Source: S0010.

Forced labour and human trafficking

Forced labour is where the migration system's failures become crimes against the person. The Global Estimates of Modern Slavery (ILO, Walk Free and IOM, 2022) put the prevalence of forced labour exploitation among migrant workers at roughly three times the non-migrant rate — and the sex-disaggregated figures show the exposure is not evenly shared even among migrants: 16.0 per thousand for migrant men against 4.5 per thousand for non-migrant men, and 10.6 per thousand for migrant women against 3.6 per thousand for non-migrant women [9]. The estimates are careful about the trafficking nexus: they "did not aim to estimate the prevalence of trafficking for forced labour," but "it is likely that for many migrants subjected to forced labour there was criminal involvement of traffickers at earlier stages of their journey – such as at the time of recruitment and facilitation of travel – with intent to exploit them once they reached their destination" [9]. Trafficking, in other words, is frequently the supply chain of forced labour rather than a separate phenomenon.

The estimates identify the vulnerability machinery with unusual precision. Risk concentrates "when migration is irregular or poorly governed, or when recruitment practices are unfair or unethical, or when migrants are unprotected in law and practice" [9]. At the journey's start, "unscrupulous recruitment intermediaries… exact from them recruitment fees and related costs, exacerbating the cycle of debt and risk of abuse" — the debt-bondage mechanism the child-trafficking evidence displayed in operation [9]. At destination, vulnerability is maintained by "language and cultural barriers, lack of reliable information and support networks, challenges of economic and social integration, lack of access to basic services and social security, or restrictions on their ability to change employer or organize and bargain collectively" [9]. Sector compounds status: "migrant workers are often employed in sectors such as domestic work or agriculture, which may not be covered by the labour code," where informality limits "access to workplace protections or grievance mechanisms," and employers and landlords exploit "their limited knowledge of local conditions and reduced bargaining power" — a trap "particularly challenging for women migrant workers, for whom regular migration channels might be restricted by law or practice" [9]. Alongside private exploitation, the estimates treat forced labour imposed by the state as a distinct category of the global total [9].

The remedy framework the estimates propose is legal-architecture work, not awareness campaigns. "Reducing the vulnerability of migrants to forced labour and human trafficking depends first and foremost on national policy and legal frameworks… that protect their human and labour rights and do not instead contain gaps that leave them more exposed," with protection applying "at all stages of the migration process, regardless of their migration status" — and the report notes how rare full compliance is: "[t]here are only a few examples of countries of destination extending equality of treatment to migrant workers with respect to all aspects of employment" [9]. Its instruments are gap analyses comparing domestic law against international human and labour standards, migrant voice in policy design, and — the structural lever — regular pathways: "[p]olicies that create and widen pathways for regular migration help reduce irregular migration flows, and the risks of trafficking in persons and forced labour associated with them" [9]. Reform movement exists at the hard end of the system: Qatar "has adopted a range of legislative reforms and other measures aimed at ensuring the rights and freedoms of migrant workers," and the United Arab Emirates has legislated migrant domestic workers' right to "terminate their work contracts unilaterally" — a direct strike at the employer-tied immobility that converts employment into coercion [9]. On the protection side, IOM's Human Trafficking Case Data Standards and referral-mechanism guidance aim to make victim identification and case management consistent across frontline organisations [9]. The section's conclusion writes itself from the prevalence arithmetic: forced labour is not randomly distributed across the workforce but concentrated, by a factor of three, precisely where legal protection is thinnest — which makes it, uniquely among this report's problems, a measure of governance choices rather than of migration itself.



Exhibit. The composition of forced labour exploitation differs from that of the broader labour force, with migrants forming a much higher share of people in forced labour than of workers overall. Source: S0016.

EU visa policy and irregular arrivals

The European Union's irregular-arrival statistics for 2023 show a system being steered — by visa policy upstream, by externalisation bargains midstream, and by displacement effects that move flows rather than stop them. Frontex registered 354,713 irregular crossings at the EU's external borders in January–November 2023, up 21.6 per cent on 2022 and 108.9 per cent on 2021, with the year-end figure expected at roughly 380,000 — "the highest number since 2016 but still clearly below the figures recorded during the height of the 'refugee crisis' (1.3 million in 2015 and 511,000 in 2016)" [21]. Two routes — the Central Mediterranean (157,479 detections, up 49.2 per cent) and the Western Balkans (99,068, down 31.3 per cent) — together accounted for 67.6 per cent of all detections, followed by the Eastern Mediterranean (60,073, up 55.3 per cent), the Western African route (40,403, up 161.3 per cent), the Western Mediterranean (16,915) and the Eastern Border route (5,608, down 63.7 per cent) [21].

The Western Balkans decline is the cleanest demonstration in the dataset that visa policy is migration policy: the route's fall is attributed "not least due to Serbia's stricter visa policy towards important countries of origin of irregular migrants and asylum seekers, such as Burundi (down 92.4%), India (down 93.0%) and Tunisia (down 37.5%)" [21]. Visa-free entry to a neighbouring state had functioned as a legal front door into an irregular corridor — fly in lawfully, walk onward unlawfully — and withdrawing it collapsed those national flows almost entirely, without a single additional border guard. It is the empirical basis for the ICMPD Outlook's framing question: whether "a revamp of EU visa policy" — aligning visa-free regimes and suspension mechanisms with arrival data — could do at European scale what Serbia did unilaterally [21].

The Central Mediterranean surge shows the counterpart mechanism: suppression displacing rather than deterring. Crossings on the route rose 61 per cent through November 2023, but their composition inverted. After the EU–Tunisia memorandum of understanding of July 2023 — financial and technical assistance, search-and-rescue cooperation, border management, smuggling disruption, returns and readmission, plus expanded regular pathways — detected North African nationals fell sharply: Algerians down 50.9 per cent, Moroccans 48.9 per cent, Egyptians 45.1 per cent, Tunisians 13.4 per cent [21]. Simultaneously, sub-Saharan detections exploded — Guinea up 452.1 per cent, Côte d'Ivoire 305.3 per cent, Burkina Faso 3,708.2 per cent, Mali 568.0 per cent, Cameroon 315.6 per cent, Sudan 373.0 per cent — lifting the West and Central African share of arrivals on the route "from approx. 5% in 2022 to approx. 40% in 2023," with Guinea (16,132) and Côte d'Ivoire (14,580) entering the route's top three nationalities [21]

[21]. The Outlook's causal account is explicit: North African states' "increasingly restrictive stance" — expulsions from Algeria and Tunisia, a hostile public climate, enforcement against resident migrant populations — meant that "in order to escape the increasing social and political pressure… many of them decided to leave for Europe instead," and flows substituted across routes, the Western African route rising 112 per cent [21]. Libya illustrates the same secondary-movement logic from the stock side: of its more than 700,000 resident migrants, almost 90 per cent had come seeking work, one in four was out of work amid political impasse and Storm Daniel's displacement of over 43,000 people — and "a large proportion of the crossings from Libya and other Southern Mediterranean countries did not involve migrants in transit, but people who had originally wanted to stay and work" there and felt compelled to leave [21].

The downstream consequence lands in the asylum system: 927,030 applications in the EU in the first ten months of 2023, up 21.3 per cent and the highest since 2016, with 93.4 per cent filed in just ten member states — Germany alone taking 284,380 (30.6 per cent, up 55.6 per cent), ahead of France (137,500), Spain (137,315) and Italy (110,634) — while fifteen member states recorded declines [21]. The Outlook's forward judgment was that pressures would not diminish in 2024 and applications "might well reach 1 million or more again" [21]. The section's analytical yield is a hydraulic model of irregular arrival: flows respond to the price and availability of every door — visa regimes, transit-state bargains, resident-stock conditions — so that pressure applied at one point reappears at another, and the only interventions in the record that reduced flows without displacing them were changes to legal access itself.

Asylum systems under strain

Asylum trends and key flows

The asylum system's defining trend is a queue that grows faster than it is processed. "The total number of asylum-seekers waiting for a decision at the end of 2024 stood at 8.4 million, an increase of 22 per cent from end-2023," UNHCR reports; "[t]he number of pending asylum claims has risen for eight consecutive years since 2016 and the pace of these increases has risen in recent years as new individual asylum applications have continued to outpace substantive decisions" [7]. The backlog's geography has shifted beyond the traditional destinations: the United States remains largest (3.2 million pending at mid-2024, "still the largest number of pending applications globally at end-2024 despite the partial reporting"), but Egypt follows at 631,100 — "a nearly 3-fold increase" — then Peru (540,000, +6 per cent), Germany (348,900, −3 per cent) and Canada (292,100, +29 per cent) [7]. Backlogs are no longer a rich-country administrative problem; they are where the world's displaced actually wait, including in the low- and middle-income hosts that hold most refugees.

UNHCR's diagnosis is institutional rather than numerical: "[f]air and efficient asylum procedures are essential to provide safety for those fleeing conflict, violence or persecution," yet "systems have not been strategically adapted to the current context," with weaknesses spanning "legal and policy frameworks, institutional performance, procedural effectiveness, workforce capacity and asylum-seeker participation through information and legal aid" [7]. The stakes of the queue run both ways — delay prolongs uncertainty and vulnerability for those who will be recognised, and it parks those who will not be inside the system for years, feeding the irregularity dynamics examined earlier: slow adjudication is simultaneously a protection failure and a pull factor.

Against the queue, 2024 produced a counter-trend on the solutions side. Returns surged: 1.6 million refugees returned to their countries of origin during the year — 563,800 more than in 2023, a 54 per cent increase — and 8.2 million IDPs returned to their place of origin, up 3.1 million (61 per cent) [7]. Resettlement arrivals rose 19 per cent and the number of refugees naturalised or granted permanent residency nearly tripled against 2023 [7]. The flows of the system, in other words, are polarising: new claims accumulate in an adjudication queue that grows for an eighth straight year, while the exits — return above all — accelerate faster than they have in years. Whether the returns prove durable is the question the IDP analysis posed earlier; what the asylum data establish is that the system's centre of gravity is shifting from processing arrivals to managing departures, even as the pending mountain — 8.4 million people in procedural limbo — keeps growing on the other side of the ledger.

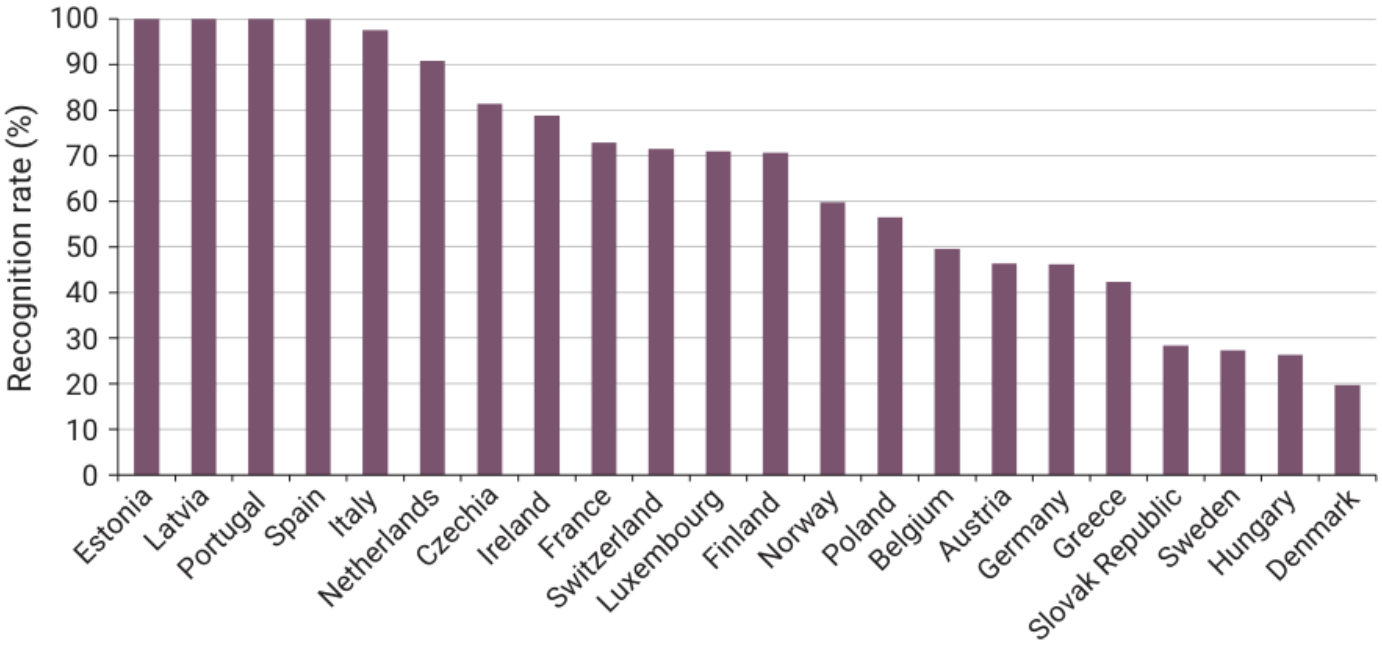


Exhibit. Recognition rates for Afghan asylum-seekers varied greatly across European countries in 2021, showing how the same caseload faced sharply different prospects of protection depending on where the claim was decided. Source: S0010.

Pending claims and processing backlogs

A backlog is arithmetic before it is politics: claims in minus decisions out, compounded. Globally, "[t]he total number of asylum-seekers waiting for a decision at the end of 2023 stood at 6.9 million, an increase of 26 per cent from the end of 2022," because "despite increases in productivity, new individual asylum applications have continued to outpace substantive decisions" — in 2023 states made 1.4 million substantive decisions, up 8 per cent, against 3.6 million new individual applications, up 40 per cent [18]. The queue's growth poles are instructive: the United States held 2.6 million pending at end-2023 (up 45 per cent in a year), then Peru (508,400), Germany (361,500, up 38 per cent), Mexico (257,400, up 22 per cent) and Egypt (232,400, up 263 per cent), while the fastest growth rates were in displacement-adjacent states — the Central African Republic's caseload rose 69-fold to 32,500 on Chadian inflows, Ethiopia's 29-fold to 63,800, Rwanda's 26-fold and Nigeria's 21-fold [18]. UNHCR's list of causes is institutional, not demographic: "weak institutions, cumbersome decision-making structures, weak case management, and under-resourced or poorly capacitated workforces," with differentiated case processing and group recognitions the countermeasures some states are adopting [18].

The United States — holder of the largest backlog — is also the best-documented case that backlogs are reversible, because it has eliminated one before. The mid-1990s reforms rebuilt the asylum system around speed: filings fell from their 150,000 peak in FY1995 to 30,000 in FY1999 (an 80 per cent drop), while "the approval rate for asylum cases increased from 15 percent in FY 1993 to 38 percent in FY 1999, indicating that a larger share of the applications filed were valid claims" [22]. The affirmative backlog was then ground down "from 464,000 in FY 2003 to 55,000 by the end of FY 2006" and to "slightly more than 6,000" by FY2010, with credible-fear processing steady at about 5,000 cases a year [22]. The lesson embedded in that history is about incentives: fast, credible adjudication deters weak claims by removing the queue's ancillary benefits, leaving a caseload that is smaller and stronger.

The current backlog rebuilt on changed flows and restored incentives. Arrivals at the southwest border shifted from single economic migrants to mixed protection flows — "about a decade ago, approximately one in every 100 border crossers was an unaccompanied child or potential refugee seeking humanitarian protection; today, that share is more than one in three" [22]. Defensive asylum receipts before immigration judges rose from 33,000 in FY2010 to 65,000 in FY2016 and 120,000 in FY2017, led by Northern Triangle nationals — Salvadoran defensive claims alone rose from 7,000 to 18,000 between FY2014 and FY2016, Guatemalan and Honduran claims from about 4,000 to 11,000 each [22]. By July 2018 the immigration courts held "a record backlog of 746,000 cases of all types," asylum comprising about 30 per cent of the court caseload, with "some applicants must wait up to five years for a hearing" — and expanding the bench "from 250 in 2016 to approximately 350 in 2018 has not slowed new growth in the backlog" [22]. On the affirmative side, USCIS raised asylum officers from 272 in 2013 to 520 by 2018, detailed 100 refugee-corps officers, and opened new sub-offices [22].

The incentive gauge is the employment-authorisation clock: US rules grant work permits to applicants whose cases pass 180 days undecided, and approvals on that basis rose "from 55,000 in FY 2012 to 270,000 in FY 2016, and further to 278,000 in just the first six months of FY 2017" — evidence, as MPI puts it, that "as processing times have grown, so too have incentives to file claims as a means of obtaining work authorization and protection from deportation, without a sound underlying claim" [22]. The system's most consequential recent intervention targets exactly that margin: from January 29, 2018, USCIS reinstated last-in-first-out interview scheduling — "a return to the emergency measure introduced by the reforms of the mid-1990s" — so new applicants are interviewed within months while the legacy queue waits, and "likely as a result of this change, the backlog of pending cases did not grow in April, May, and June of 2018" [22]. The generalisable finding of the backlog literature is that queues are policy outputs, not weather: they respond to adjudication capacity, scheduling rules and the benefits attached to pending status — and they punish most severely the applicants with the strongest claims, who spend the longest time in the legal insecurity the system exists to end.

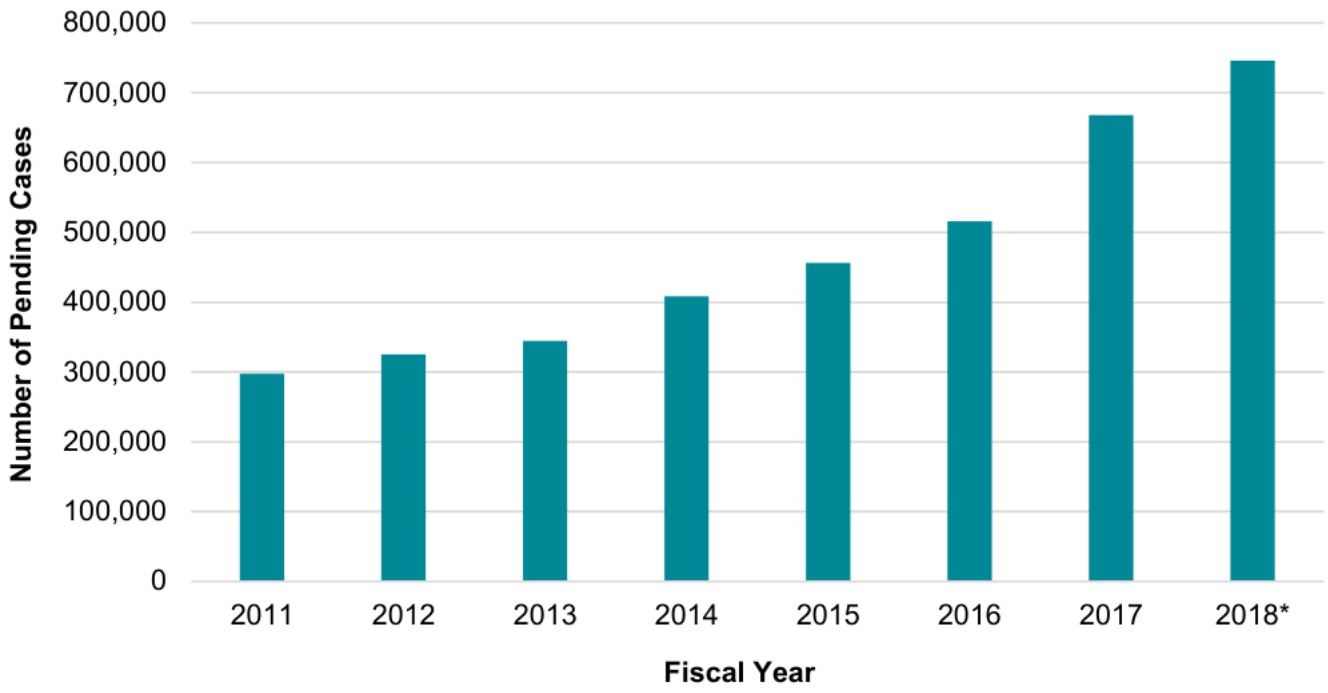


Exhibit. The backlog of cases pending in United States immigration courts from fiscal 2010 to 2018 traces the steady accumulation of undecided cases that overwhelmed the asylum and removal system. Source: S0012.

The U.S. asylum system in crisis

The United States operates not one asylum system but three interlocking ones, and its crisis is best understood as their collision. The **affirmative** track serves people already present and not in removal proceedings: asylum officers at USCIS adjudicate, granting protection or referring the unsuccessful to the immigration courts (EOIR, within the Department of Justice) for fresh consideration by a judge [22]. The **defensive** track is asylum claimed as a defence against removal before those same judges, and it absorbs the affirmative track's referrals [22]. The third, hybrid track was created by the 1996 Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act: most migrants taken into custody at the border lack entry documents and face **expedited removal** — "a swift administrative form of deportation that does not allow for a hearing before an immigration judge" — unless they express a fear of return, which triggers a credible-fear interview testing whether they have a "'significant possibility' of establishing eligibility for asylum" or Convention Against Torture protection; those who pass enter formal removal proceedings and claim asylum defensively [22]. Expedited removal's reach expanded stepwise — to sea arrivals in 2002, and in 2004 to anyone not admitted who is encountered within 100 miles of the southwest border and cannot prove 14 days' presence [22]. Unaccompanied minors are carved out of the fast track by the Trafficking Victims Protection Reauthorization Act of 2008: their claims go first to asylum officers rather than courtrooms, "so that they may avoid, to the greatest extent possible, the adversarial setting" [22]. For years this architecture worked — in MPI's assessment, "[t]he federal government succeeded for many years in delivering fair and timely decisions on asylum cases, and in curtailing nonmeritorious claims" [22].

The crisis arrived when the flow changed character and the queues rebuilt (the previous section's arithmetic: defensive receipts tripling in seven years, a record 746,000-case court backlog, waits to five years against a six-month statutory standard). The restrictionist response of 2017–18 — deterrence through narrowed pathways, including the attorney general's June–July 2018 legal guidance under which "the number of cases that pass the credible-fear test can be expected to fall" — draws MPI's sharpest verdict: the Trump administration's policies, "intended to deter flows by severely restricting the pathways to asylum," are "unnecessarily harsh and costly, and they are unlikely to substantially deter future unauthorized arrivals" [22] [22]. The report's counter-thesis is that deterrence is a by-product of function: an alternate path "based on principles of timeliness and fairness in providing protection, which will, in turn, discourage unfounded claims and deter opportunistic flows" [22].

The capacity evidence supports the counter-thesis. Between FY2013 and FY2018, "the number of asylum officers nearly doubled from 272 to 520, with authorization to hire up to 687 total officers," and "the Asylum Division budget grew by more than 55 percent" — resources which, "[b]ased on historical experience… should be sufficient for the task of deciding the current level of incoming cases" [22]. What misallocates that capacity is routing. MPI's first recommendation targets the system's most duplicative joint: the "tens of thousands of cases in which asylum officers have found applicants to have credible fear" that are nonetheless referred to immigration courts each year, where they "must begin anew after waiting several years" [22]. Keeping positive credible-fear cases with the Asylum Division for full merits adjudication "would capitalize on the investment of time and expertise the division has already made," resolve meritorious cases faster, and relieve both officer and judge queues — the current procedure being "needlessly duplicative," weakening sound cases through delay while inviting misuse by those filing to obtain work authorisation or delay removal [22]. Companion recommendations would fast-track high-screen-in-rate categories directly to full determination under a senior cross-agency coordinator, and move cancellation-of-removal cases — increasingly initiated through the affirmative asylum queue, where they are "misplaced" — into a separate process [22]. The January 2018 return to last-in-first-out scheduling is endorsed only as triage: effective, but "[b]ecause it further disadvantages cases that have already been waiting for long periods, it should be treated as an emergency measure—not a new standard," to be retired once new cases are decided within the statutory six months, when "case receipts are likely to decrease, approval rates increase," and capacity can rotate back to the legacy queue [22]. The US case thus generalises the backlog chapter's lesson with an institutional corollary: in asylum, the queue is not only a capacity problem but a design problem — and a system that re-adjudicates its own screening decisions from zero, years later, manufactures its own crisis.

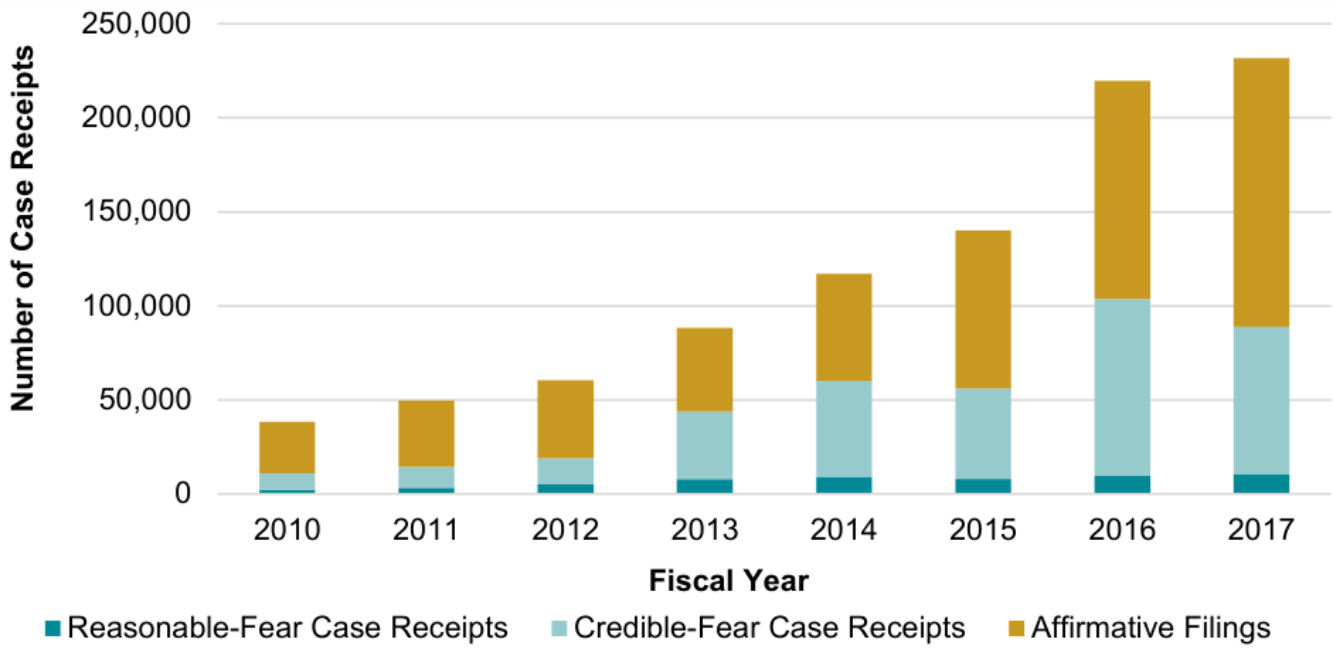


Exhibit. The USCIS Asylum Division's workload of affirmative asylum, credible-fear and reasonable-fear cases from fiscal 2010 to 2017 shows the surge in screening and merits caseloads that drove the system's crisis. Source: S0012.

Resettlement and complementary pathways

Against the asylum system's spontaneous-arrival logic stands the planned one: the durable-solutions framework. A durable solution exists when a displaced person's situation "is satisfactorily and permanently resolved through en-

suring national protection for their civil, cultural, economic, political, and social rights," and for refugees the framework recognises three: voluntary repatriation in safety and dignity, local integration in the host country, and resettlement to a third country — supplemented by complementary pathways and family reunification [18]. UNHCR's own summary of performance is blunt: "durable solutions continue to remain a reality for very few people" [18]. Resettlement, the third-country leg, is "a crucial protection tool and a solution for refugees who face urgent or specific risks, and for populations in protracted situations," and the mechanism by which wealthy states share responsibility with the first-asylum countries hosting the large numbers [18].

Its scale, measured against need, is the section's central fact. In 2023, "158,700 arrivals through resettlement, community sponsorship and other third-country solution programmes were reported by 24 countries," up 39 per cent on the year — yet "the total still only accounted for 8 per cent of the estimated 2 million individuals globally identified by UNHCR as in need of resettlement" [18]. The geography of generosity is concentrated: the United States received 75,100 resettled refugees (22,100 from the Democratic Republic of the Congo, 14,700 Syrians, 8,600 Afghans, 6,600 from Myanmar), Canada 51,100 (16,600 Afghans, 9,200 Eritreans, 8,400 Syrians, 4,300 Somalis), and Germany 4,500 [18]. The Myanmar caseload illustrates both the mechanism's reach and its fragility: in 2024 some 31,900 refugees from Myanmar — over 19,500 of them Rohingya — were considered for resettlement, more than 10,100 departed (up 47 per cent on 2023, over three-quarters to the United States), and a further 1,790 left on complementary pathways from five Asian countries of asylum — even as UNHCR warned that "the availability of third-country solutions through resettlement will decrease in 2025" [7].

The complementary pathways are where the growth is, and they work by reclassifying refugees as something states already admit: family members, students, workers. On 2022 data compiled with the OECD, OECD countries and Brazil "issued approximately 214,800 residence permits to Afghan, Eritrean, Iranian, Iraqi, Somali, Syrian and Venezuelan refugees for the purposes of family reunification, education or employment opportunities" — already exceeding formal resettlement volumes — with "family reunification… the most important legal pathway for refugees during the year, representing 57 per cent of all permits issued" [18]. Pathways of this kind "can lead to solutions, ease pressure on host countries and enhance refugees' self-reliance, including through education pathways or labour mobility" [18]. Their significance for the report's larger argument is structural: they convert protection from a discretionary humanitarian allocation into an application of ordinary migration categories, which is why they scale — and why their eligibility rules, set by labour and education systems rather than protection criteria, quietly re-sort who gets out.

The third solution, local integration, is the least measured: "statistics on local integration are rarely available," and naturalisation serves UNHCR as "an imperfect proxy" [18]. On that proxy, about 30,800 refugees acquired host-country citizenship in 2023 across 24 reporting countries — down 39 per cent on 2022 — led by Syrians (8,900), Eritreans (2,500) and Iranians (1,900), with the Netherlands alone naturalising 14,900, followed by Canada (9,400) and France (2,500) [18]. The solutions arithmetic of the displacement system is therefore lopsided in a specific way: return moves millions (5.1 million IDP returns in 2023, 62 per cent of them in the DRC and Ukraine), resettlement moves one in twelve of those identified as needing it, pathways move a growing but eligibility-gated stream, and integration proceeds largely uncounted [18]. For a refugee in a protracted situation — the population resettlement was designed for — the realistic exits remain, in order, a change of politics at home, absorption where they are, or a lottery-like selection whose odds the data now state precisely.

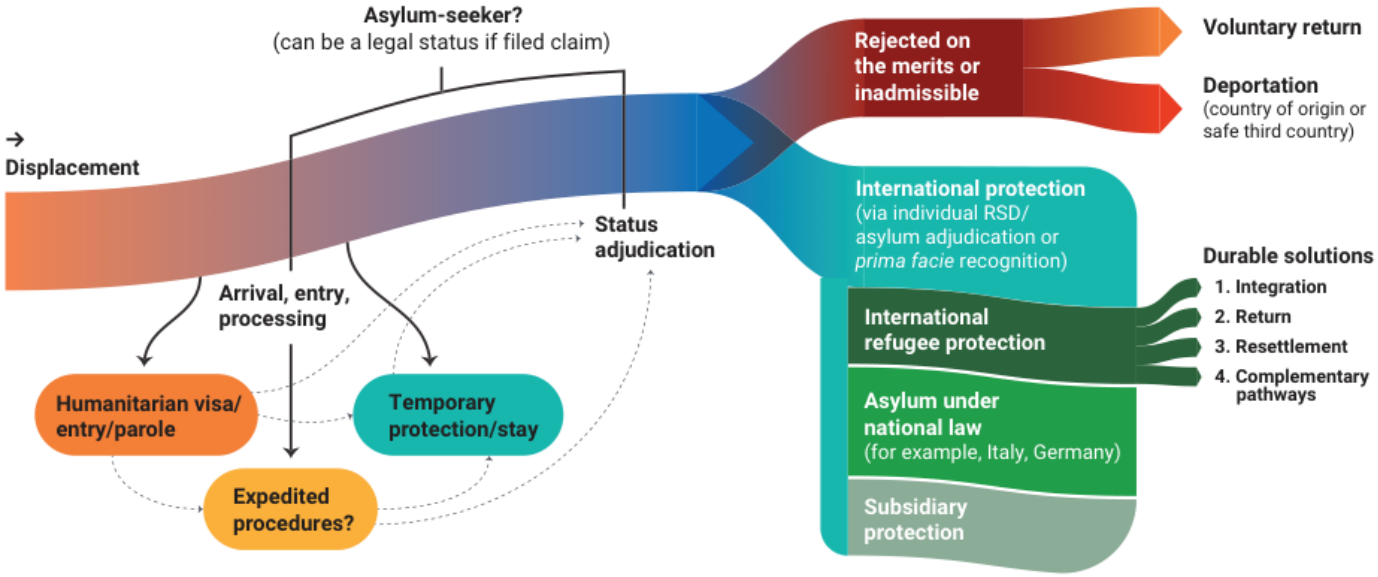


Exhibit. The maze of complementary protection pathways facing a displaced person, branching from an asylum claim toward legal status, voluntary return, or rejection and deportation to the origin country or a safe third country. Source: S0010.

Borders and control regimes

Shifting realities at borders: the U.S.-Mexico case

The US–Mexico border is where the report's abstract machinery — backlogs, pathways, enforcement hydraulics — becomes operational. The scale first: "[o]f the 6.6 million migrant encounters recorded along the U.S.-Mexico border between FY 2021 and FY 2023, 5.9 million (90 percent) were processed by the U.S. Border Patrol between POEs," an average of nearly 2 million encounters a year "with migrants of increasingly different nationalities and characteristics" [23]. The compositional change drives everything else. Migrants who expect quick processing and release — "Venezuelans, Cubans, Nicaraguans, and Haitians" — "tend to seek out and surrender to U.S. authorities soon after crossing," in encounters agents call "give-ups," reflecting an intention to seek asylum; "Mexicans and Central Americans, who are often aware that they may be detained and removed, are more likely to attempt to evade detection," with an estimated 1.7 million "gotaways" detected but not encountered since FY2021 [23]. A border built to deter evasion now primarily processes surrender.

The processing chain is a relay with tight clocks: the Border Patrol — roughly 19,000 agents — "generally has 72 hours to process migrants before transferring custody" to ORR (for unaccompanied children, within 24 hours), USCIS (credible-fear interviews), ICE (removals) and ultimately EOIR's courts, with temporary holding capacity expanded to "slightly more than 23,000 individuals per day, spread across 68 stations and 13 soft-sided facilities" [23]. What exits the relay is mostly not removal. Even as arrivals fell in June 2023 and the administration "sought to scale up the use of expedited removal, the fact that large numbers of migrants sought protection and/or could not easily be removed due to their nationality forced the Border Patrol to continue to rely on release with an NTA as its primary processing mechanism" [23]. Family units drive the pattern, since detention of families is time-limited: the Border Patrol "aims to quickly process and release families (and unaccompanied children) from custody," and surges in family migration translate directly into NTA issuance [23]. The systemic consequence closes the loop with the backlog chapters: "the increased use of NTAs and parole creates a growing population of migrants with liminal statuses for extended periods of time, adding to the backlog of asylum and other cases in U.S. immigration courts and leaving migrants in legal limbo for years to come" [23]. Attempts to run the fast track without detention remain marginal: the Family Expedited Removal Management programme (May 2023), which conducts credible-fear interviews for families in a "nondetained but monitored setting," processed "just 1,600 families between May and September 2023" [23].

Geography and federalism complete the picture. Sectors differ by terrain — "miles of coastline in San Diego to sand dunes in Yuma and remote desert locations in Del Rio" — and agents themselves describe fencing "primarily as a means of increasing field capacity by slowing down migrants and smugglers," with AI-equipped mobile surveillance "described as critical for daily operations" [23]. States now legislate inside the federal system: Texas's Operation Lone Star (March 2021) deployed National Guard and state police to build fencing and arrest migrants for trespassing — welcomed in some border communities, criticised for uncoordinated fencing in El Paso and for high-speed chases

causing “bystander injuries and fatalities,” and escalated in July 2023 with a Rio Grande buoy-and-razor-wire barrier linked to two deaths that month [23]. Texas Senate Bill 4 (November 2023) went further, making unauthorised entry a state misdemeanour and authorising state judges to order returns to Mexico, with implementation expected in February 2024 under multiple lawsuits [23]. The case study’s lesson for the wider report is that a modern border is less a line than a queue-management system under legal constraint: its outputs are determined not at the fence but by detention limits, removal feasibility by nationality, court capacity downstream, and an increasingly crowded field of state and federal actors whose instruments work at cross purposes.

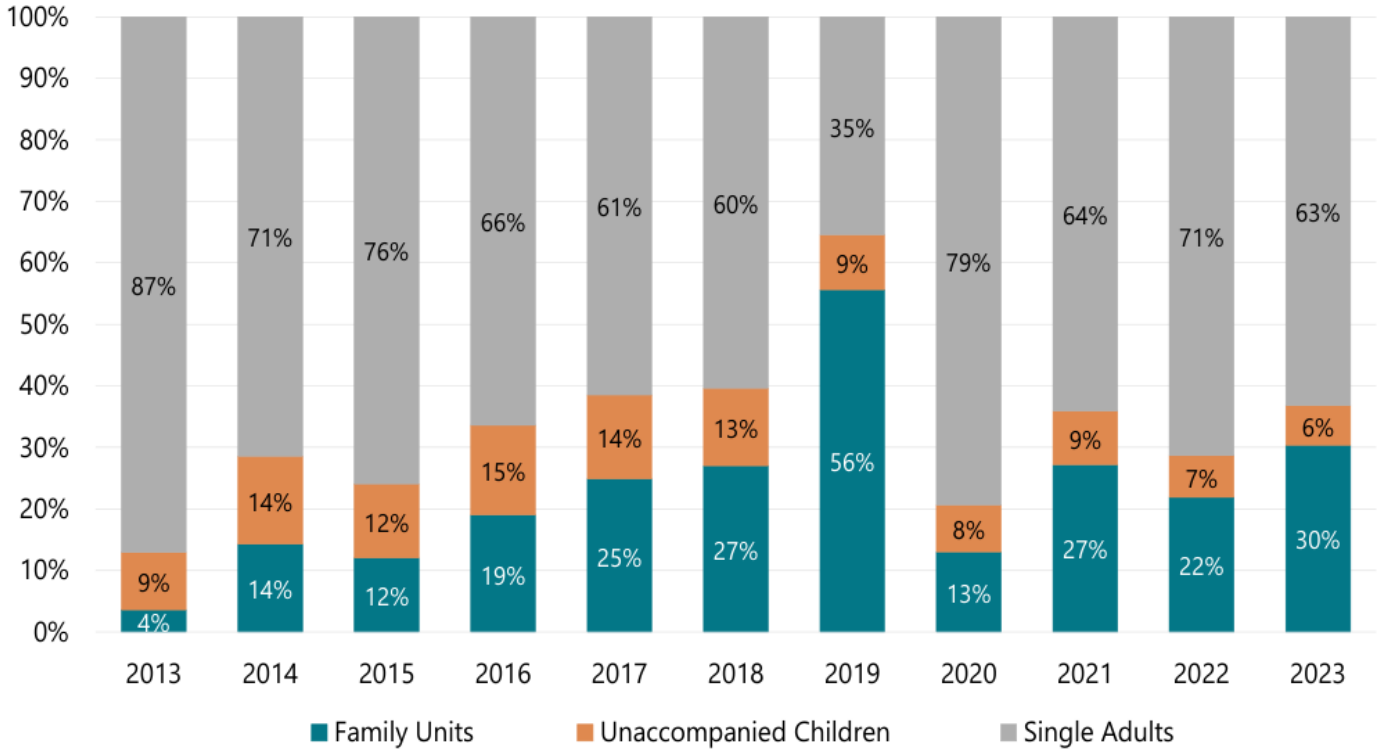


Exhibit. United States Border Patrol encounters at the U.S.–Mexico border are broken down by type from fiscal 2013 to 2023, showing how the composition of encounters shifted across the decade. Source: S0018.

Border enforcement: practices, spillover effects, and difficult trade-offs

Enforcement begins from the structural trap the irregular-migration chapters established: acute origin–destination differentials pressing against severe entry restrictions generate the smuggling market, and asylum becomes the residual door — a claim “prevents their immediate deportation because it initiates a review process,” in systems “ill-equipped to process large numbers of people efficiently,” whose delays themselves become an asset to the claimant [8]. Every enforcement practice is an attempt to escape that trap, and each relocates rather than removes the pressure.

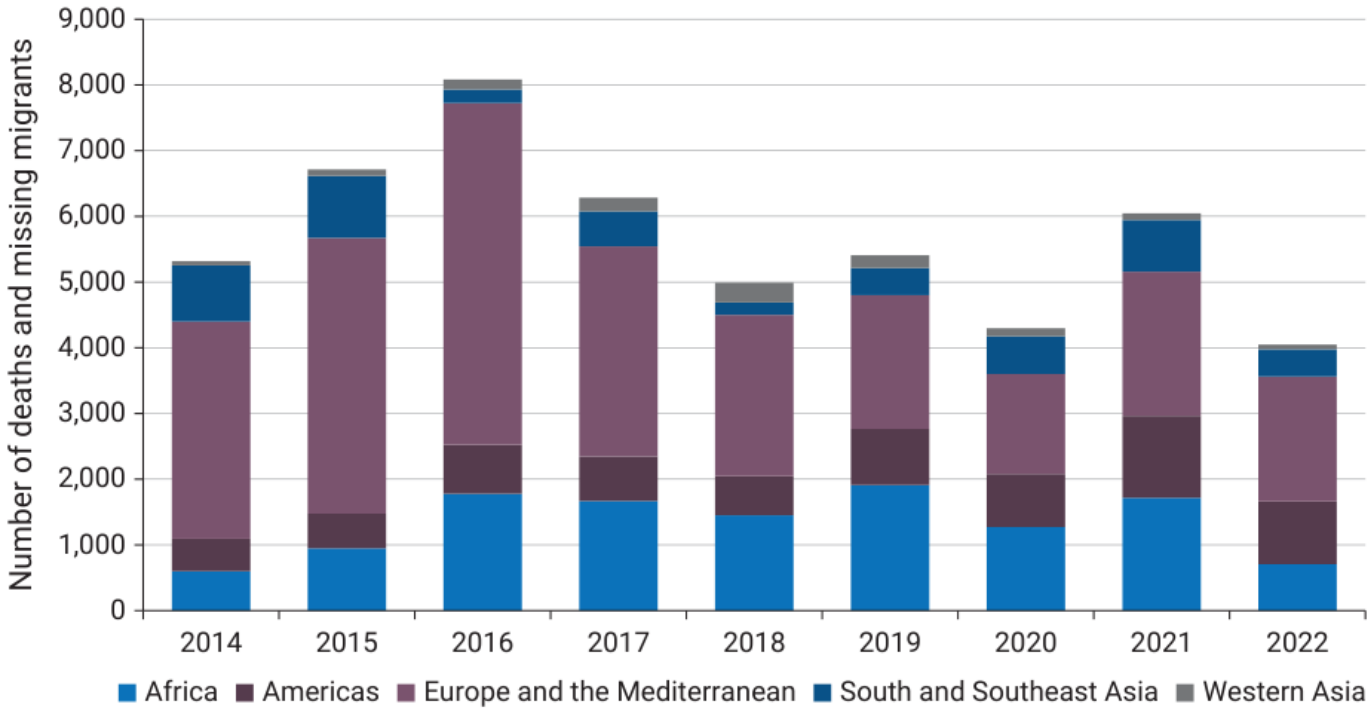
The dominant relocation strategy of the past two decades is **externalisation**: “several high-income destination countries have entered into agreements with other countries—typically low- or middle-income countries—to shift border control or asylum processing functions away from their physical borders” [8]. The WDR’s catalogue spans the repertoire. Italy’s agreements with Libya fund and equip Libyan coast-guard patrols against Mediterranean departures. Australia’s arrangements with Papua New Guinea and Nauru offshore both processing and settlement of boat arrivals, sweetened by a “package of assistance and other bilateral cooperation” (the PNG agreement ended in late 2021). The EU–Türkiye bargain traded returns of irregular crossers to the Greek islands for Syrian resettlement places, refugee funding, and visa facilitation for Turkish citizens. The 2019 US–Mexico arrangement had Mexico take “unprecedented steps” to increase its own enforcement and hold US asylum seekers during adjudication. The UK–Rwanda partnership would send irregular arrivals to lodge their claims in Rwanda, with development funding attached [8].

The spillovers are legal, humanitarian and diplomatic. “In the absence of sufficient safeguards,” the WDR warns, implementation “can contravene countries’ legal obligations related to due process and the nonpenalization of asylum-seekers (non-refoulement) and human rights” [8]. Italy’s Libya arrangement was condemned by the European Court of Human Rights and denounced by the UN Special Rapporteur on the Human Rights of Migrants as “exposing dis-

tressed migrants to death, torture, sexual and gender-based violence, labor exploitation, and other forms of contemporary slavery"; Papua New Guinea's Supreme Court found the detention of Australia's transferees unconstitutional [8]. Externalisation also converts migration control into a tradable asset for transit states — the EU–Türkiye visa and funding terms, the assistance packages — giving partners leverage that must be re-purchased whenever flows resume, and pushing risk onto the migrants displaced into the partner's weaker protection system.

The alternative paradigm, visible in the post-Title 42 US regime of May 2023, is channelled deterrence: expand scheduled, lawful arrival while penalising the unscheduled kind. Its instruments pair the CBP One appointment system at ports of entry (entrants receiving parole, typically two years) with the Circumvention of Lawful Pathways rule — migrants crossing between ports, or arriving without an appointment, are treated as ineligible for asylum unless previously denied protection in a transit country — plus nationality-specific sponsorship parole programmes for Cubans, Haitians, Nicaraguans and Venezuelans, and a regional network of Safe Mobility Offices intended to divert would-be irregular migrants into lawful pathways [23]. Early results were genuinely mixed: apprehensions between ports "fell by 46 percent" between April and June 2023, "then increased each month through September," driven by families and Venezuelans; FY2023 closed with 2 million crossings between ports and 430,000 arrivals at ports [23].

MPI's diagnosis of why such regimes underperform returns to the queue: agencies "insufficiently equipped to respond effectively… must perpetually react and shift operations according to their strained capacity and daily changes in migrant arrivals," producing "unpredictable and arbitrary processing decisions," an inability to screen most arrivals for protection eligibility, and "spillover effects for U.S. and Mexican communities, local governments, and nongovernmental organizations" [23]. The study's conclusion generalises the trade-off: "border control cannot be achieved at the border alone" — the binding constraints sit in the adjudication and removal agencies behind the line (USCIS, ICE, EOIR, ORR), so enforcement surges at the fence mostly convert into backlog, limbo and bridge closures that tax lawful trade [23]. The difficult trade-offs are therefore threefold and structural: deterrence strong enough to change behaviour tends to breach protection obligations or export harm; externalisation buys distance at the price of partner leverage and legal exposure; and channelled systems work only as well as the lawful channels' capacity — enforcement, in the end, is a rationing decision about where the queue will stand.



Source: Missing Migrants Project (dashboard), International Organization for Migration, Geneva, https://missingmigrants.iom.int/.

Exhibit. Thousands of migrants die or go missing in transit every year, with annual deaths from 2014 to 2022 broken down by region of origin and the Americas, Africa and Europe among the deadliest regions. Source: S0010.

Detention and processing capacity

Detention is where the border system's abstractions become physical: beds, pods, hours. The US build-out has been rapid and explicitly temporary in form — "Border Patrol's expanded use of soft-sided, tent-like facilities to re-

duce processing times, improve migrant care," and free agents for frontline enforcement; by August 2023 the agency ran 13 such facilities, "each with the capacity to house between 600 to 2,000 migrants in pods," lifting total holding capacity past 23,000 people at any one time [23]. The staffing model splits custody from adjudication: 961 processing coordinators (a role created in April 2021) handle "migrant care, intake processing, and administrative and logistical support," and more than 1,300 contractors provide security, food, medical and child care — but "only agents can authorize case adjudications to issue NTAs or place migrants in removal proceedings," so the legal bottleneck persists inside the expanded physical plant [23].

Conditions inside the surge infrastructure are spartan by design and hazardous at overflow: "[m]igrants in pods sleep on mattresses on the floor with foil blankets," outdoor time varies, in some facilities "the lights remain on 24 hours a day," single adult men stay locked in their pods while family and child pods move more freely — and "when facilities are overcrowded, deficiencies in contractor-provided care can lead to harmful conditions for migrants, including reported deaths" [23]. The facilities are engineered as transfer hubs as much as holding space: ICE personnel are embedded to serve notices, schedule removal flights and distribute alternatives-to-detention technology such as GPS-enabled phones; dozens of private booths let USCIS conduct credible-fear interviews virtually; ORR coordinates child transfers without an in-person presence; and "[l]egal service providers are not authorized to enter these facilities, which reduces migrants' access to in-person representation during processing" [23].

The decisive feature of the system is that its capacity is a cascade, not a stock. "[T]he capacity of secondary agencies such as ORR, USCIS, and ICE can have a major impact on how migrant processing plays out": when they cannot take custody, interview, or remove, "Border Patrol may end up detaining migrants beyond the intended 72-hour period, or their initial disposition may change" [23]. Each gate is capacity-conditional — a notice-to-appear with arrest warrant transfers to ICE custody only if ICE has beds, failing which the migrant is released under monitoring; exhausted removal capacity lengthens Border Patrol detention; and "[i]n turn, longer detention periods in Border Patrol facilities may overwhelm those facilities' capacity during spikes in migrant arrivals, resulting in added pressure to release migrants with temporary parole" [23]. Detention and release are thus the same dial at different settings: the system's real capacity is set by its slowest downstream agency, and every upstream surge is resolved by some mixture of longer custody and wider release.

The child-detention record from Australia's offshore system shows what prolonged processing custody does when the cascade stalls for years rather than days. By end-March 2016 approximately 300 children remained in Australian immigration detention in some form — facilities, community detention or alternative places — down from the 2013 peak, but "[m]ore than 40 per cent of all people in Australian immigration detention are held for over a year," and among community detainees "more than half are held for over a year, with more than a third held for at least two years" [5]. On Nauru, used for offshore processing, "children and other vulnerable people are at risk of sexual and physical abuse, especially without an independent authority on the island to monitor service provider care," while children born in detention in Papua New Guinea lacked identity documentation altogether [5]. The comparison disciplines the capacity debate: processing detention is defensible as a short administrative interval and corrosive as a residence — which is precisely why the binding policy variable is not bed count but throughput, the speed at which the agencies behind the fence convert custody into decisions.

Deportation, returns, and readmission

Return is the displacement system's largest flow and its least voluntary-looking one at the current margin. In 2024 "more than 1.6 million refugees from 117 countries of origin returned from a total of 78 countries of asylum" — "the highest annual number of refugee returns since 2002, when nearly two million Afghans returned" — with 92 per cent of all returnees going to just four countries: Syria (512,700), South Sudan (404,700), Afghanistan (364,400) and Ukraine (209,100) [7]. The decade shares underline the bunching: of 1.7 million South Sudanese returns over ten years, nearly a quarter occurred in 2024 alone; of 1.1 million Syrian returns, nearly half; of 962,700 Afghan returns, over a third [7].

UNHCR's framework insists on the conditions that make return a solution rather than a relocation of harm: returns must "remain voluntary and take place in safety and dignity," and, per the Global Compact on Refugees' fourth objective, "for returns to be sustainable, especially on a large-scale, conditions in the countries of origin need to have improved sufficiently to support their reintegration. Lasting peace, or at least a cessation of fighting, is paramount" [7]. The 2024 caseload mostly fails that test on its own reporting: "[t]hese returns have occurred either because of adverse circumstances in the former country of asylum, or to countries where security concerns persist, peace remains elusive or the infrastructure is significantly degraded" [7]. Afghan returnees arrived in a country "gripped with

pervasive poverty, soaring unemployment, severely inadequate public services and widespread food insecurity," with women and girls returning to an environment where rights to education, movement and expression "are being systematically eroded"; many Ukrainians returned "partly due to challenges in accessing rights and services in host countries" — push factors at both ends [7]. Genuinely conducive returns exist in the same data — Nigeria (37,700, up 19 per cent, with government–UNHCR support for voluntary return "in safety and dignity"), Burundi (21,100), the Central African Republic (19,900) and Cameroon (17,700) — but they are the minority pattern [7].

Behind the adverse-conditions cases sits state pressure machinery of a specific, documentable kind. Pakistan's October 2023 "Illegal Foreigners' Repatriation Plan" announced a scheme "to expel all undocumented foreigners," and 813,300 Afghans returned from Pakistan between September 2023 and December 2024 across all return types, deportations included [7]. Iran followed the administrative route: in February 2025 it announced that Afghan headcount slips would not be extended beyond 20 March 2025, after which holders would be treated as undocumented "with no access to healthcare, medical services, real estate transactions and other public services" — status withdrawal as a return incentive [7]. Venezuela's government-run Plan Vuelta a la Patria, credited with some 300,000 repatriations since 2018, shows the origin-state variant, though UNHCR notes there are no official statistics [7].

For ordinary (non-refugee) migration, the WDR states the destination-country case and its limits in one passage. "Return migrants humanely": deportation "is always a tragedy for the individuals involved, but it may be necessary to ensure the sustainability of the migration system because it demonstrates to both citizens and would-be migrants that rules are enforced," while "enforcing returns is fraught with risks, including possible human rights violations" [8]. The binding constraint is cooperation: the Global Compact for Migration "calls for cooperation between states in facilitating safe, dignified return and readmission for migrants, as well as sustainable reintegration," because "[i]n practice, forced returns are exceedingly difficult if the origin countries do not cooperate" — sustainable agreements "should reflect the interests of both the destination and origin countries" and sit inside broader bilateral migration arrangements [8]. Readmission is therefore a negotiated commodity like externalised control, purchased with the same currencies — and the return statistics above suggest the system's centre of gravity is shifting from negotiated, condition-based return toward pressure-based return, in which the voluntariness the framework requires is engineered away by making asylum untenable rather than origin safe.

Governance: from national policy to global compacts

Global Compact for Migration and Global Compact on Refugees

December 2018 produced the closest thing migration has to a constitutional settlement: two framework documents adopted within days of each other, one for migrants, one for refugees. The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration — adopted by heads of state and government meeting in Morocco on 10–11 December 2018, reaffirming the 2016 New York Declaration — was, in IOM's assessment, "a groundbreaking milestone in the history of global migration governance," built on foundations laid since the early 2000s and "grounded in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development" [2] [2]. Its refugee twin, the Global Compact on Refugees, organises international cooperation around burden- and responsibility-sharing, with objectives spanning support to host countries, refugee self-reliance, expanded third-country solutions, and — its fourth objective — supporting "conditions in countries of origin for return in safety and dignity" [7].

The compacts' design choices explain both their adoption and their limits. Both are non-binding; the GCM negotiations repeatedly affirmed that "migration governance is a core element of national sovereignty," with international cooperation framed as occurring under, not above, national authority [2]. Implementation is deliberately differentiated: as the UN Secretary-General put it two years after adoption, "the implementation of the Global Compact is not an even process and will mean different things to different States" — a flexibility IOM's governance chapter treats as one of the compact's "main strengths," recognising "different capacities and priorities" [2]. The regime the compacts crown is multistakeholder rather than intergovernmental in the old sense: global migration governance "has evolved from international cooperation on migration towards its current multistakeholder regime under the guidance of the United Nations," bringing states together with civil society, migrants' organisations, local authorities and the private sector, coordinated through the UN Network on Migration [2].

Institutionally, the GCM created the review machinery the field had lacked. The 2022 International Migration Review Forum was "another milestone, as, for the first time, United Nations Member States and stakeholders discussed progress towards the objectives of the Global Compact for Migration, ending with a unanimous adoption of a Progress

Declaration" [2]. The genealogy matters for judging novelty: the WMR traces the line from the Global Commission on International Migration (launched 2003, reporting 2005) through the Global Forum on Migration and Development to the 2016 New York Declaration and the 2018 adoptions — migration, in its phrase, was "the last big multilateral issue being included in the work of the United Nations" [2].

The two-compact architecture also hard-codes the field's deepest seam. Refugees fall under a 1951 Convention with binding non-refoulement and a dedicated agency; migrants fall under a voluntary compact with objectives but no status — and the WMR 2020 governance analysis was devoted precisely to "complementarity, coherence and gaps between the two compacts," including the contested boundary cases (people fleeing disasters, or in refugee-like situations without recognition) that this report's displacement chapters show are growing fastest [2]. The compacts' operative content, where this report has tested it, is real but hortatory: the GCM's call for cooperation on "safe, dignified return and readmission" frames the readmission bargaining of the previous section without constraining it, and the GCR's return objective states the voluntariness standard that the 2024 return wave was measured against — and largely failed [8] [7]. The compacts are best read, then, as the governance layer's coordinating language: they name the standards (responsibility-sharing, self-reliance, safe return), convene the stakeholders, and run the review cycle — while the binding constraints on state behaviour remain where the enforcement chapters found them, in courts, capacity and bilateral bargaining power.

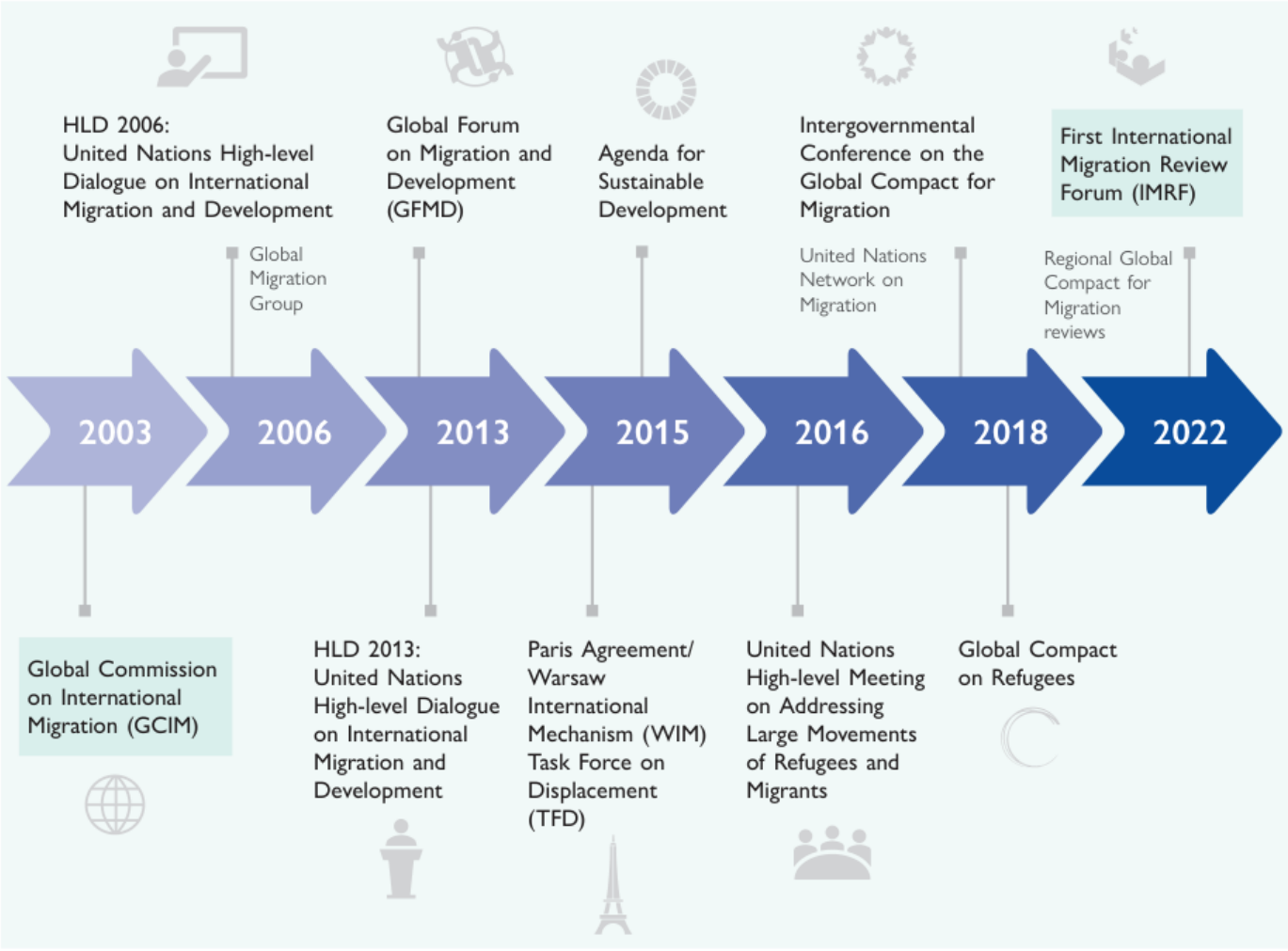


Exhibit. Key international events and processes from 2003 to 2022 — including the 2006 High-Level Dialogue, the Global Forum on Migration and Development, and the first International Migration Review Forum — chart the build-up to the global compacts. Source: S0001.

Multi-stakeholder migration governance

"Governance" in migration has a deliberately wide definition, and the width is the point. The Global Commission on International Migration defined it as assuming "a variety of forms, including the migration policies and programmes of individual countries, inter-State discussions and agreements, multilateral [forums] and consultative processes, the activities of international organizations, as well as relevant laws and norms" [2]. IOM's updated definition widens it

further: “[t]he combined frameworks of legal norms, laws and regulations, policies and traditions as well as organizational structures (subnational, national, regional and international) and the relevant processes that shape and regulate States’ approaches with regard to migration in all its forms, addressing rights and responsibilities, and promoting international cooperation” [2]. The contrast case is trade: “[u]nlike other areas of globalization – such as trade, for instance – there is no single regime governing human mobility at the global level” [2]. What exists instead is a regime complex — and, since 2018, one that formally seats non-state actors inside it.

The multi-stakeholder turn is the compacts’ main institutional innovation. The GCM’s implementation is expressly framed as a whole-of-society approach — the scholarly assessment in the report’s own references evaluates it in exactly those terms [2] — and the 2022 International Migration Review Forum operationalised it: alongside the intergovernmental sessions, the forum held an “informal interactive multi-stakeholder hearing” of civil society, migrant organisations and other stakeholders [2]. Civil society has organised for the role: the Civil Society Action Committee produced its own assessment paper on the IMRF, and the literature tracks a “global migrant rights movement” pressing democratisation of governance “from the bottom up” [2]. The stakeholder map the system now recognises spans international organisations (IOM, UNHCR, ILO and the UN Network on Migration as coordinator), national governments, subnational authorities — IOM’s Migration Governance Indicators have assessed migration governance “in dozens of countries and local authorities worldwide” — employers and unions, diaspora and migrant-led organisations, and academia [2] [2].

The analytic literature is equally clear about the costs of this proliferation. Kainz and Betts, again in the report’s reference apparatus, explain the field’s structure as “power and proliferation”: the fragmentation of global migration governance is not an accident to be tidied but an outcome of states forum-shopping among overlapping institutions whose mandates they can control [2]. The WMR’s own overview draws the operational conclusion: “Migration requires a truly whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach. Developments in global governance will only benefit all persons on the move if the emerging architecture accommodates this reality” [2]. Read against this report’s evidence chapters, multi-stakeholder governance is best understood as the system’s adaptation to its own fragmentation: where no single regime can bind, coordination itself becomes the governance technology — standards diffused through indicators and review forums, services delivered by NGOs and cities, protection monitored by civil society, and employers and origin states bargained with bilaterally. Its weakness is the mirror of its strength: everyone is a stakeholder, so no one is accountable — the IMRF’s unanimous Progress Declaration coexisted, in the same years, with the externalisation deals, detention cascades and pressure-driven returns documented in the preceding chapters.

Regularization and amnesties: country experiences

Regularisation is the irregular system’s pressure valve, and its scale is larger than the politics around it suggests. In Europe alone, “over 6 million people have applied to transit from irregular to legal status over the decade to 2007, with an approval rate of 80 percent” — Italy processing the most applications (1.5 million), followed by Spain and Greece — and “[m]ost European countries have operated some form of regularization programme, albeit for a range of motives and, in some cases, despite denying that regularization takes place (Austria and Germany)” [4]. The instrument is not an OECD peculiarity. Under the MERCOSUR regional agreement, “Argentina… has legislated that any citizen of a MERCOSUR country without a criminal background can obtain legal residence”; South Africa moved to regularise irregular Zimbabweans through a temporary residence permit granting access to health care and education and the right to stay and work for at least six months; Thailand regularised 135,000 migrants in early 2008, though there “periods of regularization were followed by stepped-up rates of deportation” [4].

The largest recent case reframes regularisation as mass status policy rather than case-by-case mercy. Colombia’s 2021 temporary protection statute for Venezuelans — “more than 1.8 million permits granted so far” — regularised a displaced population wholesale [2]. IOM’s gender chapter states the structural rationale: regularisation schemes “are often not considered regular migration pathways, although they are intrinsically complementary, filling the gaps in and the flaws of regular pathways when those create situations of irregularity,” and they “effectively reduce vulnerabilities associated with irregularity” — other schemes have targeted specific sectors such as domestic work or fishing [2].

The evaluation literature is honestly mixed, and the HDR’s summary of country experience gives both sides. For destination states the gains “relate to security and the rule of law,” while regularised individuals “may be better placed to overcome social and economic exclusion”; against stand the standard objections — “concerns about encouraging future flows, the undermining of formal admissions programmes and fraudulent applications” [4]. Context decides the

fiscal arithmetic: “in the United States many irregular immigrants already pay taxes, so the revenue benefits are much lower than in countries with large informal economies, where taxes are avoided on a much larger scale”; and “[s]urveys of country experiences have tended to conclude that the socio-economic impacts of regularization have been mixed, with the expected positive impacts on wages, mobility and integration not always materializing” [4]. The human stakes behind the statistics are visible in the deportation data the same report cites: a survey of Salvadoran deportees found a quarter had lived in the United States for over 20 years and about four-fifths were working when deported, many with US-born children — long-settled populations are what the regularise-or-remove choice actually governs [4].

Design has converged on a middle instrument between blanket amnesty and case-by-case discretion (the US family-ties mechanism being the discretionary archetype): **earned regularisation**. It provides “a provisional permit to live and work in the host country, initially for a finite period, which can be extended or made permanent through the fulfilment of various criteria, such as language acquisition, maintaining stable employment and paying taxes” — “[t]here is no initial amnesty but rather a conditional permission to transit to full residence status,” an approach the HDR judges “the most viable way forward” partly because of its potential for “broad public acceptance” [4]. The European experience adds implementation ingredients: “the involvement of civil society organizations, migrant associations and employers in planning and implementation; guarantee against expulsion during the process; and clear qualifying criteria (for example, length of residence, employment record and family ties)” — against recurring failures of long delays and, in locally administered schemes such as France’s, “variable treatment across locations” [4]. Permanence pathways complete the design space: several states let temporary status convert after years of regular residence — Italy after six years, Portugal and the United Kingdom after five — typically conditioned on labour-market record and clean criminal history [4]. The pattern across experiences is that regularisation works as system maintenance rather than as an event: states that admit their channels manufacture irregularity end up regularising repeatedly, and the policy question is only whether they do so by design — earned, criteria-based, protected against expulsion mid-process — or by episodic amnesty under pressure.

Integration outcomes and lessons

Integration is the stage where migration policy either compounds or wastes everything spent upstream, and it is the stage the system measures worst. The standard policy yardstick, the Migrant Integration Policy Index (MIPEX), in place since 2007 and “rolled out in 56 countries across six continents, identifies and measures integration policies across eight areas: labour market mobility, education, political participation, access to nationality, health care, family reunion, permanent residence and anti-discrimination” [2]. The governance yardstick is broader still: IOM’s Migration Governance Indicators comprise “90+ indicators… based on the six principles and objectives of the IOM Migration Governance Framework, grounded in target 10.7 of the Sustainable Development Goals, and aligned to the 23 objectives of the Global Compact for Migration,” with 92 countries and 52 subnational authorities assessed and 18 follow-up assessments building a longitudinal record [2]. But the chapter states the limitation plainly: “the MGI is limited insofar as it focuses on the existence of migration governance structures, with limited assessment of how policies are implemented and no assessment of the outcomes of those policies” — which is why the IMRF Progress Declaration (paragraph 70) commissioned a dedicated GCM indicator set, with a UN Network on Migration workstream co-led by IOM and UN DESA developing it [2].

The outcome evidence, as assembled in the World Development Report’s reference base, converges on four findings. First, refugees integrate more slowly than otherwise-similar migrants — the “refugee gap” in economic outcomes documented by Connor (2010) and surveyed for high-income countries by Brell, Dustmann and Preston (2020) in the Journal of Economic Perspectives — reflecting interrupted careers, credential loss and the asylum process itself rather than capability [8]. Second, the gap’s slope is policy-sensitive: Danish register evidence (Clausen et al., 2009) shows integration policies measurably change “the time until regular employment of newly arrived immigrants,” and a field experiment (Battisti, Giesing and Laurentsyeva, 2019) finds job-search assistance improves refugees’ labour-market integration — while Denmark’s work-first approach for refugees has its own evaluated literature (Arendt, 2022) [8]. Third, networks mediate outcomes: Beaman’s study of US-resettled refugees shows co-national networks shape labour-market dynamics for better and worse, and Bailey and co-authors (2022) map the social integration of Syrians in Germany through their network formation [8]. Fourth, the long run is strongly positive where status is secure: Abramitzky, Boustan, Jácome and Pérez (2021) document immigrants’ intergenerational mobility in the US over two centuries; Baker (2015) finds immigrant legalisation reduced crime; and Bahar, Ibáñez and Rozo (2021) evaluate the labour-market effects of Colombia’s large-scale amnesty for Venezuelans — the regularisation programme of the previous chapter — in the Journal of Development Economics [8] [8].

The lessons compose into a sequence this report has been building implicitly. Status security is the master input: the refugee gap is widest where asylum limbo is longest (the backlog chapters), the legalisation dividend appears where status is granted early, and integration spending yields least where it substitutes for status rather than following it. Timing beats intensity: early labour-market access and search assistance move employment dates by years, while classroom-first sequencing delays them. Networks are infrastructure: dispersal policies that ignore co-national networks discard a job-finding asset, as the networks literature shows. And measurement must graduate from structures to outcomes — the MGI's own acknowledged gap — because the field currently scores governments on the policies they announce rather than the employment, education and naturalisation trajectories their migrants actually achieve. Integration, in short, is where the queue logic of the earlier chapters either resolves into membership or hardens into a permanent outsider class; the evidence says the difference is made early, by status and first-job speed, more than by any later programme.

Migrant rights, discrimination, and xenophobia

The World Development Report's Spotlight 6 states the framing this section follows: "[m]igration policies and impacts cannot be fully understood without acknowledging how race and ethnicity shape individual and community experiences at all stages of cross-border movements — in normative frameworks, as drivers of movement, in explicit and tacit criteria for entry, and in treatment at the destination." Its drivers are named plainly — "racism, xenophobia, ethnic animosities, and religious prejudice" — and its scope is universal: "[p]laying out in countries at all income levels, they aggravate human distress and result in inequitable opportunities and outcomes" [8]. Discrimination is therefore not an attitudinal footnote to the migration system; it is one of its allocation mechanisms, operating at the border (entry criteria), in the labour market (the occupational downgrading and exploitation floors of earlier chapters) and in politics.

The political-economy evidence in the report's base refines the contact hypothesis into a conditional one. Steinmayr's study, titled "Contact versus Exposure: Refugee Presence and Voting for the Far Right" (Review of Economics and Statistics, 2021), distinguishes mere exposure to refugees from actual contact with them — the voting effects run in opposite directions — while Dustmann, Vasiljeva and Piil Damm (2019) trace refugee migration's electoral outcomes in Denmark and Halla, Wagner and Zweimüller (2017) estimate immigration's effect on far-right voting in Austria [8]. Tabellini (2020) shows the pattern is not new: the age of mass migration produced both immigrant economic gifts and native political backlash, with redistribution conflict mediating the response [8]. Opinion research (Sides and Citrin, 2007) finds European attitudes structured by identities, interests and information jointly — and the information term is manipulable: Williamson's (2020) experiment shows "countering misperceptions" measurably reduces prejudice toward Muslim Americans [8]. The HDR adds a cross-national regularity: publics in countries where the migrant stock is relatively high tend to favour equal treatment of migrants — familiarity at national scale correlates with tolerance even where local exposure can inflame [4].

The HDR also specifies the system's most dangerous feedback loop. "Economic and security concerns can sometimes reinforce each other, in what becomes a vicious circle. Migrants who are marginalized — due, for example, to temporary or irregular status or high levels of unemployment — may resort to anti-social or criminal behaviour, confirming the security fears of locals. If this leads to further discrimination in the labour market and in policy formation, such migrants may turn away from the new society back to the old, possibly forming gangs or other anti-social organizations that threaten local populations" — a pathology the report observes among some young Maghrebians in France [4]. The loop's policy implication cuts against intuition: status insecurity and labour-market exclusion are not neutral enforcement by-products but inputs into the very insecurity invoked to justify them — the same inversion the detention and backlog chapters documented institutionally.

Two correctives complete the picture. First, exclusion is not a rich-country monopoly: Zhou's work on refugee resentment and national identity in Africa and on "migrant exclusion within the Global South," alongside Abel's (2017) labour-market discrimination evidence from South Africa in the report's references, locates the phenomenon in the South–South systems that carry most of the world's movement [8]. Second, rights themselves have practical limits as a remedy: Voss, Silva and Bloemraad's "The Limits of Rights: Claims-Making on Behalf of Immigrants" (2020) examines how rights claims succeed or fail depending on organisational and political conditions, not merely legal text [8]. The section's conclusion is structural: because discrimination operates through entry criteria, labour markets and electoral feedback simultaneously, anti-discrimination policy cannot be a communications add-on — it is continuous with status policy, integration speed and the accuracy of public information, and its failures compound through exactly the queues and limbo states the preceding chapters measured.

Development and the migration question

Root causes and development: does prosperity stem migration

"Root causes" is the destination world's favourite long-run answer to unwanted migration: develop the origin country, and the flow will subside. The Americas provide the best-funded test of the idea. In 2014 the governments of El Salvador, Guatemala and Honduras adopted the Alliance for Prosperity in the Northern Triangle, "a plan aimed at addressing the root causes of migration by boosting security and economic development in the region," and from 2016 the US Congress appropriated USD 1.4 billion for engagement in Central America, including through the Alliance (USD 750 million in FY2016, USD 655 million in FY2017) [22]. MPI's assessment identifies the design flaw immediately: the Alliance "does not, however, specifically address the protection needs of displaced persons" — yet the Northern Triangle flow was driven substantially by violence and protection needs, not only by income gaps [22]. A development plan aimed at a protection flow treats the wrong variable.

The complementary instruments of the same period concede the point by their design. The Central American Minors (CAM) programme, launched in 2014, let parents lawfully present in the United States request resettlement interviews for their children in-country, "to make dangerous travel less necessary for young people escaping violence": some 13,000 applications were filed, approximately 1,500 minors were admitted as refugees and 1,400 paroled, and thousands of cases were still pending when the programme was phased out in 2017 [22]. The 2016 Protection Transfer Arrangement with Costa Rica, UNHCR and IOM prescreened the most urgent protection cases for transfer and processing [22]. These are pathway instruments, not development instruments — an implicit admission that for people fleeing violence now, prosperity in a decade is not a substitute for an exit today.

The framework scaled up rather than changed character in the 2020s. The 2022 Los Angeles Declaration on Migration and Protection, signed by 21 countries across the hemisphere, committed signatories to "generating stability and assistance for communities hosting large displaced migrant populations; expanding legal pathways; strengthening protection systems; and increasing coordination on migration management and emergency responses," backed by nearly USD 485 million in US assistance for migrants, host communities and vulnerable populations [23]. Its operational arms mix the same ingredients — Safe Mobility Offices (inaugurated in Guatemala and Costa Rica in June 2023, Colombia in July, Ecuador in October) to route people into lawful pathways, restarted removal flights, and a US–Colombia–Panama anti-smuggling campaign in the Darién Gap that "has been uneven and ineffective at reducing irregular migration" [23].

MPI's synthesis of the regional record states the defensible version of root-causes policy: pair destination-system repair "with regional efforts to address the conditions spurring migration northward," working on both tracks at once — "the severe security challenges and development needs driving displacement" in origin countries, and asylum capacity in Mexico and other regional states "to receive, identify, adjudicate, and integrate asylum seekers" [22]. Three qualifications from this report's earlier evidence discipline the prosperity hypothesis further. First, the drivers are heterogeneous: violence-driven flows respond to security and protection, climate-driven flows to adaptation, and wage-driven flows to differentials so large (the four-to-six-fold place premium) that no plausible aid programme closes them on a political timescale. Second, development assistance is small against the flows it targets — USD 1.4 billion across three countries over years, against remittance streams and smuggling markets of comparable or larger annual scale in single corridors. Third — the subject of the next section — rising prosperity in poor countries historically increases emigration before it reduces it, by financing the move and raising aspirations faster than local opportunities grow. Root-causes spending is therefore best justified on its own terms (security, development, host-community stability) and as the price of regional cooperation on pathways and protection — not as a near-term migration-control instrument, a role the record does not support.

The migration hump: development first raises, then lowers emigration

The previous section's policy question — will prosperity stem migration? — has an empirical answer, and it is shaped like a hump. Start at the bottom of the income distribution: "low-income countries have low emigration rates, an explanation being that low income levels are an obstacle in accumulating the funds needed to undertake migration." The condition has a name — **involuntary immobility**, people "who would like to migrate internationally are unable to do so for a number of reasons, including costs" [2]. Poverty, in other words, traps as well as pushes. As incomes rise, the constraint relaxes before the motive fades: "emigration increases with higher income levels, and… at a certain point, higher incomes enabling increased emigration can then become a stabilizing influence and reduce

outward migration. In other words, as GDP per capita increases, emigration initially increases and then decreases" — the pattern analysts call the mobility transition, depicted in the chapter's Figure 3 after Clemens (2014) [2].

The hump's peak has an estimated address. "Clemens's analysis estimates that emigration rates start to decrease if countries rise above GDP per capita income levels of USD 7,000–8,000," a band that in the 2005 PPP data included Ecuador, Egypt, Fiji and North Macedonia [2]. Below that band the correlation runs the policy-inconvenient way: Clemens and Postel's (2018) review, cited in the chapter, finds that "economic growth has historically raised emigration in almost all developing countries." The chapter is explicit about why the finding matters: the mobility-transition literature "calls into question the commonly held notion that overseas development assistance will act to 'stabilize' populations and dampen emigration rates from low-income countries by providing greater opportunities at home" [2]. Aid that succeeds economically should be expected, on this evidence, to raise emigration from poor countries for a generation — financing journeys, spreading information and networks, and lifting aspirations toward the standards visible through them — before the declining arm of the hump is reached.

The chapter is equally explicit that the science is unsettled, in three specific ways. First, functional form: some scholars identify "a so-called 'plateau'" rather than a hump, questioning "the notion that emigration rates decline as countries develop over time" [2]. Second, period sensitivity: analyses over shorter windows find "economic growth in poor countries coincides with less emigration," a result the chapter notes "has been hotly contested with the discussion focusing on technical errors in modelling" [2]. Third, measurement: in the 1960–2019 emigration-prevalence data the confidence bands are so wide "that we cannot be certain that emigration declines with higher incomes; however, emigration prevalence is non-linear (meaning that there is not a straightforward positive relationship between emigration rates and country income levels)" [2]. A further bias runs through the literature itself: it "focuses on emigration from low-income countries, almost certainly due to the preoccupation in policy and academic spheres with (irregular) migration to very high HDI countries," while much actual emigration occurs between wealthy countries [2].

What survives the contestation is robust enough to govern policy expectations. The rising arm is not in serious doubt: the poorest societies emigrate least, capability constraints bind first, and development relaxes them — which is why the global migrant stock is drawn disproportionately from middle-income countries, and why the involuntary-immobility population (the 750 million Gallup counted as wanting to move, in this report's earlier chapters) so vastly exceeds the flow. The declining arm is plausible, historically visible in countries that completed the transition (the European emigration giants of 1900 are today's immigration countries), but its timing and income threshold are estimates, not laws. For the root-causes agenda the implication is a sequencing warning: development assistance to poor countries is a long-run emigration increase on any honest forecast, defensible — as the previous section concluded — for its own benefits and for the cooperation it buys, and self-defeating if sold to destination publics as a near-term brake on arrivals.

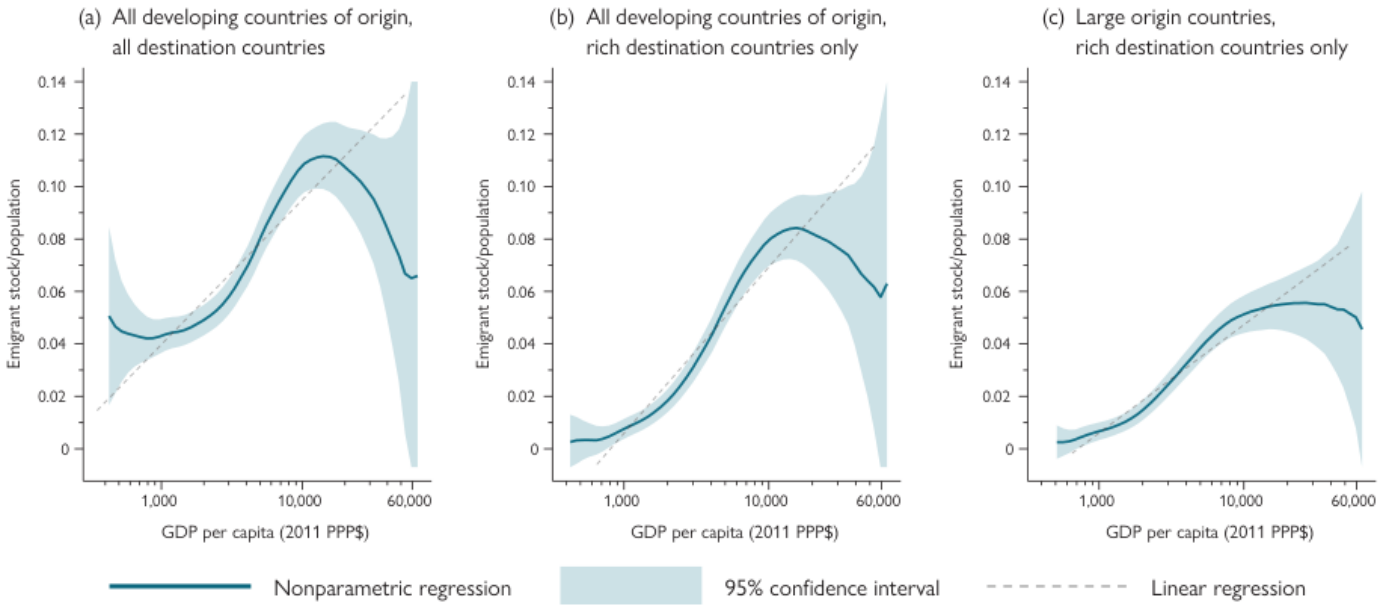


Exhibit. Emigration prevalence from 1960 to 2019 is tracked for developing countries of origin overall and for large origin countries, split by all destinations and rich destinations only, tracing the hump's long-run shape. Source: S0001.

Human development outcomes for movers

The Human Development Report's founding exhibit is a map. Along the US–Mexico border, human development outcomes sort almost perfectly by side: "the lowest HDI in a United States border county (Starr County, Texas) is above even the highest on the Mexican side (Mexicali Municipality, Baja California)" — Starr County at 0.766 against Mexicali's 0.757 — suggesting "that moving across national borders can greatly expand the opportunities available for improved well-being" [4]. The same gradient appears when movement is unleashed internally: as China "progressively liberalized its strict regime of internal restrictions" between 1984 and 1995, "[m]assive flows followed, largely towards regions with higher levels of human development" [4]. People vote with their feet for the HDI map.

The rigorous estimates survive the selection correction — movers differ systematically from stayers, and the studies the HDR cites "carefully disentangle these complex relations" — and remain very large: "individuals with only moderate levels of formal education who move from a typical developing country to the United States can reap an annual income gain of approximately US$10,000 — roughly double the average level of per capita income in a developing country" [4]. The gains are not only monetary: "[b]ackground research commissioned for this report found that a family who migrates from Nicaragua to Costa Rica increases the probability that their child will be enrolled in primary school by 22 percent" [4]. Movement also buys exits that income doesn't capture — from armed conflict, political repression, and "the traditional roles that they were expected to fulfil in their society of origin" [4].

Against this, the HDR insists on the distribution: "vast inequalities characterize not only the freedom to move but also the distribution of gains from movement. When the poorest migrate, they often do so under conditions of vulnerability that reflect their limited resources and choices. The prior information they have may be limited or misleading" [4]. The extreme case is gendered and global: "[a]buse of migrant female domestic workers occurs in many cities and countries around the world, from Washington and London to Singapore and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states," and research in the Arab states found abusive, exploitative domestic-work conditions with no redress mechanisms trapping women "in a vicious circle of poverty and HIV vulnerability" — compounded by regimes that "test migrants for HIV and deport those found to carry the virus," with few origin countries running reintegration programmes for those forcibly returned [4]. The mover's expected gain is large; the variance is larger, and it is allocated by the same status and bargaining-power gradients the exploitation chapters measured.

Finally, the report relocates the centre of gravity: most human-development-relevant movement is internal. "In terms of the number of people involved, internal migration far exceeds external migration. An estimated 136 million people have moved in China alone, and 42 million in India, so the totals for just these two countries approach the global stock of people who have crossed frontiers" [4]. International moves carry costs that "tend to be regressive" — fees and travel — plus the "heavy if unquantifiable psychological burden" of leaving networks behind, which is why the HDR's mobility principles are addressed first to national governments: remove barriers to internal mobility, guarantee movers full civic, economic and social rights, and never make movement a precondition for basic services [4] [4]. The development verdict of the whole movement is thus double: for the individual mover, mobility is the single largest available human-development intervention — worth roughly a doubling of income plus schooling and safety gains — and the binding constraint on realising it is not motivation but the rationing of the right to move, whose relaxation, internal or international, is where the unrealised gains sit.

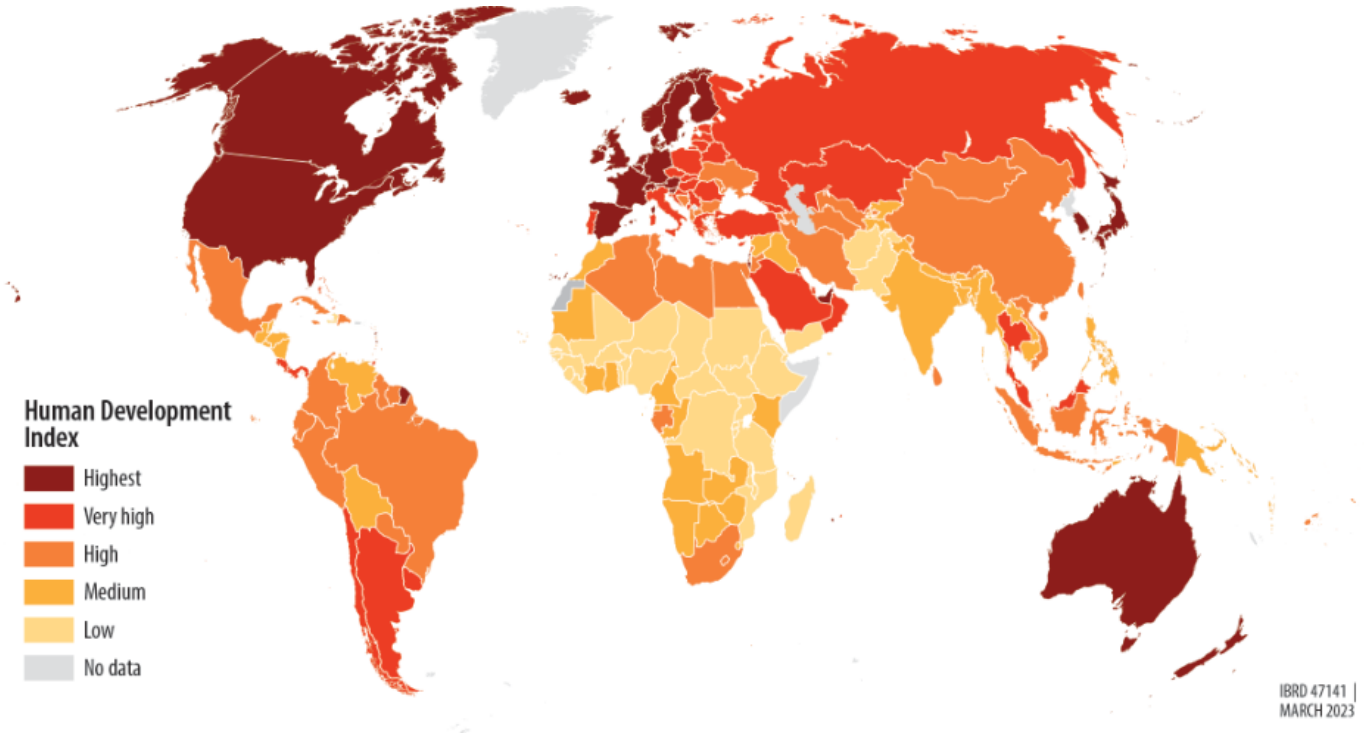


Exhibit. A heat map based on 2021 Human Development Index data displays the global imbalances in development that drive migration movements between low- and high-HDI countries. Source: S0010.

Climate adaptation as an alternative to migration

The section's title poses a choice the evidence dissolves. In the World Migration Report's climate chapter, migration is not the failure of adaptation but one of its working forms: "[m]igration appears as a coping or adaptation option among other strategies when households are confronted with the impacts of climate hazards," pursued "more so when faced with structural poverty, limited access to land and land ownership, and in the face of detrimental climatic conditions affecting their crops" [2]. In low- and middle-income countries adaptive migration runs mostly rural-to-urban, while longer international moves finance the origin household "via remittances" [2]. The adaptation dividend is documented at household level across regions: South Asian mobilities "have promoted climate resilience in sending communities"; "remittances help households to adapt as well as facilitate agricultural adaptation, which ensures greater food security"; in northern Thailand, small-scale farming innovation "has been related to translocal migration networks"; in Nepal, "remittance-recipient households are more likely to invest a part of their savings in flood preparedness if the women staying behind have access to capacity-building interventions" in precautionary savings and flood readiness [2]. The consumption floor matters as much as investment: in Burkina Faso "even where rainfall variability has a negative impact on food security, remittances are found to enhance food security," Indian internal migrants' remittances go mostly to daily consumption including food, and Bangladeshi households "adapt to climate stressors by combining local-level adaptation measures with the migration of one or a few members of their households" — portfolio adaptation, not flight [2].

The in-situ alternative is real but complementary, and the chapter states the ordering explicitly: "[a]daptive migration should not substitute for investment in adaptive capacity-building in situ. However, with adequate support and inclusion in guiding strategies, it certainly has the potential to benefit communities in exposed locations to build adaptive capacity" [2]. Water systems, crop switching, flood defences and social protection raise the threshold at which movement becomes necessary — the Groundswell modelling of earlier chapters is precisely a comparison of futures with and without such investment — while migration handles the residual: the households and places where in-situ adaptation runs out, and the income diversification that funds adaptation for those who stay. Framing the two as substitutes mistakes a portfolio for a fork.

The under-examined side of the ledger is the destination. "Research has focused more on understanding how migration and environmental change relates to climate assessments at the origin of the migrating communities, and less on the receiving communities" [2]. What is known is sobering: Zimbabwean migrants in South African cities "face a high level of malnutrition upon arrival," driven by irregular income and receiving-community opposition; and the receiving cities inherit compounded climate risk — "[w]ithout adequate adaptation interventions and urban planning, the infrastructure of urban centres receiving climate-related migrants will also be at increased and compounding

risk," through informal settlement expansion in risk-prone areas, coastal sea-level exposure, and water demand rising with arrivals [2]. Political mediation compounds the physical: outcomes are "largely mediated by the perception of migrants in the receiving communities," and inflated projections "can cause a misinterpretation of the scale of migration, leading to xenophobia and triggering potential security concerns, despite little evidence that migrants pose security threats at State or international levels" [2]. The adaptation-as-alternative question therefore resolves into a governance question: whether movement is planned — pathways open, receiving cities investing, remittance channels cheap — so that migration performs its demonstrated adaptation function, or unplanned, in which case the same movement arrives as distress migration at destinations that have not adapted to receive it.

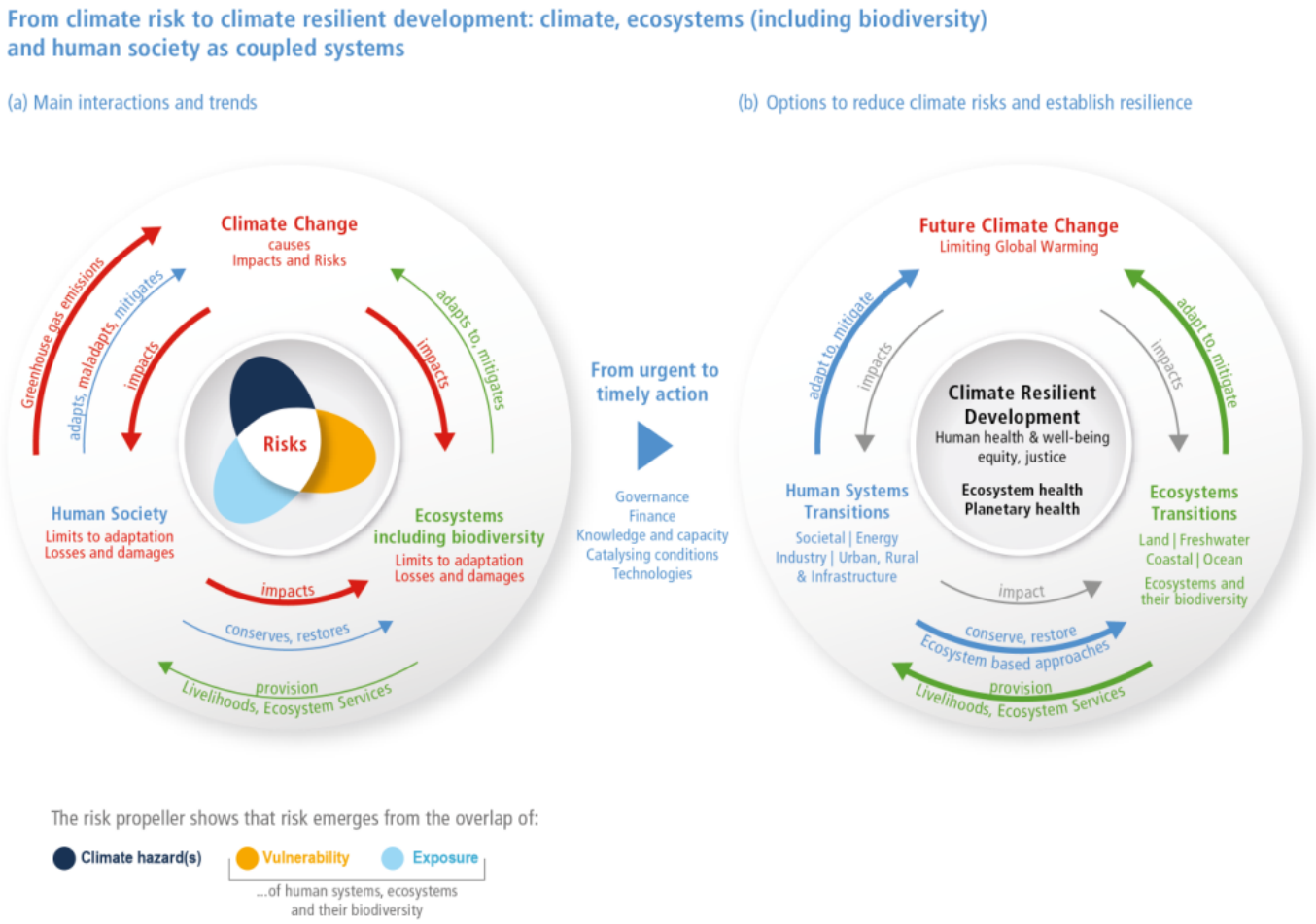


Exhibit. Interactions among the coupled systems of climate, ecosystems including their biodiversity, and human society frame the assessment's focus on climate risks, adaptation and vulnerability. Source: S0017.

Data, methods, and the 200-year forecast

Data sources and measurement challenges

Every number in this report rests on a measurement stack with known seams, and the closing evidence movement begins by exposing them. The foundation layer is the population census: UN DESA's migrant-stock series — the source of the 304-million headline — is "based on data from population censuses," with international migrants "defined as foreign-born" as far as possible and citizenship used "where data on place of birth were not available" [4]. The definitional fallback is not cosmetic: birthplace and citizenship classify different people (the naturalised disappear from one count and not the other; the native-born children of migrants appear in neither), so cross-country comparisons embed classification differences. Origin–destination matrices come from a separate construction (the Sussex Global Migrant Origin Database, built on the 2000 census round), and the HDR's reader's guide warns that such databases "present data on migrant **stocks** — i.e. the total number of migrants both by country of origin and country of destination — and not the annual (or periodic) **flows**," stocks being "the cumulative effect of flows over a much longer period of time" [4]. Even the OECD's immigrant database, compiled from the same census round plus la-

bour-force surveys, uses definitions that "may differ slightly," making direct comparison with UN figures impossible [4].

The labour layer shows the same architecture improving and breaking at once. The ILO's International Labour Migration Statistics (ILMS) database — "the world's largest and most robust repository of national data on international labour migration," covering "more than 70 indicators and 170 countries as of June 2024," mostly on a country-of-birth criterion — feeds the ILO's global estimates, whose fourth edition adopted "a new estimation methodology" with "robust model-based estimation methods to impute missing data" [24]. The gain in coverage is real; so is the cost: estimates for 2013, 2017 and 2019 were revised under the new method and "supersede the results disseminated in the three previous editions, to which they should not be compared" — a series break declared in the text, of the kind that silently corrupts trend claims when ignored [24]. Harmonisation is in progress — revised ILO guidelines "closely aligned with the revised UN recommendations on international migration statistics," expected by mid-2025 — but the present system measures with several rulers [24].

Forced-displacement data rest on a different logic entirely: administration. "Routine registration, which is created to establish a legal or administrative record or to administer entitlements and deliver services, constitutes the main source of refugee data" — counts follow entitlement systems, not enumeration [4]. Where registers do not exist, UNHCR estimates for 27 developed countries rest on recognised asylum recognitions plus assumed naturalisation over ten years, a method whose "most notable challenges… pertain to its underlying assumption that all recognised asylum seekers are indeed refugees and the harmonization of its cut-off period to 10 years" [4]. IDP figures, compiled by IDMC from OCHA, UNHCR and government sources, carry the guide's bluntest warning: "[b]ecause of the difficulty in tracking IDPs, estimates are associated with high levels of uncertainty and should therefore be interpreted with caution" [4].

The blind spots are systematic, and this report has tripped over each: internal migration, the largest movement of all, lacks cross-nationally comparable data — the HDR commissioned a bespoke 24-country census analysis and still cautions that its three sources' definitions differ and "comparisons should be treated with caution" [4]; irregular migrants are by construction undercounted (the doors-merging estimation problem of the counting chapter); stateless populations are undercounted by a factor the agencies themselves flag; and emigration-prevalence series carry confidence bands wide enough, as the hump chapter noted, to leave the sign of the development relationship formally uncertain [2]. The measurement lesson generalises the counting chapter's opening: migration statistics are a patchwork of censuses, registers, surveys and models, each layer with its own definition, vintage and incentive structure — usable, indeed indispensable, provided the seams are carried into the conclusions rather than footnoted away.

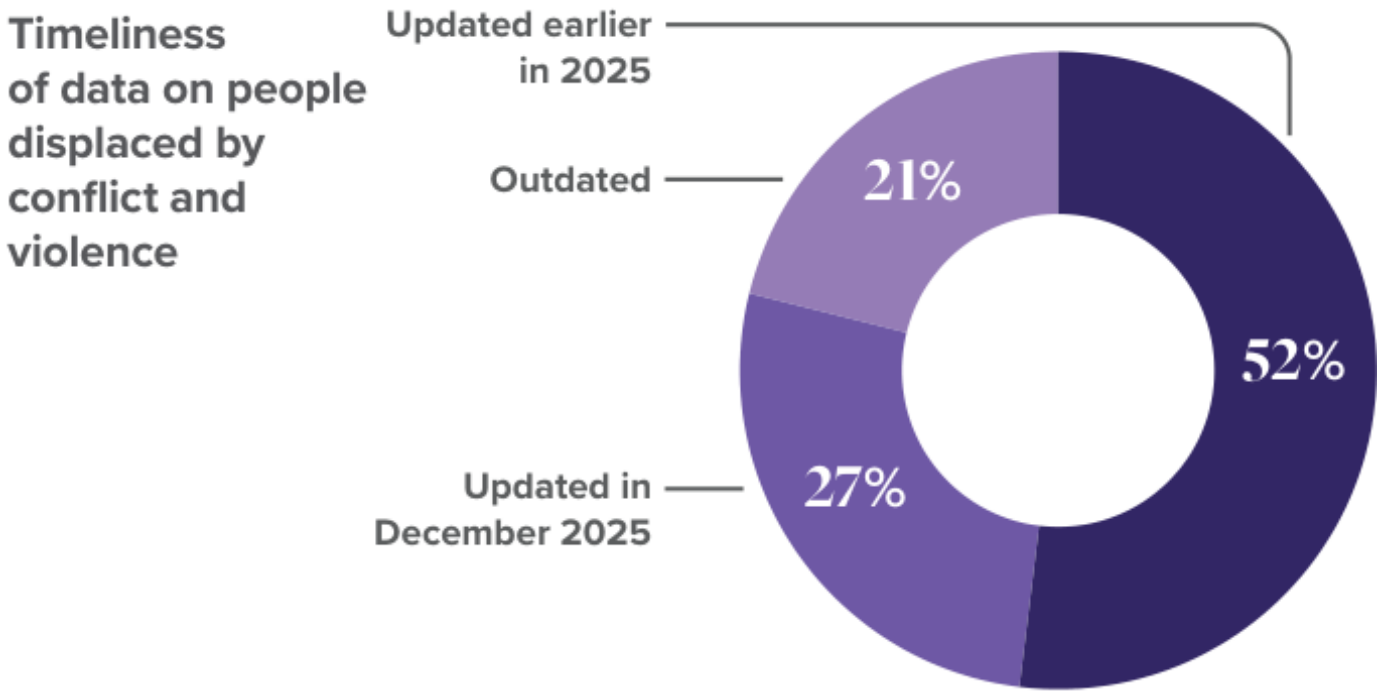


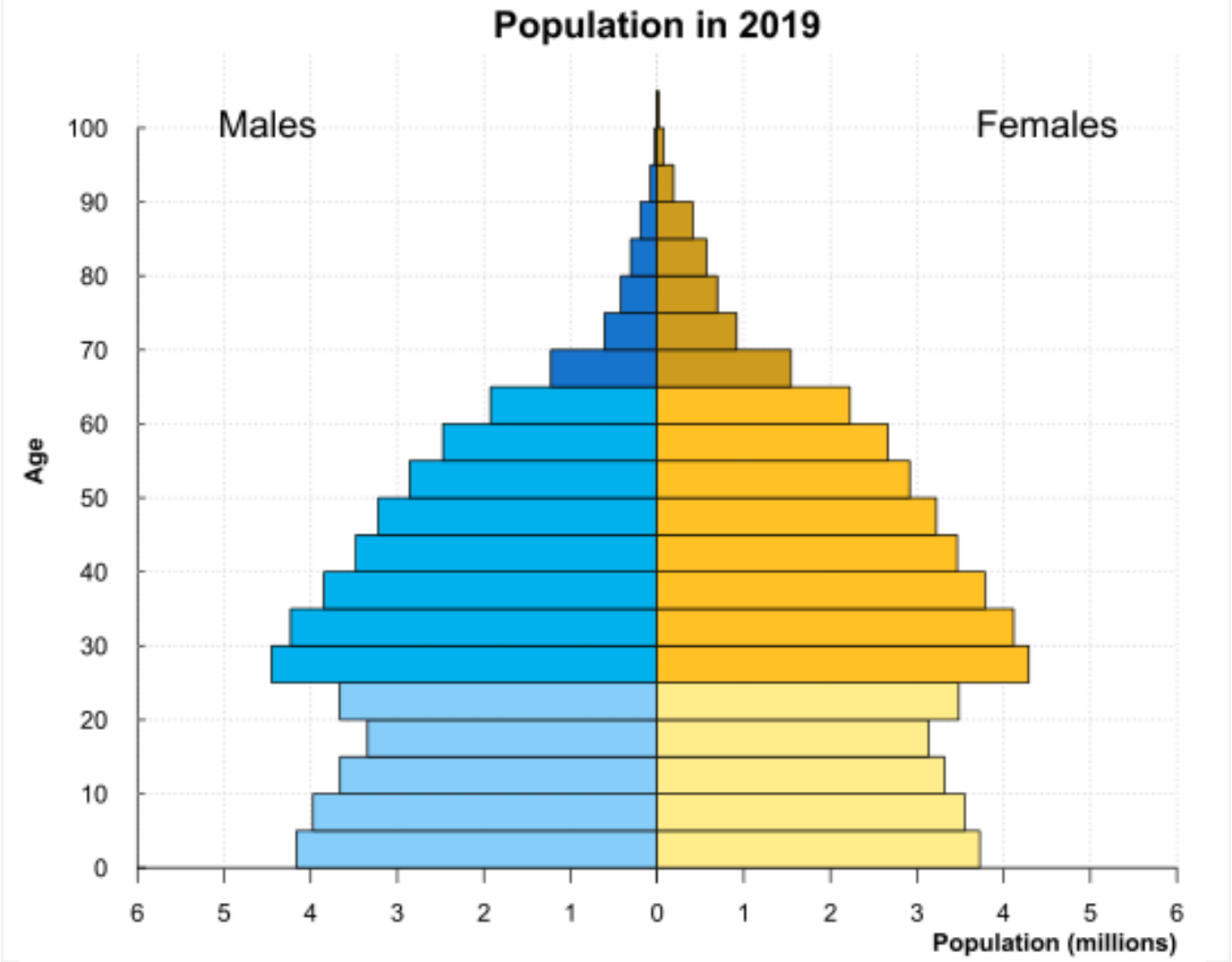
Exhibit. Timeliness of data on people displaced by conflict and violence: 52% updated in December 2025, 27% updated earlier in 2025, 21% outdated (IDMC). Source: S0029.

Forecasting methods and their limits

Migration forecasting inherits demography's machinery and its deepest problem: the further out the projection, the more it is an assumption with arithmetic attached. The UN's World Population Prospects states the general condition plainly: "[l]ong-range population projections are highly uncertain, due in large part to uncertainty around the number of children that will be born," and for below-replacement countries "projecting future fertility levels can be particularly challenging, since there is only limited historical precedent that can be used to inform projections" [10]. The medium scenario's central device for such countries is a modelled fertility rebound — fertility rising gradually to 1.4 births per woman by 2100 (95 per cent uncertainty range 1.2–1.8), "informed by trends from 39 countries that have experienced declines in total fertility below 2 children per woman, followed by a subsequent rebound" — while the constant-fertility alternative leaves 2100 fertility a quarter of a child lower, a reminder that scenario architecture, not data, drives the long-range spread [10].

Methodologically the field has moved from deterministic variants to probabilistic projection. The 2022 WPP revision shifted to single years of age and annual intervals, probabilistic fertility and mortality models, standardised net-migration estimation and crisis-mortality assessment; the 2024 edition made "the projections of net migration... probabilistic for the first time, with the magnitude of past variability in annual net migration rates being incorporated into the uncertainty of the migration projection for each country," enabling analysts "to compare the uncertainty attributable to migration to that associated with future trends in fertility and mortality" [10]. The medium scenario now uses the Bayesian posterior mean rather than the median, improving coherence where distributions are skewed [10]. Around this core sit the report's other forecasting instruments, each with declared conditionality: the SSP/RCP scenario families of the climate-migration models (projections are if-then statements, not predictions — the 216-million figure of the projections chapter is a scenario output, as its own chapter insists), gravity and radiation models calibrated on past flows, agent-based models, and intentions surveys whose link to realised flows has been examined only for "a narrow and specific geography" [2].

Three limits bind everything. **First, the empirical base decays with distance from the rich world.** WPP 2024 rests on 1,910 censuses, but "population data from censuses or registers referring to 2019 or later were available for 114 countries and areas" of 237 (48 per cent, covering 54 per cent of world population); for 100 countries the latest count is from 2009–2018, and for 23 countries "the most recent available census data were from before 2009, that is, more than 15 years ago"; vital registration with at least 90 per cent completeness covered five countries for 2023 — one per cent of deaths worldwide [10]. **Second, migration is the politically discontinuous component.** Fertility and mortality trend smoothly; migration responds to wars, coups, visa regimes and enforcement paradigms — the step changes this report documents (a 2018 scheduling rule flattening a backlog within a quarter; a 2023 rule reversing border flows within months) are invisible to models calibrated on past variability, which is why migration's uncertainty contribution, now measurable, dominates at policy horizons. **Third, reflexivity and horizon**: forecasts alter the policies that alter the flows, and beyond mid-century the scenario spread (fertility rebound or not; SSP pathway; climate trajectory) exceeds any signal — which is why this report's final movement speaks in scenarios to 2226 rather than forecasts, and why the honest output of the forecasting literature is a fan of conditional futures with named assumptions, not a line.


Population in 2019
Males
Females
Age
100
90
80
70
60
50
40
30
20
10
0
6
5
4
3
2
1
0
1
2
3
4
5
6
Population (millions)

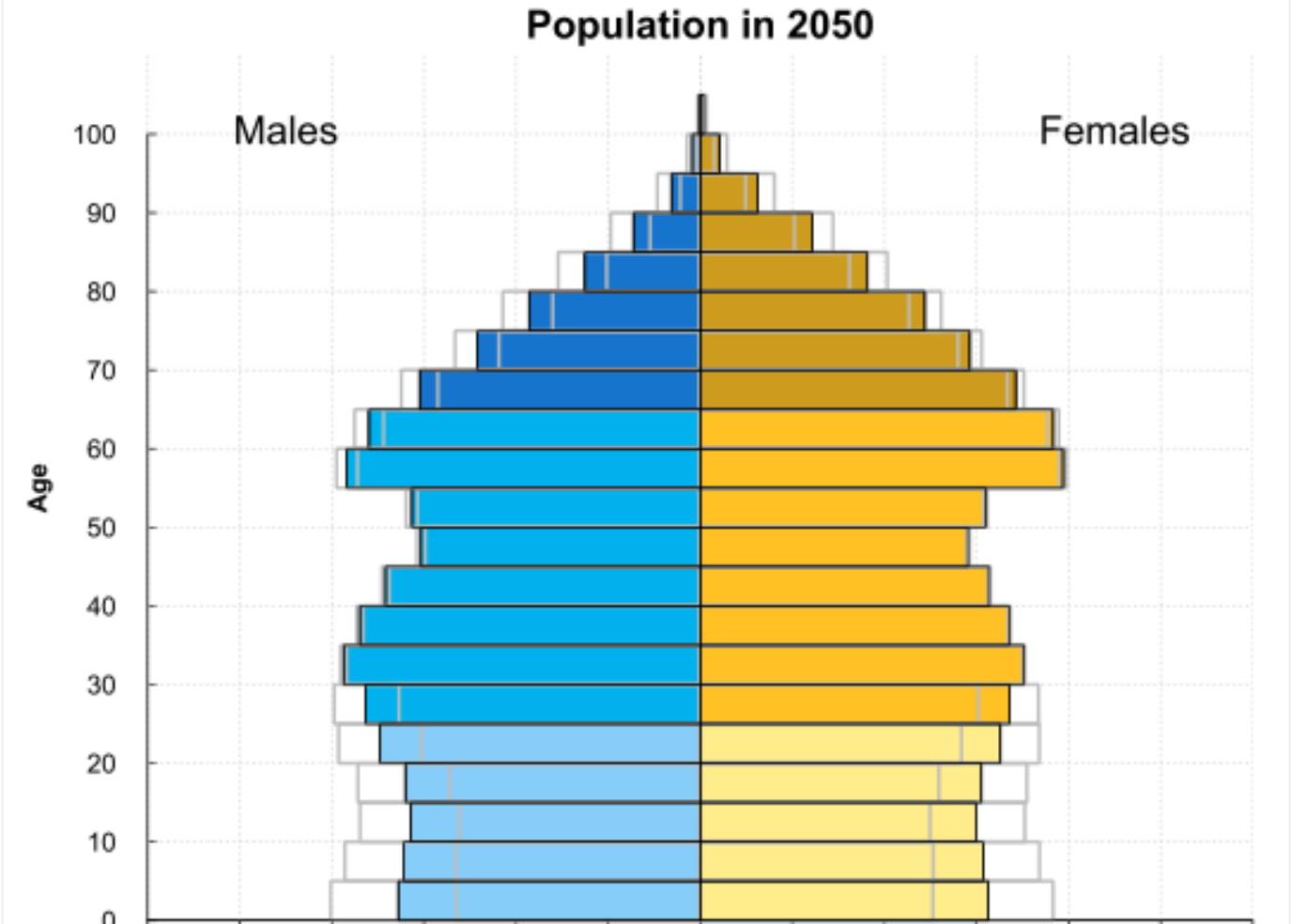

Population in 2050
Males
Females
Age
100
90
80
70
60
50
40
30
20
10
0

Exhibit. Figure 3.12: Vietnam population pyramids, 2019 and 2050 Source: UN DESA (2019b). Source: S0005.

Scenario framework for migration to 2226

Extending the migration outlook across two centuries — to 2226 — forces the analysis out of forecasting and into scenario architecture, and the climate-migration literature supplies the template the rest of the field borrows. The Groundswell programme's framework builds "three plausible scenarios — reflecting different combinations of future climate change impacts and development pathways," each "compared with alternative scenarios with the same development pathways, but no climate change impacts," with projected population differences "assumed to have been the result of in- or out-migration (or dampened population growth)" — and the methodological warning is printed in the framework itself: "those estimates reflect a plausible range of outcomes and should not be seen as precise forecasts" [16]. The three named scenarios span the policy-relevant corners: "Pessimistic (the reference scenario for this report): high global greenhouse gas emissions combined with an unequal development pathway"; "More inclusive development: with equally high emissions, but a more equal development pathway"; and "More climate-friendly: with lower emissions, combined with an unequal development pathway" [16]. Underneath sit the standard climate-economics building blocks — "two Shared Socioeconomic Pathways — SSP2 (moderate development) and SSP4 (unequal development) — and two Representative Concentration Pathways — RCP 2.6 (low emissions) and RCP 8.5 (high emissions)" [16].

Three design choices in this framework generalise to any migration scenario exercise at century scale. First, the counterfactual discipline: climate (or policy) effects are isolated only by differencing against an identical-development no-shock twin, which is what converts a demographic projection into an attributable migration estimate. Second, the output grammar is distributional rather than point-valued — the framework reports, per subregion, total movers, movers as a share of all internal migrants, hotspot maps of amplified and dampened population trends, and net flows across rural livelihood zones, coastal zones and urban areas — because at long horizons the geography of movement is more robust than its volume [16]. Third, aggregation is staged: regional models are combined across report generations — Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia and Latin America from the first Groundswell, the remaining regions in Part 2 — "resulting in global projections of climate migration across the six World Bank regions" [16].

Applied to the full migration system out to 2226, the framework's logic yields scenario axes rather than trajectories: emissions and development inequality (the Groundswell pair), fertility-rebound assumptions of the kind the UN medium scenario builds in, hump dynamics that convert today's poor origins into tomorrow's middle-income senders and then into destinations, and the policy variables — status regimes, externalisation, regularisation cycles — that the governance chapters showed can re-base flows within a single electoral term. The sections that follow populate this framework: first with the long-run global picture it produces, then with the alternative, action-oriented scenario the evidence supports.

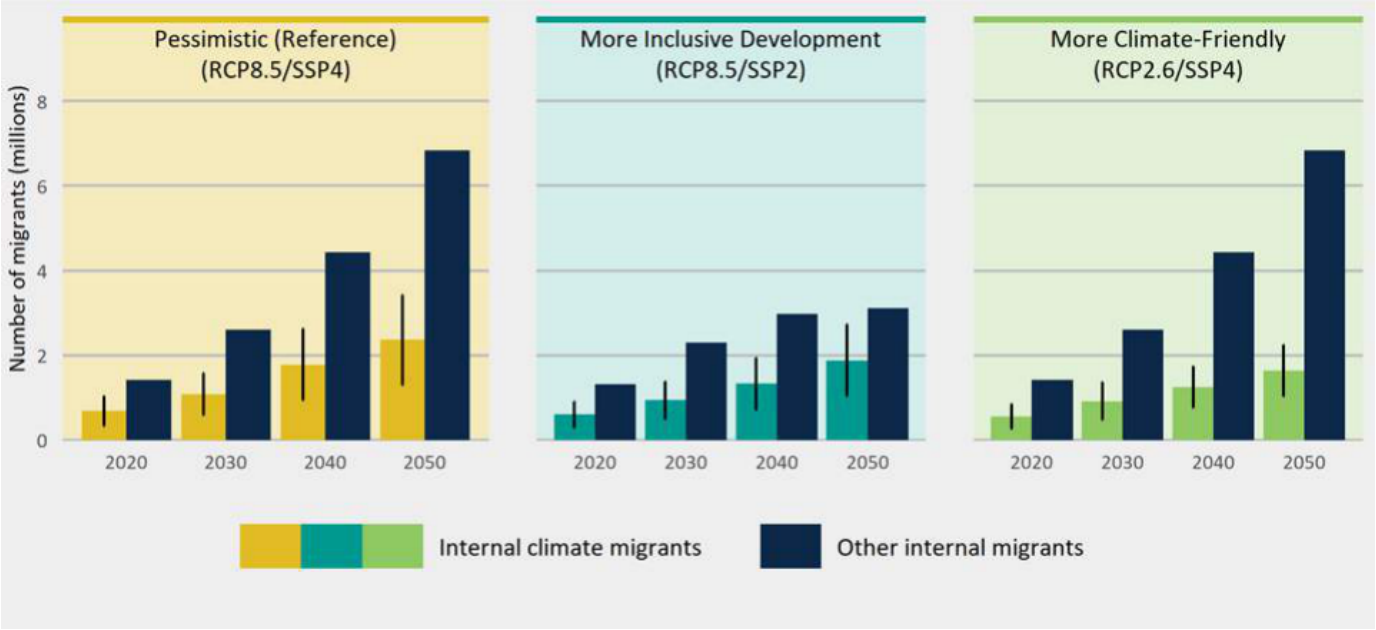


Exhibit. Projected numbers of climate and other internal migrants in Central Asia from 2020 to 2050 are shown under three scenarios, with whiskers marking the 95th percentile confidence interval across the four models. Source: S0005.

Key uncertainties: climate, demography, policy

Three uncertainty families govern everything the scenario framework can say, and they differ in kind. Climate uncertainty is partly reducible and partly structural: "[t]here are inherent uncertainties in the way climate impacts will play out in a given locale and this will affect the magnitude and pattern of climate change-induced movements," with local impacts deviating from "the broader trends identified in a global-scale analysis"; "[o]ver time, as more data become available on climate change and its likely impacts on water availability, crop productivity, and sea level rise, the scenarios and models would need to be updated," and "[i]ncreasing the modeling resolution and improving data inputs to produce more spatially-detailed projections are among the possible future applications" [3]. The known blind spots are specific: the first-generation models cover agriculture and water but not health or coastline change, exclude "short-duration, rapid-onset events" unless they compound into successive shocks, and treat slow- and sudden-onset processes separately even though "[s]low-onset climate change and sudden-onset extreme events may have compounding effects on internal migration" — in a world where "[r]apid-onset events such as floods and cyclones displaced an average of more than 26 million people a year from 2008–15" [3]. The largest single blind spot is non-movement itself: "[i]mmobility — estimated to affect millions of people who are unwilling or unable to leave strained environments — may be one of the most important blind spots in the current debate" [3].

Demographic uncertainty is the slow kind documented in the forecasting chapter: fertility-rebound assumptions that move 2100 populations by hundreds of millions, hump thresholds estimated within wide confidence bands, and development pathways (SSP2 versus SSP4) that change both the capacity to move and the need to. Policy uncertainty is the fast kind, and at two-century horizons it dominates: the governance chapters showed status regimes, externalisation bargains and regularisation cycles re-basing flows within years, none of which any model can schedule; "[c]limate change can be an inhibitor or a driver of cross-border migration, depending on a range of factors," and several projected hotspots sit in transboundary areas where "migration does not necessarily stop at borders" [3].

The methodological response the literature converges on is to plan under deep uncertainty rather than to forecast through it: "[d]ecision-making techniques under deep uncertainty need to be further developed and applied for policy making and development planning," supported by country-level data capacity — climate and migration questions in censuses and surveys are "a cost-effective way to advance understanding" — and by new data sources "including from satellite imagery and mobile phones," with personal-data privacy protected [3]. Robustness, not accuracy, is the attainable virtue at this horizon: policies that perform acceptably across the scenario set — portable status, flexible channels, monitored hotspots, protected immobile populations — dominate policies optimised for any single projected future.

Extending the horizon: what 2050 scenarios imply for 2100 and beyond

The bridge from the modelled century to 2226 rests on a property of the scenario machinery itself: its levers barely diverge before 2050 and separate mainly after it. The Representative Concentration Pathways are trajectories of greenhouse-gas concentrations producing specified radiative forcing in 2100 — 2.6 versus 8.5 watts per square metre — and they are deliberately decoupled from socioeconomic assumptions, since "[m]any different socioeconomic futures or pathways may lead to the same level of radiative forcing" [16]. In RCP2.6, emissions decline from around 2020, forcing peaks by mid-century, and the extended pathway assumes negative emissions by 2070 — a Paris-consistent world holding warming well below 2°C; in RCP8.5, an energy-intensive, fossil-reliant future with little or no climate policy, temperatures rise "by 2.6°–4.8°C by 2100" on the IPCC's AR5 assessment (3–5.5°C on the Groundswell model pair) [16] [3]. Two cautions attach to the high pathway: it sits "at the high end of business-as-usual scenarios, and maybe even unrealistic" given its coal dependence and population assumptions (Hausfather and Peters 2020), yet it "tracks closely to historic emissions" and is defensible to 2050, "even if beyond mid-century there are increasing uncertainties" (Schwalm, Glendon and Duffy 2020) [16]. Climate sensitivity itself — 1.5–4.5°C of warming per doubling of CO_2 — means identical emissions can deliver different climates [16].

Three implications follow for the long horizon. **First, the 2050 numbers are floors, in two senses.** Groundswell describes its own estimates as "a lower-bound estimate of the likely impact of climate change on migration," because they count only slow-onset, internal, modelled-channel movement [3]; and the scenario spread at 2050 understates the spread at 2100, because the emissions pathways' temperature consequences diverge mostly in the second half of the century — the window in which, as the framework chapter noted, slow-onset impacts become "much more pronounced and nonlinear." Extending the horizon therefore widens the fan asymmetrically: the climate-friendly arm stabilises (warming peaks and plateaus), while the pessimistic arm keeps compounding — sea-level commitment,

water stress and heat accumulate with forcing, and each decade's displaced baseline becomes the next decade's starting condition.

Second, demography rotates the map. The UN's rankings of the ten most populous countries are tabulated for 2024, 2054 and 2100 precisely because the ordering churns — the growth-through-2054 countries, concentrated in Sub-Saharan Africa, ascend while the peaked countries recede [10]. By 2100 the demographic axis of the scenario framework is no longer a rich-destination/poor-origin gradient of the twentieth-century kind: it is a world in which the largest populations, the youngest cohorts and the most climate-exposed territories substantially coincide, while the historically dominant destinations are old, shrinking, and — under the governance axis — either competing for the mobile or fortifying against them. Migration's questions invert: less "how do destinations absorb surplus labour" than "which societies can attract and retain people at all," with emigration control by ageing origin states a live possibility the 2050 literature barely contemplates.

Third, beyond 2100 the honest instruments change. The span 2100–2226 is longer than the entire era of modern migration statistics behind us, an era that contained the invention of the passport system, two world wars, decolonisation, the jet age and the internet — regime breaks no 1900 scenario framework would have contained. What survives such spans are mechanisms, not levels: the place premium and its rationing, the migration hump's capability logic, the queue dynamics of adjudication systems, gravity's pull of mass and distance, and the political economy that converts movement pressure into legal flow, irregular flow or trapped immobility in proportions set by governance. The closing chapters therefore use the 2226 scenarios structurally — asking which mechanisms dominate under each axis combination, and which present-day decisions (emissions now, pathway architecture now, data systems now) keep the most futures open — rather than pretending to magnitudes two centuries out. That is the framework's final discipline: the further the horizon, the more the analysis owes the reader mechanisms and decision-relevant branch points, and the less it owes them numbers.

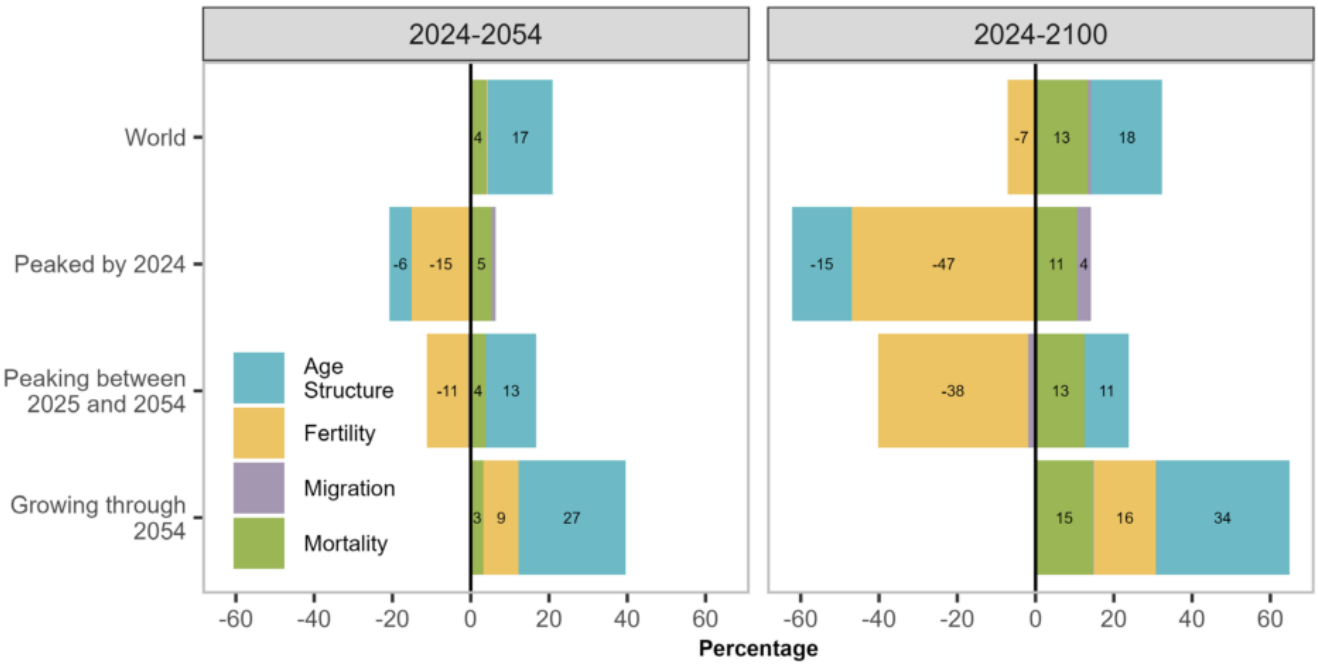


Exhibit. Population growth over the specified period is decomposed into its components, expressed in percentage terms, showing how natural increase and net migration each contribute to total change. Source: S0002.

Findings and recommendations

Key findings

1. Scale is not share. Humanity is more mobile than ever in absolute terms — 304 million international migrants [1], 123.2 million forcibly displaced [7] — yet migrants' share of world population has moved only from 2.6 to about 3.7 per cent in six decades, and internal movers outnumber international ones roughly three to one. The politics of migration is calibrated to the counts; the economics is governed by the shares.

2. The place premium is the system's engine, and rationing is its business model. Identical workers earn four to six times more across a border; because admission is rationed, the gap persists, and intermediaries — recruiters, smugglers, readmission partners, transit states — monetise access to it. Where legal channels close, the premium does not vanish; it is collected by less accountable actors.

3. Development does not brake migration on any policy-relevant timescale. Poverty first traps (involuntary immobility), then finances departure: emigration rises with income until roughly USD 7,000–8,000 per capita, and the declining arm of the hump beyond that point remains contested. Root-causes programmes are justifiable as development and as the price of cooperation, not as near-term flow control.

4. Displacement is protracted, proximate and increasingly urban-internal. Two-thirds of refugees sit in protracted situations; the majority of the displaced are internal; hosting falls overwhelmingly on neighbouring low- and middle-income states; and durable solutions reach a small minority — resettlement met 8 per cent of identified need in 2023 — while return, much of it pressure-induced, carries the bulk of observed resolution.

5. Climate change multiplies movement mainly inside borders, and the modelled figures are floors. Without concrete climate and development action, "just over 143 million people — or around 2.8 percent of the population of these three regions — could be forced to move within their own countries" by 2050 across Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia and Latin America alone, with internal climate migration set to "rise through 2050 and then accelerate unless there are significant cuts in greenhouse gas emissions and robust development action" [3]. Scenario choice moves the totals by up to four-fifths — policy is the largest variable in the projections.

6. Queues, not walls, are the operative border. Asylum backlogs (6.9 million pending at end-2023), processing cascades whose slowest agency sets detention length, and liminal statuses lasting years do more to shape who actually moves and stays than fences do. Systems that decide slowly manufacture both irregularity and the incentives to exploit it; the one demonstrated cure — the 1990s US reform — was speed with credibility.

7. Enforcement relocates pressure; it rarely removes it. Externalisation converts control into a purchasable, renewable commodity and exports legal and humanitarian risk; channelled deterrence works only as well as the lawful channel's capacity; readmission is a negotiation, not an attribute of sovereignty. Every instrument's effect is hydraulic unless paired with pathways and adjudication capacity.

8. Status is the master policy variable. Regularisation at scale (6 million Europeans in a decade; 1.8 million Venezuelans in Colombia), early status security, and first-job speed determine integration outcomes more than programme spending; imposed status insecurity feeds the exploitation floor and the discrimination vicious circle alike.

9. The gains are enormous and unevenly shared. Moving is worth roughly a doubling of income to the mover, large fiscal and innovation gains to destinations, and $656 billion a year to origin households [12] — while costs concentrate on specific workers, places and the movers least able to bear them. Aggregate surplus and distributional grievance are both real; policy that denies either fails.

10. The evidence base is thinner than the decisions it carries. Definitions differ across the flagship series; a leading labour-migration series declares its own editions non-comparable; IDP and stateless counts carry declared high uncertainty; and the research frontier the WDR names — non-economic drivers, climate compounding, demographic-imbalance responses, South–South labour migration, gender dimensions, and longitudinal policy evaluation — maps exactly onto this report's weakest chapters [8]. The findings above are the best current reading, held with the confidence the measurement chapters prescribe.

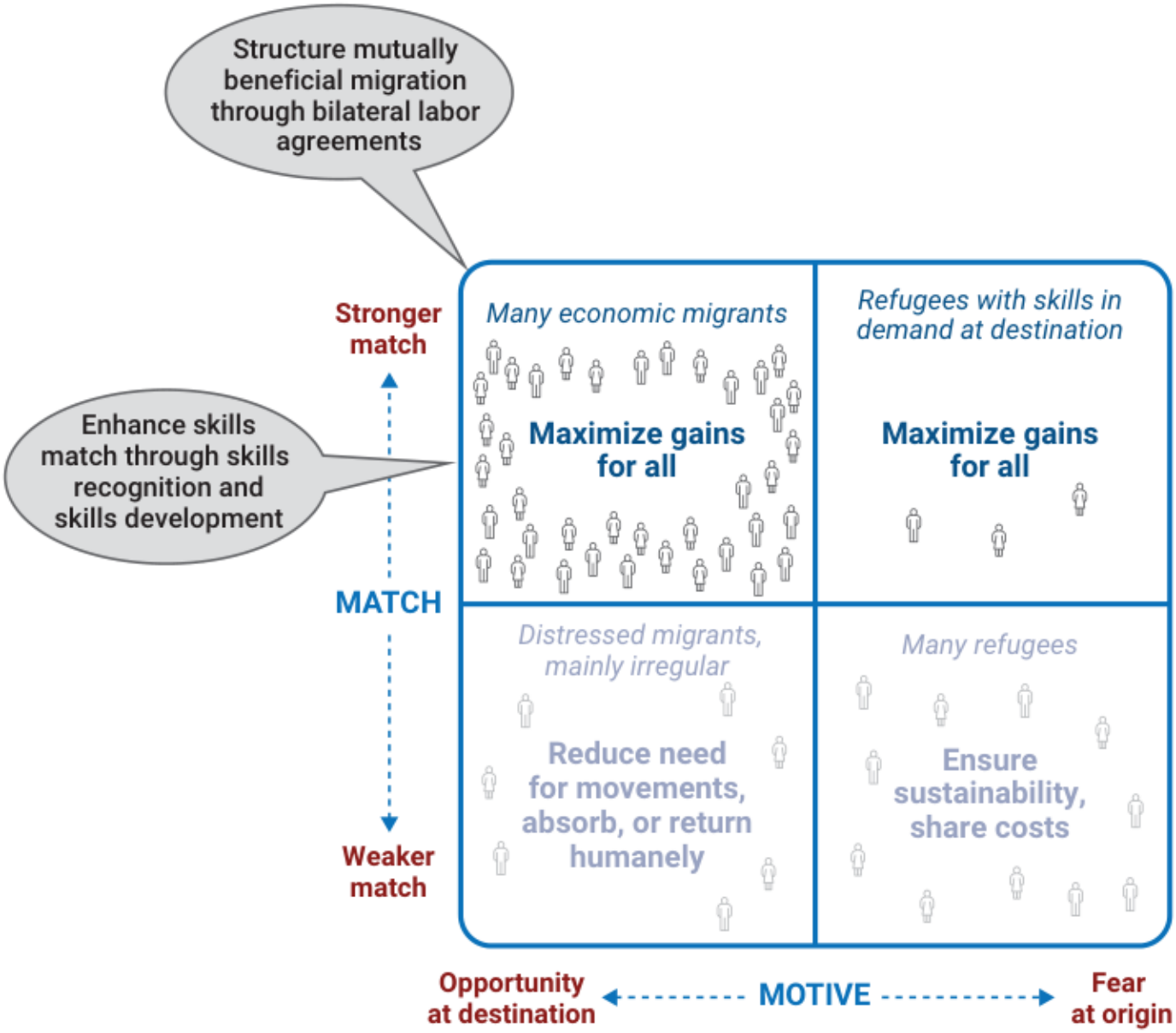


Exhibit. Bilateral cooperation through labour agreements can improve the match between migrants' skills and attributes and destination country needs, structuring migration so that gains are shared more widely. Source: S0010.

Policy recommendations for origin, transit, and destination countries

The recommendations follow the World Development Report's Match–Motive framework, which this report's evidence supports: the **match** between a migrant's skills and destination demand "determines the extent to which migrants, countries of origin, and countries of destination gain from migration," while the **motive** — opportunity-seeking versus a "'well-founded fear' of harm at home" — determines the destination's legal obligations, protection duties arising for the latter [8]. Policy should maximise match where motive is opportunity, and honour protection where motive is fear, rather than applying one instrument to both.

Origin countries: manage emigration as development policy. "In countries with relatively large numbers of current or potential labor emigrants, economic and development strategies should reflect the importance of the potential contribution of emigration to poverty reduction," with strategies built from inputs of "the private sector, labor unions, current and would-be migrants, and the diaspora," and dedicated institutions where needed [8]. The Philippines is the standing example — successive governments have made labour migration integral to development strategy, its 2017–2022 Development Plan aiming "to mainstream migration, facilitate temporary movements, and support migrants' return" [8]. The origin agenda in full: cut remittance costs (facilitating inflows is the cheapest development finance available); expand skills formation aligned with destination demand while mitigating brain drain; facilitate knowledge and technology flows and diaspora investment; protect nationals abroad; and support returnees' labour-market re-entry [8] [8]. Add this report's two riders: do not promise that development will reduce emigration soon (the

hump), and treat involuntary immobility as a welfare problem in its own right — the trapped are a policy population, not a rounding error.

Transit countries: cooperation is not optional. Distressed migrants may pass in days, stay months or years earning the next stage, or settle and move again after failing — each situation calling for different responses [8]. The structural fact is that restrictive destination policies strand people in "'last border transit countries'… sometimes for years," leaving them "to accommodate an often vulnerable population, which comes at a cost"; the challenges of transit and destination states "are inextricably linked, and they cannot be resolved unilaterally" — entry and asylum policies must be made consistent, with costs shared rather than dumped [8]. The January 2023 North American Leaders' Summit illustrates the cooperative form: steps "to encourage migrants to apply for legal status rather than using smugglers," including an online platform giving "streamlined access to legal pathways" and a legal centre in southern Mexico backed by private-sector funding [8]. This report adds: transit cooperation purchased purely as outsourced enforcement reproduces the externalisation pathologies of the enforcement chapters; agreements should bundle protection capacity and pathways, not only returns.

Destination countries: capacity, speed and honest distribution policy. Harness migration deliberately for long-term labour needs — ageing and skills shortages — rather than admitting by crisis [8]. Fund adjudication to the statutory standard (the backlog is a policy choice with a demonstrated cure); keep screening and merits decisions in one competent pair of hands instead of restarting cases between agencies; expand complementary pathways, which already out-scale resettlement; make regularisation earned, criteria-based and routine; and pair admission with the distributional policies — housing, local services, wage-floor enforcement against the irregular labour market — that determine whether residents experience migration as gain or threat. International cost-sharing for refugee hosting is the solidarity counterpart: hosting is a global public good currently financed by the neighbours of crises [8].

Cross-cutting. Reform of any of this "can be supported by data and evidence… financial support that can help mitigate short- or even medium-term costs… and greater engagement by all stakeholders" [8]. Data first: the GCM's first objective is evidence-based policy data, yet "methodologies and databases are inconsistent across countries, making aggregation, integration, and cross-country or even cross-sector comparisons impossible" — harmonise definitions, questions and sampling, strengthen national statistical offices, and govern biometric collection ethically in refugee settings [8]. Finally, use the compacts' forums as the standing venue where commitments and emerging norms are negotiated — with "development considerations… an integral part of these global conversations" [8].

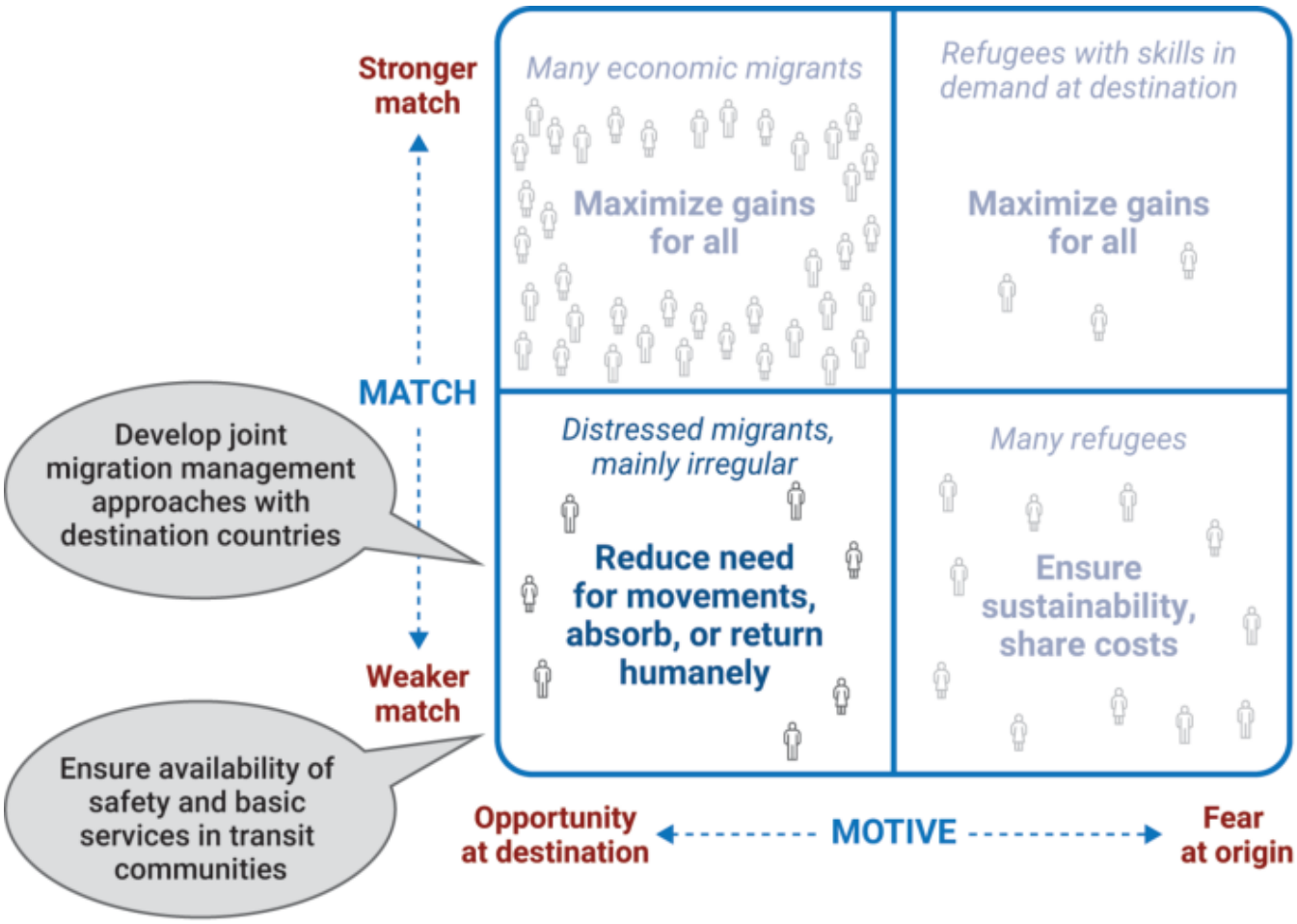


Exhibit. The cooperation required between destination countries and the last border transit countries on a migration corridor to manage distressed movements consistently. Source: S0010.

The way forward

The way forward is a sequence, not a wish list, and its first step is embarrassingly basic: measure. The two compacts were born with asymmetric accountability — the Refugee Compact's paragraph 102 promised indicators of success ahead of the first Global Refugee Forum in 2019, while the Migration Compact, for all its status as a "collective commitment to improving cooperation on international migration," devoted just eight paragraphs (40–47) to implementation "with no information on how its implementation or success would be monitored," leaving the question to the 2022 Review Forum [2]. The Forum's Progress Declaration supplied the repair agenda. Its paragraph 70 requests the Secretary-General to propose "a limited set of indicators… to assist Member States, upon their request, in conducting inclusive reviews of progress" — a workstream the UN Network on Migration has activated, possibly drawing on the SDG 10.7.2 methodology — and, with no official baseline yet set, the 2026 Forum may be where "the international community to build a baseline against which progress will be assessed from 2030" [2]. The same paragraph commissions "a comprehensive strategy for improving disaggregated migration data at the local, national, regional and global levels," and paragraph 76 adds the humanitarian frontier: "actionable recommendations on strengthening cooperation on missing migrants and providing humanitarian assistance to migrants in distress… with the aim of preventing loss of life in transit" [2]. A governance system that cannot yet count its dead reliably is being asked to manage the largest movements in its history; the data strategy is not housekeeping but the precondition for every other claim in this report to be testable.

The second step is to fix the machinery that already exists before inventing new machinery. The asylum case is emblematic: the reforms that would restore the US system to its statutory standard "can be achieved through administrative measures already available to decisionmakers" [22]. The generalisable pattern from the middle chapters is that the highest-yield interventions are unglamorous throughput decisions — single-handed adjudication instead of inter-agency restarts, adjudication funded to the standard, detention governed by downstream capacity, regularisation made routine — each available under current law in most systems, each blocked by politics rather than by knowledge.

The third step is to build the lawful channels at the scale the premium demands, using the pilot discipline the partnership literature prescribes: new labour-mobility organisations such as LaMP plan to "pilot its services in specific corridors before looking to scale up," testing each function across actors and regional contexts, adapting the design to findings, and building the public-goods layer — advocacy grounded in "the demographic need," aimed at "building positive narratives of labor mobility" — in parallel [11]. Pilots that can fail cheaply, in named corridors, with published results: that is how pathways grow from the boutique scale documented in the partnerships chapter toward the volumes the demographic chapters require.

The destination of the sequence is the post-2030 settlement. The Review Forum process runs to a third meeting in 2030, "a crucial year for the United Nations and the international community" and the end of the SDG era, and the trajectory of two decades — incremental progress "since the turn of the century, and its acceleration since 2015" — is "paving the ground for human mobility to become a more central issue for the post-2030 United Nations framework," with the Migration Compact as "an enabling framework for countries to work together on migration governance" through the 2020s and beyond [2]. This report's two-century frame suggests what that centrality will demand. The branch points are this decade's: the emissions path chosen while the pathways still barely diverge; the pathway architecture built while destination labour demand is still rising; the data baseline fixed while the SDG framework still supplies the scaffolding; and the protection norms defended while they are merely strained rather than broken. Beyond those branch points, the mechanisms documented here — the premium, the hump, the queue, the hydraulic border, the vicious circle — will keep operating under every scenario, in 2100 as in 2026. The closing judgement of the governance literature is also this report's: migration requires a truly whole-of-government, whole-of-society approach, and the emerging architecture will benefit people on the move only if it is built around that reality [2]. Two centuries of evidence say people will move; the open question the next two centuries put to this one is whether the architecture will finally be built for the world as it moves, rather than for the world as it was imagined to stay still.



Exhibit. Global migration and mobility after COVID-19 are examined for a post-pandemic rebound, assessing whether movement recovered to its pre-pandemic trajectory or settled onto a different path. Source: S0001.

References

1. Top Statistics on Global Migration and Migrants (2025). Migration Policy Institute. pdf. Source S0011.
2. World Migration Report 2024 (full report). IOM. pdf. Source S0001.
3. Groundswell: Preparing for Internal Climate Migration (2018). World Bank. pdf. Source S0006.
4. Human Development Report 2009: Overcoming Barriers — Human Mobility and Development. UNDP. pdf. Source S0022.
5. Uprooted: The Growing Crisis for Refugee and Migrant Children (2016). UNICEF. pdf. Source S0015.
6. Scaling Fences: Voices of Irregular African Migrants to Europe (2019). UNDP. pdf. Source S0024.

7. Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2024. UNHCR. pdf. Source S0004.
8. World Development Report 2023: Migrants, Refugees, and Societies. World Bank. pdf. Source S0010.
9. Global Estimates of Modern Slavery: Forced Labour and Forced Marriage (2022). ILO / Walk Free / IOM. pdf. Source S0016.
10. World Population Prospects 2024: Summary of Results. UN DESA. pdf. Source S0002.
11. Labor Mobility Partnerships: Expanding Opportunity Globally for the Mobile Workforce. Center for Global Development. pdf. Source S0007.
12. Migration and Development Brief 40: Remittances Slowed in 2023, Expected to Grow Faster in 2024. World Bank / KNOMAD. pdf. Source S0008.
13. International Migrant Stock 2024: Key Facts and Figures. UN DESA. pdf. Source S0009.
14. Lessons Learned from Projects Linking Green-Skilled Training and Migration. Center for Global Development. pdf. Source S0020.
15. AR6 WGII Summary for Policymakers: Climate Change 2022 — Impacts, Adaptation and Vulnerability. IPCC. pdf. Source S0017.
16. Groundswell Part 2: Acting on Internal Climate Migration (2021). World Bank. pdf. Source S0005.
17. Global Report on Internal Displacement 2026 (GRID). IDMC. pdf. Source S0029.
18. Global Trends: Forced Displacement in 2023. UNHCR. pdf. Source S0003.
19. Children on the Move in North Africa and along Key Routes: Trends, Vulnerabilities and Experiences of Migrant Children (2025). UNICEF / IOM. pdf. Source S0028.
20. Competing for Talent: What Role Can Employment- and Skills-Based Mobility Projects Play?. Migration Policy Institute. pdf. Source S0021.
21. Migration Outlook 2024. ICMPD. pdf. Source S0014.
22. The U.S. Asylum System in Crisis: Charting a Way Forward. Migration Policy Institute. pdf. Source S0012.
23. Shifting Realities at the U.S.-Mexico Border: Immigration Enforcement and Control in a Fast-Evolving Landscape (2024). Migration Policy Institute. pdf. Source S0018.
24. Global Estimates on International Migrant Workers: International Migrants in the Labour Force, 4th edition (2024). ILO. pdf. Source S0026.